

"The solution to the problems of the Islamic nations is unity of words, friendship, and cooperation on the path of goodness."

Iran's Supreme Leader
Mojtaba Khamenei

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Fertiliser shock raises poverty risk

US war on Iran could cause a 30% price hike this year

REJAUL KARIM BYRON

The World Bank has warned that delayed fertiliser deliveries could reduce Bangladesh's rice production, raising food prices and pushing more people into poverty.

In a review of $300 million funding for emergency fertiliser imports, the World Bank said the US war on Iran and its fallout could push international fertiliser prices up by 30 percent in 2026, after a 12 percent increase already recorded in the first quarter.

The World Bank gave the loan last month to help 30 lakh small and marginal farmers secure fertiliser on time under the lender's Emergency Support for Food Security Project.

The financing was designed as short-term crisis support for the ongoing Aman and upcoming Boro seasons, not for Bangladesh's long-term fertiliser needs or recurrent subsidies.

Bangladesh uses about 66 lakh tonnes of fertiliser a year, with rice cultivation accounting for roughly 75 percent of the total.

More than 85 percent of the country's fertiliser requirements are met through imports, leaving it exposed to global supply disruptions.

Aman, Boro account for 90% of production	They require 43 lakh tonnes of chemical fertilisers	85% of fertiliser requirements met through imports
Fertiliser supply disruption may push rice prices up	14 lakh people may fall into poverty if rice prices rise 10%	

That dependence is particularly significant because of Bangladesh's links to Middle Eastern suppliers.

Saudi Arabia alone supplied roughly one-third of the country's diammonium phosphate (DAP) in 2025, according to the World Bank.

Three of Bangladesh's seven fertiliser factories are currently shut due to gas shortages, making imports "even more critical", the lender said.

To avert any shortage, the government has approved imports of 4.8 lakh tonnes of various fertilisers over the past two weeks.

The Aman season runs from July to October and Boro from October to April. Together, they account for more than 90 percent of national rice production and require over 43 lakh tonnes of chemical fertiliser.

If fertiliser is not available on time, farmers may reduce its use, with direct effects on yields, the World Bank said.

"Given rice's central role in household consumption, lower production would quickly feed into higher food prices. Poor households are especially exposed because they spend a larger share of their budget on food," it added.

Rice accounts for 22 percent of food consumption expenditure among the bottom 40 percent of households, and a 10 percent rise in rice prices could push an additional 14 lakh people into poverty, the report said.

The risk is particularly acute for small farmers, who make up 92 percent of farm households and operate 65 percent of cultivated land, leaving them with limited capacity to absorb delayed deliveries or higher costs.

SEE PAGE 2 COL 4



PHOTO: RASHED SHUMON

The 24-kilometre Dhaka-Ashulia Elevated Expressway under construction at the Dhaur intersection. Physical progress of the mega project has reached 63.5 percent, with two service lanes from Dhaur to Ashulia Bazar expected to open to traffic later this month. The project cost has risen to Tk 27,046 crore. Once completed, the expressway is expected to significantly reduce congestion for commuters and industrial transport entering the capital from the northern districts. Photo was taken recently.

Gas crisis turns Aug grim

Production suffers, cooking at home stalls, power generation plummets

ASIFUR RAHMAN *and* SUKANTA HALDER

Gas supply in August has fallen to a level not since the early stages of the global coronavirus pandemic, bringing the country to a near standstill as it had back in 2020.

The average daily gas supply fell to 2,235 million cubic feet per day (mmcfd) in August, the lowest level recorded for the month in a decade, according to an analysis of gas-supply data from 2017 to 2026.

The last time the gas supply was lower was back in April 2020, when it averaged 2,020 mmcfd.

Official estimates put current demand at around 3,860 mmcfd, but energy sector officials say the actual demand has already crossed 4,000 mmcfd and has remained at that level for the last two years.

To supplement the declining domestic gas production and meet rising demand, Bangladesh began importing LNG in 2018.

Because of the US-Israel war on Iran, Qatar, one of Bangladesh's major long-term LNG suppliers, is currently not providing its contracted supply, forcing Bangladesh to meet its requirements largely through the spot market.

But spot market procurement has now become increasingly difficult and expensive, adding further pressure to the country's gas supply.

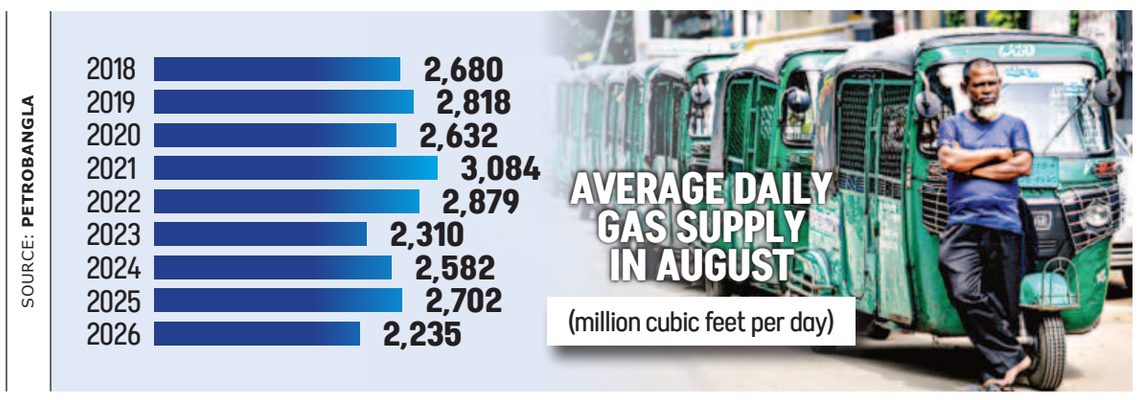
The shortage has quickly spilt over into power generation.

At the height of the crisis this month, the average hourly power generation shortfall reached around 3,000 megawatts, while dozens of gas-fired generating units struggled to obtain adequate fuel.

As of 12:00pm yesterday, the Bangladesh Power Development Board was producing only 12,688 MW against the demand of 16,278 MW.

Power production from gas was around 5,000 MW against an installed capacity of at least 12,000 MW.

SEE PAGE 2 COL 1



MPs lock horns over JS panel chairs

Treasury links committee posts to charter body participation; opposition rejects 'tied deal'

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

A dispute over opposition representation in parliamentary standing committees brought the treasury and opposition benches into a fresh confrontation in the House yesterday.

The ruling party set a condition for giving the opposition chairmanship of standing committees: opposition lawmakers must first agree to participate in the special parliamentary committee on constitutional amendment.

The opposition rejected the condition, insisting that chairmanships be distributed in proportion to their representation in parliament.

They also said they would not join the special committee on constitutional amendment.

Deputy Speaker Kayser Kamal urged both sides to work together in the national interest and suggested "closed-door" discussions between their top leaders if necessary.

There are 50 standing committees, including 39 related to ministries.

Under the Rules of Procedure, all standing committees must be formed within the third session. So far, only 15 committees have been formed in the 13th Parliament, including nine ministry-related ones.

On July 13, parliament formed a 12-member special committee on constitutional amendment, chaired by Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed. The opposition was asked to nominate five members but rejected the committee.

The opposition says it supports constitutional reform under the July charter but objects to the composition of the special committee.

The charter proposes that opposition MPs chair the committees on public accounts, privileges, estimates and public undertakings, and receive ministry-related

SEE PAGE 2 COL 4

Dhaka sees no risk in joining Mecca pact

Says State Minister Humaiun Kobir

UNB, *Dhaka*

Bangladesh sees no risk in joining the Mecca pact, as the country will continue to maintain balanced relations with various international partners, said Humaiun Kobir, state minister-1 for foreign affairs.

"What is the point of worrying about dying before you even live? I mean, if we start worrying about risks before even initiating the process, that becomes a problem," he told reporters yesterday after a meeting with Saudi Ambassador to Bangladesh Abdullah Zafer bin Abiyah at the foreign ministry.

A country like Bangladesh must approach foreign policy and security cooperation in a "very integrated and flexible"

SEE PAGE 8 COL 3



A drone view shows a man walking past damaged buildings and houses covered in mud next to the Likhu River yesterday following deadly flash floods and mudslides in Devighat, Nuwakot district, Nepal.

PHOTO: REUTERS

NEPAL-CHINA FLOODS

Rain, rising rivers hamper rescue ops

Death toll now 797; number of missing over 3,000

AGENCIES

Rescuers in Nepal and China yesterday battled through leg-sucking mud and the threat of rain, rising rivers and a newly formed lake to search for thousands missing after a glacier collapse unleashed a catastrophic mudslide across the Himalayas.

Nepal starts mass burial of unidentified bodies	Rescuers drill debris to reach trapped workers

Authorities said the death toll rose to 797, with 3,048 people missing on both sides of the Nepal-China border after a torrent of ice, rock, mud and debris swept through mountain valleys and rivers on Wednesday, causing widespread devastation.

The Red Cross has estimated that more than 90,000 people are likely to have been affected by the disaster, which China has linked to the effects of climate change.

Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi told his Nepalese

SEE PAGE 2 COL 4

MECCA DEFENCE PACT

Turkey, KSA, Pakistan to hold first meeting today

REUTERS, *Istanbul*

Top officials from Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan will gather in Istanbul today for a first committee meeting under the joint defence accord that they signed this month, a Turkish foreign ministry source said.

The "Mecca Joint Defence Agreement", signed on August 7, brought together Sunni Muslim US allies concerned by the Iran war and regional conflict that has led to Iranian missile fire on Gulf oil exporters.

It is intended to strengthen collective deterrence against any act of aggression and stipulates that an armed attack against any of the three would be regarded as an attack on all, similar to Nato's Article 5 collective defence clause.

Foreign and defence ministers, as well as the chiefs of staff, of the three countries will attend the meeting in Istanbul, the ministry source said.



A farmer applies fertiliser to a paddy field in Debipur village of Khezur Union in Naogaon's Mahadevpur upazila yesterday. Farmers say "shortages" are forcing them to buy fertiliser from the black market at higher prices. PHOTO: AZAHAR UDDIN

'BNP, JCD leaders' held over robbery of gold worth Tk40 lakh

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Police yesterday arrested two men, reportedly a Jatiyatabadi Chhatra Dal leader and a ward-level BNP leader, in connection with the robbery of gold ornaments worth around Tk 40 lakh in the capital's Airport area.

The arrestees are Al-Amin Shanto, 27, secretary of the Airport thana unit of JCD, and Abdur Rauf, 40, president of an organisational ward of Airport thana BNP.

Tareq Mohiuddin, joint convener of Airport thana BNP, confirmed their party positions, saying both were active in party activities.

Mirza Mohammad Tareq Baig, deputy commissioner of DMP's Uttara division, said a robbery case was filed with Airport Police Station against four people.

Two of the accused have been arrested, and 100 grams of gold, out of the 200 grams allegedly robbed, has been recovered, he told The Daily Star.

The other two accused remain absconding.

The case was filed on Saturday by Md Suman, 26, of Raipura in Narsingdi. The other two accused are Ripon, 27, and Rubel, 32.

According to the case statement, Suman's elder brother in Malaysia sent 200 grams of gold ornaments for his sister's wedding. Suman collected half at Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport, while his associate Rohan Chowdhury, 25, received the rest.

Near Balaka Bhaban, the four accused allegedly surrounded them, identified themselves as Awami League and Chhatra League members, assaulted them, and fled with the gold.

A passerby recorded part of the incident on a mobile phone.

Opposition MPs boycott JS panel meeting over rights bills

Move comes 3 days after a walk out from JS when NHRC, enforced disappearance bills were placed

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Opposition lawmakers yesterday boycotted parliamentary standing committee discussions on the enforced disappearance and NHRC bills, three days after walking out of parliament before the same bills were tabled.

In the morning, opposition members of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on the Law Ministry boycotted discussion on the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) Bill, 2026.

In a joint statement, three opposition members of the committee later alleged that the government had unilaterally repealed the National Human Rights Commission Ordinance, 2025, ignoring the views of affected citizens, stakeholders, and domestic and international human rights organisations.

Najibur Rahman, Al Faruq Abdul Latif and Akhter Hossen said the government had promised a stronger and more effective law when repealing the ordinance but had instead placed before parliament a weaker and more limited bill.

They further alleged that the proposed bill did not comply with the Paris Principles, relevant international conventions and declarations, or standards recognised by the Global Alliance of National Human Rights Institutions.

The opposition members also objected to the committee being given only two working days to submit its report, saying the timeframe restricted proper consultation with stakeholders and independent scrutiny of the bill.

Speaking to this newspaper, Najibur Rahman, spokesperson for the Jamaat-e-Islami parliamentary party, said, "We will no longer take part in any kind of further discussion on the bill."

Later in the afternoon, Jamaat-e-Islami MPs Nurul Islam and Abdul Baten walked out of a meeting of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on the Home Ministry before discussion began on the Enforced Disappearance Prevention and Redress Bill, 2026.

However, they had not issued any statement explaining their walkout.

Committee Chairman Zainul Abedin said committee members could place amendments or opinions, offer suggestions, and, if necessary, oppose provisions during the meeting. "That is the responsibility of committee members. But walking out of the meeting does not fall within parliamentary norms."

The committee held detailed discussions on submitting its report on the bill and decided to forward the bill to parliament, according to the press release issued by the Jatiya Sangsad.

Earlier on Thursday, both of these bills were tabled in parliament and sent to the respective parliamentary standing committees for scrutiny. Opposition MPs walked out of the House before the bills were placed.

Opposition Leader Shafiqur Rahman objected to ministers placing bills on a Thursday, traditionally reserved for private members' business, and criticised the government for not convening a constitutional reform council in line with the referendum verdict.

Law Minister Md Asaduzzaman moved the NHRC Bill, while Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed introduced the enforced disappearance bill.

The bills follow debate over legal frameworks introduced during the interim government. Three ordinances relating to the NHRC were repealed during the first session of the 13th parliament, while two ordinances on enforced disappearances lapsed after parliament failed to ratify them within the constitutional timeframe.

The enforced disappearance bill assigns investigations to police officers, usually of sub-inspector rank, while the interim ordinance had empowered the NHRC to investigate such cases.

The NHRC Bill also limits investigations into alleged rights violations by disciplined forces, requiring the commission first to seek a report from the force concerned before making recommendations.

Fertiliser shock raises poverty risk

FROM PAGE 1

Agriculture employed 45 percent of Bangladesh's labour force in 2024 and around two-thirds of workers in the bottom 40 percent of earners.

It is also the largest source of employment for women, many of whom are engaged in subsistence farming and depend directly on agricultural output for household consumption.

"Agricultural growth has historically been an important contributor to poverty reduction, reinforcing the case for protecting production during the current emergency," the World Bank said.

Rice occupies about 72 percent of cultivated land and supplies roughly 67 percent of total caloric intake, while 63 percent of the rural population depends on agriculture for livelihood.

"Although Bangladesh has made major gains in domestic food production, the sector remains vulnerable to slowing productivity growth, climate shocks, and external input disruption," the report said.

A WARNING PLAYING OUT

Although the World Bank warned about the risk involving imports in June, the domestic market has since been hit by volatility despite government data showing adequate stocks.

Farmers in some areas said they were struggling to get supplies. A few days ago, farmers looted a fertiliser dealer's warehouse in the northern region. In parts of the country, they have also blocked roads demanding supplies.

Speaking at an event in Faridpur on August 29, Agriculture Minister Mohammed Aminur Rashid said there is no fertiliser shortage and alleged that a group is systematically trying to create an artificial shortage to drive up prices.

"Action would be taken against retailers if complaints were received that fertiliser could not be obtained without paying more," he said.

The minister said Bangladesh imports roughly 15 lakh tonnes more fertiliser than national demand and maintains adequate safety stocks.

He alleged that some retailers were falsely claiming fertiliser was unavailable while selling it at higher prices and warned of strict action against them.

The combined safety-stock limit for all fertilisers is 17 lakh tonnes, enough for three months, according to agriculture ministry data. Opening stock stood at about 18 lakh tonnes at the start of the financial year and fell to 14 lakh tonnes by August 24.

On August 25, the government formed a cabinet committee headed by Social Welfare Minister AZM Zahid Hossain to assist the agriculture ministry. The committee will review fertiliser distribution and dealer appointments nationwide and advise the ministry accordingly.

'PROBLEM IN DISTRIBUTION'

Agriculture economist M Asaduzzaman said that if government estimates show sufficient stock, the problem must lie in distribution.

"Stock sitting in warehouses serves no purpose unless it reaches farmers," he said, adding that the government must determine why farmers are struggling to obtain fertiliser.

"If farmers are forced to break into dealer warehouses to collect fertiliser or take to the streets in protest, it must be understood that there is a problem somewhere," said Asaduzzaman, former research director of the Bangladesh Institute of Development Studies.

Now, Aman rice is entering its peak growth period, he said. Without proper fertiliser application now, flowering will not occur by mid-October and yields will suffer.

He asked whether anyone had considered the consequences of a 15 to 20 percent drop in Aman yields, particularly since the next major rice harvest, Boro, will not arrive until April.

Past rice crises in Bangladesh were mostly driven by drought or water scarcity during Aman cultivation, Asaduzzaman said.

Fertiliser has now become a bigger constraint than water, as high-yielding and hybrid varieties once largely confined to Boro cultivation now dominate Aman as well, making fertiliser indispensable to output, he added.

Asaduzzaman welcomed the government's formation of the committee but said it must include field-level agriculture officers, dealers and technical experts.

He also called for an immediate investigation into whether local undue influence or irregularities are affecting dealership appointments and allocation procedures and urged prompt, effective action.

Gas crisis turns Aug grim

FROM PAGE 1

Industries have been caught between inadequate gas pressure and frequent power outages, with factories across major industrial belts either cutting production or struggling to operate at sharply reduced capacity.

In Narayanganj, one of the country's major industrial hubs, the gas crisis from the middle of July has taken a severe toll on both production and daily life.

Dyeing factories have been severely affected by the acute gas shortage and the frequent power outages, said Amzad Hossain, president of the Bangladesh Knit Dyeing Owners Association.

The crisis has also affected households in Narayanganj, where more than 70,000 residential customers are connected to the Titas Gas network.

Aklima Rahman, a resident of Sastapur, said she had installed a clay stove in her flat after piped gas supplies dried up.

"Even though there is no gas in the pipeline, we still have to pay the bill. On top of that, we have to buy food from outside twice a day. So, I was forced to bring in a clay stove," she said.

Over in Narsingdi, more than 100 factories were forced to shut down or severely reduce production earlier this month, while some factories resorted to burning wood to operate steam boilers.

However, the situation is not that dire anymore, said Rashidul Hasan Rinto, president of the Narsingdi Chamber of Commerce and Industry.

Gas pressure nevertheless remained uneven among factories. Some facilities that previously received around 15 pounds per square inch (PSI) are now getting about 12 PSI, while others were receiving 14 PSI or continuing to receive 15 PSI.

"It is difficult to describe the situation simply in terms of factory closures because production is fluctuating sharply from day to day -- on some days, production falls to zero, while on other days it may reach only around 20 percent," said Fazlee Shamim Ehsan, executive president of the Bangladesh Knitwear Manufacturers and Exporters Association.

Almost all factories are being affected by the gas crisis to varying degrees, making it difficult to estimate how many could eventually shut down.

"If the government does not take action, many factories could move towards closure," said Ehsan, also the managing director of Fatullah Apparels.

His own factory is operating at around 30 percent capacity because it is not receiving enough fabric from dyeing units.

As a result, he estimated that the factory had lost around 70 percent of its production capacity on average.

The sharp fall in production is creating a serious cost problem because fixed costs remain largely unchanged even when output falls substantially.

"At such a low level of production, it is no longer economically viable," he said.

The crisis therefore poses several risks to the export-oriented apparel sector, including order cancellations, demands for discounts and a loss of credibility among international buyers.

Production in areas experiencing gas shortages had fallen by up to 50 percent, said Md Shehab Udduza Chowdhury, vice-president of the Bangladesh Garment Manufacturers and Exporters Association.

For BGMEA members, a 50 percent fall in production can result in a 50 percent increase in production costs, pushing an operation into losses.

Despite the disruption, no incidents of workers or employees being laid off because of the gas crisis had been reported so far, he added.

Businesses are reluctant to formally declare factories closed because of concerns about whether banks would continue to finance them and whether Titas Gas would restore supplies in the future, said Mohammed Amirul Haque, president of the Chittagong Chamber of Commerce and Industry.

The disruption is nevertheless increasing the cost of doing business, said Haque, also the MD of Premier Cement.

CNG stations have also struggled to maintain supplies, leading to long queues and disruptions for transport users.

[Our Correspondents in Narayanganj, Gazipur and Narsingdi contributed to the report]

Rain, rising rivers hamper rescue ops

FROM PAGE 1

counterpart during a Saturday telephone call that the mudslide was their "most severe cross-border disaster" in recent years and that rescue operations had risen to an unprecedented level of difficulty and complexity, state broadcaster CCTV reported.

Nepal's disaster authority said 781 people had died, 2,502 remained missing and 7,514 had been rescued. On the Chinese side, authorities said 16 people were killed in Gyirong County and 546 were missing.

Beijing said 261 foreign nationals from 23 countries were unaccounted for in Tibet, near a key border crossing with Nepal. The scale of the disaster has complicated rescue efforts across the rugged Himalayan terrain.

Local police in Nepal told Reuters that residents and rescue workers had moved to higher ground after the Trishuli River's water levels rose in recent hours following fresh rainfall, raising fears of additional flooding.

Rescue operations have been suspended several times since Friday because of bad weather and concerns that a lake formed across the Nepal-China border by the disaster could trigger fresh flooding after it began overflowing into Nepal's Lhende Khola and Trishuli Rivers.

The United States said Saturday it was providing $3.6 million in humanitarian aid to Nepal.

Days after desperate relatives moved between hospitals, morgues and relief centres searching for loved ones, authorities in Nepal began mass burials of hundreds of unidentified victims whose bodies had started to decompose.

Authorities are photographing the bodies, collecting DNA samples and recording identifying details in the hope that families may still be able to identify relatives after burial.

Rescue efforts have become more focused on hundreds of people believed to be trapped inside tunnels at hydropower plants damaged by the floods. A joint team of experts used drilling machines, excavators and hydraulic cutters to reach the crown head of the tunnel.

Rescuers entered the tunnel through the opening after drilling through the crown section, according to Prime Minister Balendra Shah's secretariat. However, there was no response when the rescue team called out.

About 85 Americans remain missing in the disaster, the State Department said yesterday. The US figure is just a small fraction of the more than 3,000 people that remain missing after the disaster.

MPs lock horns over JS panel chairs

FROM PAGE 1

chairmanships in proportion to their parliamentary strength.

Yesterday, Chief Whip Nurul Islam Moni moved for the formation and reconstitution of the standing committees.

Referring to a telephone conversation with Deputy Leader of the Opposition Syed Abdullah Mohammed Taher, Nurul said the government had earlier asked the opposition to submit names for the special constitutional amendment committee, but they had not done so.

Taher, however, said Nurul had not mentioned that joining the constitutional amendment committee was linked to committee chairmanships.

"One issue cannot be related to another," Taher said.

He also denied saying that the opposition would nominate members for the special committee.

Taher said there was consensus that membership and chairmanships of parliamentary committees would be distributed in proportion to parties' representation in the Jatiya Sangsad.

Under that formula, the opposition should get about 26 percent of committee memberships and chairmanships, he said.

"We are getting around 26 percent of the member posts of standing committees, but only one chairman position," Taher said. "None of the ministry-related committees have opposition chairmen."

In reply, Nurul said opposition MPs had not previously been given committee chairmanships, except when Ziaur Rahman made the Public Accounts Committee chairmanship available to the opposition.

"Already one committee has been given to the opposition. We cannot give more," he said, adding that if the opposition participated in the constitutional amendment process, it would get chairmanships as demanded.

Taher again took the floor and reiterated that the opposition would not participate in the government's constitutional amendment committee.

"We believe forcing us to join a committee by imposing conditions is not right. We also believe we are entitled to 26 percent of chairmanships," he said.

Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed then said the ruling party had offered the Deputy Speaker's post to the opposition in line with the July charter, but the opposition had rejected it.

"According to the consensus commission discussions, opposition MPs will get chairmanship of ministry-related committees proportionate to their seats. But for that, the July charter must be implemented and the constitution amended," Salahuddin said.

"We will simultaneously begin implementing the July charter. Then you will distribute chairmanships accordingly. This is a very valid argument," he said, urging the opposition to join the constitutional amendment committee.

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No more 'Aynaghar' in Bangladesh

Says president



UNB, *Dhaka*

President Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir yesterday pledged to ensure justice for victims of enforced disappearances, saying Bangladesh would never again allow "Aynaghar" or secret detention centres to exist.

"Let me state clearly as the president of Bangladesh: there will be no more 'Aynaghar' in this independent Bangladesh. No mother will have to shed tears waiting for her child, and no wife will have to wait for her husband," he said.

Speaking at a discussion marking the International Day of the Victims of Enforced Disappearances 2026 at the Bangladesh-China Friendship Conference Centre in Dhaka, he said all those involved in enforced disappearances would be brought to justice and face the highest punishment under the law.

SEE PAGE 4 COL 2



A traffic officer redirects battery-powered auto-rickshaws away from Mirpur Road at Shyamoli's Ring Road in Dhaka yesterday. The move comes amid growing protests over reckless driving and life-threatening accidents involving the vehicles, as the government seeks to restrict their movement and bring discipline to the roads.

PHOTO: PRABIR DAS

Dengue control a top priority

Says LGRD minister

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

The government is giving top priority to preventing the spread of dengue and other mosquito-borne diseases, said LGRD Minister Abdul Moyeen Khan at a meeting at the secretariat yesterday.

The remarks came as the country recorded 1,097 dengue cases, the highest daily caseload so far, and three deaths in a single day, according to health authorities.



AT A GLANCE

- 1,097 new cases
- 3 fresh deaths
- 34,683 hospitalisations
- 93 total deaths

The DGHS said at least 93 people had died of dengue and 34,683 others had been hospitalised as of yesterday.

Moyeen said efforts were under way not only to destroy mosquito breeding grounds but also to strengthen research and technical capacity to improve the effectiveness of mosquito-control insecticides.

He said mosquito control in large and densely populated areas such as Dhaka North, Dhaka South and Gazipur posed various challenges. Despite limited resources, city corporations were making every effort to control mosquitoes, he added.

BLAST flags concerns over NHRC bill

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Bangladesh Legal Aid and Services Trust (BLAST) yesterday sent a set of recommendations on the draft National Human Rights Commission Act, 2026, to the parliamentary standing committee on the ministry of law, justice and parliamentary affairs, calling for measures to ensure an effective, independent and impartial NHRC.

In a review of the NHRC Bill 2026, approved by the cabinet on August 10, BLAST welcomed several improvements but called for substantial amendments before the legislation is enacted.

It said the proposed law still falls short of ensuring an independent, impartial and effective rights watchdog.

It raised concerns over the composition of the commission and the selection committee, as well as the NHRC's administrative and financial autonomy, investigative powers and remedies for rights violations.

Under the bill, the commission will have a chairperson and four commissioners, with at least one woman.

BLAST said the provision represents a setback from the 2025 ordinance, which required two women commissioners, and criticised the absence of mandatory representation of ethnic minorities and other marginalised communities.

The most serious concern, according to BLAST, is Clause 19, which restricts the commission's ability to independently investigate allegations against disciplined forces, including police, RAB, intelligence agencies and the armed forces.

Under the Bill, the commission must initially seek a report from the force concerned before proceeding further. BLAST said such delays could frustrate investigations into enforced disappearances, torture, custodial deaths and arbitrary detention.

ENFORCED DISAPPEARANCES

Enact strong, victim-friendly laws: speakers

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

The National Committee for Observing the International Day of the Victims of Enforced Disappearances has demanded a strong, victim-friendly law and an independent mechanism to investigate allegations of enforced disappearance.

It made the demands during a march in the capital yesterday. The march started around 3:45pm at Banglamotor and ended in front of Jatiya Sangsad. Brief rallies were held at both ends.

Top leaders of the Jamaat-e-Islami-led 11-party alliance joined the programme, along with people who were subjected to enforced disappearance during the Awami League government.

A delegation later submitted a 14-point memorandum to the Speaker. It was led by Hasinur Rahman, a former army officer and joint convener of the committee, who was himself a victim of enforced disappearance.

Speaking to reporters after submitting the memorandum, Hasinur said, "We went to the Speaker with great expectations. We are satisfied. We informed him of all our points. He listened carefully and did not disagree with us."

Criticising provisions of the proposed law, Hasinur said they could make it difficult for families to establish that their relatives had been subjected to enforced disappearance.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- Accountability regardless of rank
- Review of cases from past 15 years
- Protection, rehabilitation for survivors
- Compensation for victim families

Among those taking part were Jamaat Secretary General Mia Golam Porwar, Assistant Secretary General Hamidur Rahman Azad, former BNP leader Major (retd) Akhtaruzzaman, Bangladesh Khelafat Majlis Secretary General Maulana Jalaluddin Ahmad and JAGPA Vice-President Rashed Pradhan.

At the rally in front of parliament, Dhaka-14 MP Mir Ahmad Bin Quasem, who was also a victim of enforced disappearance, said, "Allah has given me a second life. No one's rights should ever again be curtailed on the soil of Bangladesh. Enforced disappearances must never return."

Speakers also included Rokeya Begum, mother of July uprising martyr Jabir Ibrahim, and Sirajganj-4 MP Maulana Rafiqul Islam Khan, also a reserved-seat lawmaker.

In its memorandum, the committee demanded a law consistent with international human rights standards, an independent investigation mechanism free from the control of law enforcement and security agencies, and accountability regardless of political identity, rank or state authority.



Battery rickshaws to be banned on main roads

Says Shahe Alam



UNB, *Dhaka*

Battery-run rickshaws will not be allowed to operate on Dhaka's main roads, while registered e-rickshaws carrying up to four passengers will be permitted to run on internal roads, State Minister for LGRD Mir Shahe Alam said yesterday.

The policy for bringing battery-run rickshaws and e-rickshaws under a regulatory framework is at the final stage and will soon be sent to the law ministry for vetting, he told reporters after a meeting between Malaysian High Commissioner Mohd Shuhada Othman and LGRD minister Abdul Moyeen Khan at the secretariat.

"Once it comes back after vetting, we will issue it as quickly as possible," he said.

The proposed policy will make certification from engineering universities, automobile departments of government polytechnic institutes at the district level, as well as a traffic department fitness certificate mandatory for registration of e-rickshaws, which will be issued by city corporations and municipalities, he also said.



A boy uses a handheld fan for relief from the scorching midday heat while returning home from school in the capital's Banglamotor area yesterday.

PHOTO: PRABIR DAS

Three sustain bullet wounds in Dhaka

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Three people were injured in gunfire at Munsirtek in the capital's Swamibagh area yesterday evening.

Mohammad Siam, 22, Alamgir Hossain, 32, and Asha Akter, 28, were taken to Dhaka Medical College Hospital, said Mohammad Faruk, in-charge of the DMCH police outpost.

Siam, a resident of Jatrabari who works at a local hotel, said, "Suddenly, a fight broke out on the road. I was inside the shop and was pulling down the shutter when a bullet hit my right shoulder."

Alamgir's wife, Jannati Akter, said her husband runs a tea stall. "My husband was inside his tea stall when a fight and gunfire broke out in front of it. He was shot in the middle of his forehead."

Asha, a homemaker, said she was caught in the clash while walking along the road. "A bullet hit my right thigh."



Former IGP Enamul Haque passes away

STAFF CORRESPONDENT



Former inspector general of police (IGP) M Enamul Haque died at a hospital in Dhaka around 5:30am yesterday. He was 88.

He is survived by his wife, two sons and a daughter, according to a Police Headquarters statement.

His namaz-e-janaza was held after the Zohr prayers at the SI Shiru Mia Milonayatan at Rajarbagh Police Lines. Senior police officials, his relatives and former colleagues attended the funeral.

After the prayers, Additional IGP (Administration) AKM Awlad Hossain placed a wreath on the coffin on behalf of IGP Md Ali Hossain Fakir.

Dr Enamul served as IGP from October 1991 to July 1992 and as a member of the Law Commission from 2004 to 2007.

The IGP and Bangladesh Police Service Association expressed deep shock at his death and conveyed condolences to the bereaved family.

Measles death toll rises to 967

Four more children die of symptoms

UNB, *Dhaka*

Four children died with measles-like symptoms in the 24 hours till 8:00am yesterday, raising the country's combined number of confirmed and suspected measles-related deaths to 967 this year.

The DGHS has classified all four latest fatalities as suspected measles deaths.

With these, the total number of suspected measles deaths has reached 868, while confirmed deaths from measles remained at 99.

A total of 1,151 new suspected measles cases were reported during the 24-hour period, bringing the cumulative number of suspected cases nationwide to 1,56,829.

Meanwhile, 365 new confirmed measles cases were recorded, bringing the total number of laboratory-confirmed infections to 19,218.



Tourists and geo-bags stand alongside craters left by coastal erosion along Kuakata beach. *Inset*, long stretches of the beach are marked by erosion-carved cliffs, piles of geo-bags and exposed sand. The photos were taken recently.

PHOTO: STAR

Erosion threatens Kuakata beach

High tides, rough seas put embankment and key establishments at risk

SOHRAB HOSSAIN, *Patuakhali*

Persistent rainfall, high tides and rough seas in recent times have intensified coastal erosion along Kuakata beach, threatening key public and religious establishments as well as the town's coastal protection embankment.

During a recent visit, this correspondent saw large sections of the beach being washed away by powerful waves, leaving deep craters along the battered shoreline. Concrete blocks installed along the embankment were seen displaced, with cracks developing beneath them, raising fresh concerns over the embankment's stability.

The most severe damage was observed along the embankment stretching from Kuakata Chourasta to Lembur Bon, particularly near Sunset Point.

Locals said sand has already been washed away from in front of the Jame Mosque near the beach, located east of Zero Point. Visible signs of erosion have also appeared in front of the Sree Sree Radha-Krishna Temple, while the ground beneath the Tourist Police outpost has started to collapse, raising safety concerns.

Md Russell Rumman, a local businessman, said tidal waves now reach much farther inland than they did only a few months ago.

"Areas where tourists used to walk comfortably are now filled with large craters. Water is reaching dangerously close to the mosque,



temple and police outpost. Unless prompt measures are taken, the ongoing erosion could seriously disrupt tourism, local businesses and livelihoods," he added.

Engineer Nihar Ranjan Mondal, general secretary of the Sree Sree Radha-Krishna Temple Pilgrims' Service Centre, said the Bangladesh Water Development Board had been placing geo-bags every monsoon over the past five years to temporarily control erosion, but they had failed to provide a lasting solution.

"The same problem recurs every year. A permanent coastal protection project is essential to save Kuakata," he said.

Contacted, Md Shah Alam, BWDB executive engineer in Kalapara, said a Tk 759-crore project to protect an 11.2-km stretch of Kuakata beach is awaiting government approval.

"Once approved, the project will use modern engineering solutions to preserve the beach, prevent erosion and ensure the long-term sustainability of the tourism area. Meanwhile, emergency repair and temporary protection works are continuing in the damaged sections," he said.

ABM Mosharraf Hossain, lawmaker for Patuakhali-4 (Kalapara-Rangabali), said a long-term development plan is being implemented to prevent erosion along Kuakata beach, restore its natural beauty, and develop modern tourism infrastructure and facilities, with the relevant ministries working in coordination.

No more 'Aynaghar' in Bangladesh

FROM PAGE 3

But the state's responsibility, he said, would not end with punishing the perpetrators.

"The state must also assume responsibility for the dignity, social security, healthcare, education, livelihoods and rehabilitation of families who have endured years of uncertainty, financial hardship and mental suffering while waiting for their loved ones," he said.

"Enforced disappearance does not merely take away a person. It takes away the happiness, peace, dreams and economic and social security of their loved ones," he said.

Referring to the past 15 years, the president said enforced disappearances, secret detention centres and killings had been used to silence those who protested against injustice, expressed dissent or demanded democratic rights.

The president said the culture of enforced disappearances and killings had created an atmosphere of fear and terror in a country liberated in 1971 through the sacrifices of freedom fighters who fought for democracy, equality, freedom of expression and human dignity.

Calling it a painful and shameful chapter in the country's history, he said Bangladesh must now pursue justice rather than revenge.

"Now, instead of revenge, we must ensure redress and bring the actual perpetrators under the law," he said.

Referring to the final report of the Commission of Inquiry on Enforced Disappearances, Fakhrul said the commission had identified 1,569 incidents of enforced disappearance, with 287 victims found to have gone missing and been killed.

The report, he said, showed an increase in enforced disappearances before elections and the targeted abduction and secret killing of political opponents, demonstrating how state power had been misused for partisan and personal interests.

He said the Enforced Disappearance Prevention and Remedy Bill, 2026 had been placed before Parliament to protect victims and their families and permanently prohibit enforced disappearance.

Fakhrul said Bangladesh must become a country where political differences exist without political vengeance, freedom of expression exists without a culture of fear, and law enforcement never becomes a means of violating human rights and justice.

"State power will exist, but that power will remain under the control of the Constitution and the law," he said.

The president called on all to work together to establish a Bangladesh where democracy, human rights, equality and dignity form the foundation of the state; good governance guides its administration; accountability and freedom of expression strengthen democracy; and justice becomes the right of every citizen.

PRAYER TIMING
AUGUST 31

	Fazr	Zohr	Asr	Maghrib	Esha
AZAN	4-30	12-45	4-45	6-23	7-45
JAMAAT	5-05	1-15	5-00	6-26	8-15

SOURCE: ISLAMIC FOUNDATION

Malaysia to hire 200,000 Bangladeshi workers in six months

Says Shahe Alam

BSS, *Dhaka*

State Minister for LGRD and Cooperatives Mir Shahe Alam yesterday said Malaysia will hire around 200,000 workers from Bangladesh in the next six months.

The recruitment process will be implemented through various agencies in the country, he said.

He also said preparations are underway to invest about US $2 billion in electric vehicles, solar panels, renewable energy, and halal food sectors in Bangladesh.

All these processes will start soon, Shahe Alam told reporters after Malaysian High Commissioner to Bangladesh Mohd Shuhada Othman called on LGRD Minister Abdul Moyeen Khan at the Secretariat.

The state minister said, "They (Malaysia) will hire about 200,000 workers. Of them, they will hire 10,000 workers free of cost."

Shahe Alam said the manpower that will be exported from Bangladesh will start in phases from the end of September, and the process will be completed within the next six months.

He said the issues of Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's visit to Malaysia were discussed in the meeting.

Talks were held to further advance the friendly relations between the two countries, he said.

HSBC announces Tk 10 crore aid for Ctg flood victims



The project launching cerenomy at Chattogram Circuit House yesterday.

PHOTO: COURTESY

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

HSBC Bangladesh has announced Tk 10 crore in humanitarian assistance for the rehabilitation and sustainable recovery of families affected by the recent floods in Chattogram division.

The rehabilitation programme was formally launched at an event held at Chattogram Circuit House yesterday.

The funds will be used to rebuild damaged homes, restore livelihoods, repair educational institutions, and improve access to safe drinking water and sanitation facilities.

Finance and Planning Minister Amir Khosru Mahmud Chowdhury inaugurated the initiative as the chief guest.

Bangladesh Bank Director Sworup Kumar Chowdhury, Chattogram Deputy Commissioner and District Magistrate Mohammad Zahidul Islam Mia, HSBC Bangladesh Chief Executive Officer Md Mahbub Ur Rahman, and Md Liaquat Ali, director of BRAC's Disaster Risk Management Programme and Climate and Environmental Innovation Programme, also spoke at the event.

Kishoreganj road crash kills three

UNB, *Kishoreganj*

Three people were killed and three others injured as a covered van hit a CNG-run auto-rickshaw coming from the opposite direction on the Kishoreganj-Bhairab Highway in Katiadi upazila of Kishoreganj yesterday.

The deceased were Rabeya Akter, 45; Jaramoni Akter, 10, of Ajmiriganj upazila of Habiganj; and Milon Mia, of Tarail upazila in Kishoreganj.

The accident occurred at Tebhaga area around 3:00pm, leaving six people injured, said Rafiqul Islam, officer-in-charge of Katiadi Police Station.

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3. **Construction and other related works at the proposed premises of Uttara Bank PLC. Dharkhar Branch, Brahmanbaria.**
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Please visit www.uttarabank-bd.com/home/tender for details.

General Manager

Government of The People's Republic of Bangladesh
Office of the Project Director
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River Research Institute, 72 Green Road, Dhaka
Phone: +880-2-58155538 Fax: 0631-63065 Web Site: www.rri.gov.bd

Memo No.-RRI/SMR Project/2026/57 Date: 30/08/2026

e-Tender Notice

This is to notify all concern that the following tenders are invited in the national e-GP portal:

Sl. No.	Tender ID No.	Last Selling Date	Opening Date
1	1323974	08/09/2026	09/09/2026

This is an online Tender, where only e-Tender will be accepted in the national e-GP portal and no offline/hard copies will be accepted. To submit e-Tender, registration in the national e-GP portal (http:/www.eprocure.gov.bd) is required. Further information and guidelines are available in the national e-GP system portal and from e-GP helpdesk (helpdesk@eprocure.gov.bd).

30.08.2026
(Dr. Moniruzzaman Khan Eusufzai)
Chief Scientific Officer & Project Director
pd_smrproject@rri.gov.bd

GD-2067

AHSANULLAH UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY
141-142 Love Road, Tejgaon Industrial Area, Dhaka-1208.
Phone: 02 8870422 (Ext.-201) Web: www.aust.edu
Ref. No: AUST/OTM/CNT, SoB, EEE & CoE/Tender-03/2026-27

TENDER INVITATION

Ahsanullah University of Science and Technology (AUST) is inviting sealed bids from bona fide/ reputed organizations/ distributors/ business partners/agents for:

(i) **Procurement of High-Performance PC for CNT office**
(ii) **Procurement of SSD (Qty-40 nos.) for SoB**
(iii) **Procurement of RAM & SSD for EEE dept**
(iv) **Procurement of Answer Scripts & Additional Sheet (Fall-2025) for CoE office**

The bidders must submit earnest money @ 2.5% of the quoted price in the form of Pay Order issued from any scheduled bank drawn in favor of **"Ahsanullah University of Science and Technology"** along with their offer. Interested bidders may collect schedule of tender from the Procurement Office of AUST on all working days till September 10, 2026 by 4 p.m. The sealed offer must be submitted on **September 13, 2026 (Sunday)** by 2.00 p.m. at the Treasurer Office and the tenders will be opened at 02:30 p.m. on the same day (September 13, 2026). Representatives of the participating bidders may remain present at the time of opening the tenders.

The AUST authority reserves the right to accept or reject any or all the tenders without showing any reason what-so-ever and is not bound to award the work order to the lowest bidder.

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এতদ্বারা সর্ব সাধারণের অবগতির জন্য জানানো যাচ্ছে যে, ২০২৬-২০২৭ অর্থ বছরে সামাজিক বন বিভাগ, দিনাজপুর এর আওতাধীন সকল রেঞ্জ ও এস.এফ.এন.টি.সি. এর অধিনে অংশীদারিত্বের ভিত্তিতে সৃজিত মেয়াদ উত্তীর্ণ এবং উন্নয়নমূলক কাজের স্বার্থে খাড়া গাছ/ জব্দকৃত/ ঝড়ে পড়া/আহরিত/বিজ্ঞ আদালত কর্তৃক অনুমতিপ্রাপ্ত/ জামানত বাজেয়াপ্ত/ইতোপূর্বে বিভিন্ন দরপত্রে অবিক্রিত লটসমূহের এবং অন্যান্য উৎস হতে সংগৃহীত বনজদ্রব্য বিক্রয়ের নিমিত্ত অত্র দপ্তরের দরপত্র বিজ্ঞপ্তি নং- ০১/(রাজস্ব) অব ২০২৬-২৭, তারিখ- ১০/০৮/২০২৬ খ্রি. মূলে আগামী ০২/০৯/২০২৬ খ্রি. তারিখে দরপত্র গ্রহণের জন্য পত্রিকায় বিজ্ঞপ্তি প্রকাশ করা হয়। অনিবার্য কারণবশতঃ বিজ্ঞপ্তি নং-০১/(রাজস্ব) অব ২০২৬-২৭, তারিখ- ১০/০৮/২০২৬ খ্রি. মূলে ০২/০৯/২০২৬ খ্রি. তারিখে আহবানকৃত দরপত্রের সকল কার্যক্রম আপাততঃ স্থগিত করা হলো। স্থগিতকৃত দরপত্রটির কার্যক্রম পরবর্তীতে পত্রিকায় বিজ্ঞপ্তি প্রকাশের মাধ্যমে পুনরায় আহবান করা হবে।

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GD-2065

Nepal's high-tech disaster response meets low-tech reality

THE KATHMANDU POST/ANN

The floods in the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers have exposed a striking gap in the country's emergency response. The government agencies are increasingly using digital portals, drones, GIS, satellite images and artificial intelligence to collect and share information, while rescuers on the ground still lack enough specialised equipment to reach people trapped under mud and debris.

State agencies, including the Prime Minister's Office, Nepali Army, Nepal Police and the national disaster management authority (NDRRMA), have launched extensive information drives across social media platforms, emergency SMS broadcasts, mobile ringtone alerts, and specialised applications.

Concurrently,



independent tech groups and civic initiatives have rolled out digital mapping tools, tracing scripts, and open-source data repositories to track missing individuals and compile disaster statistics.

Yet, as the death toll rises and survivors remain isolated, technical analysts, emergency responders, and affected citizens point out a stark contrast. While the country's digital communication strategy appears polished, its physical search, rescue, and early warning infrastructure remains woefully underdeveloped.

On Saturday, a video circulated on social media showing a Nepali Army search team navigating the tunnel of Trishuli Hydroelectric Project to locate trapped workers. The soldiers relied entirely on the small beams of their smartphone flashlights.

The video sparked immediate public outcry. "Without proper equipment, in the faint light of a mobile phone?" commented social media user Irsad Ansari. Many others echoed his disbelief, asking how complex subterranean rescue operations could succeed without specialised demolition tools, and advanced tunnelling equipment.





A member of the Nepal police carries a sack containing money and documents retrieved from a sludge-covered bank in Trishuli, Nepal's Nuwakot district, yesterday. *Inset*, police officers carry identification tags for bodies placed in flower pots at the Devghat mass burial site for victims of the deadly flash floods and mudslides in Chitwan, Nepal.

PHOTO: AFP, REUTERS

NEPAL-CHINA FLASH FLOODS

Survivors return to ruins to salvage memories

Face a second crisis as medicines, water run short

AGENCIES



Days after a wall of water and debris ripped through Nepal, Shanti Lamichhane sat on a fruit crate in the dirt where her village once stood, staring at what remained of her home.

Across Nepal's flood disaster zone, survivors are returning to villages reduced to mud and debris, searching for belongings, documents and fragments of lives swept away in minutes.

Lamichhane said she was waiting for bulldozers to finish clearing the path so she could return.

"I want to retrieve a few things, but it is not just about that," she told AFP. "All my memories are there too."

> **"I want to retrieve a few things, but it is not just about that," Lamichhane told AFP. "All my memories are there too."**

The village of Dhunge, once home to roughly 150 families, now lies in ruins, reduced to a swampy expanse with an ominous rotting stench -- one of dozens of settlements obliterated by the Himalayan floods.

The US Geological Survey said the disaster on Wednesday morning on the China-Nepal border was caused by a glacial collapse, sending an icy torrent downstream driving boulders with its sheer force, cutting a swathe through Nepal from north to south.

As of yesterday morning, figures from Nepal and China put the total number of missing over 3,000, with at least 752 bodies recovered.

For Rekha Devi Gosain, surviving the flood was only the first ordeal.

The Trishuli Bazaar resident lives with diabetes, high blood pressure and thyroid disease, conditions that require regular medication. When the flood swept away her home and four shops she owned, there was no time to save her medicines. Her vehicle, motorcycle and other belongings were also lost.

Now she and her family are living in a displaced-persons camp near Trishuli Hospital. But the hospital does not have the medicines she needs, reports The Kathmandu Post.

"My mother has to take her medicines regularly, but the hospital does not have them," her son Raghubir said. "It has been three days since she was able to take them."

Forced to flee for their lives without time to take anything with them, many survivors are now returning to salvage whatever might remain -- or simply to see what became of what they once called home.

Santosh Adhikari was in Kathmandu when the deluge swept away his home in Dhunge. He returned three days later to find the house buried. "There was nothing," he said.

Workers clearing silt from the flood-struck region say they occasionally come across personal belongings, including gold jewellery.

"But the debris is still knee-high and there is a stench in many places," said Ayushman Kuinkel, a rescuer from the Nepal Scouts youth group. "One knows that there are also likely bodies under it."

Iceland votes 'No' to resuming EU talks

AFP, *Reykjavik*

Iceland voted 'No' to resuming membership negotiations with the European Union (EU), final referendum results showed yesterday, dealing a heavy blow to Brussels which had been keen to welcome a new wealthy member.

In a vote held Saturday, 52.8 percent of Icelanders rejected the resumption of EU entry talks suspended 13 years ago, while 47.2 percent voted 'Yes', according to the official tally published by RUV, the public broadcaster.

The result will be a disappointment to Brussels, which had appeared willing to compromise on thorny issues to facilitate Iceland's accession. The result will likely bury the EU question in Iceland until at least 2028.

The country applied to join the EU in the wake of a 2009 financial crisis that devastated its economy. Membership talks were then suspended in 2013 when a eurosceptic government came to power.

Amid growing international tensions, Iceland's government headed by PM Kristrun Frostadottir wanted to sound out Icelanders on deepening their ties to the EU.

'Recognise your real enemy'

Iran's Khamenei calls on Gulf rulers to unite against US, Israel

AGENCIES

Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei urged Muslim countries, particularly those in the Gulf, to unite against what he called their "real enemy" and said divisions among Muslims served the interests of their adversaries.

"The solution to the problems of the Islamic nations is unity of words, friendship, and cooperation on the path of goodness," he said yesterday as Shia Muslims marked the birthday of the Prophet Mohammed (PBUH).

"Anyone, in any position, who does anything that leads to division among Muslims and creates conflict in the Muslim community, knowingly or unknowingly, intentionally or unintentionally, has served the purpose of the enemies of Islam," he added, according to his official website.

The supreme leader called on the rulers of regional countries to "recognise your real enemy, understand its plan, and confront it", referring to the US and Israel. He asked whether Palestinians would have been left "so helpless" if Muslims had been united, reports Reuters.

Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said yesterday the Strait of Hormuz remains closed and Tehran is in no hurry to reopen it. The IRGC also said that it maintains firm control over the strait, accusing US leaders of spreading false statements regarding the passage to sway energy prices.

UKRAINE ENERGY SECTOR

Russia gears up for 'massive strikes'

Says defence minister; fire reported at Russian refinery after drone crash

AGENCIES

Russia's defence ministry yesterday said it was gearing up for large-scale attacks on Ukraine's energy infrastructure in a tit-for-tat response to strikes by Kyiv.

"Russian forces have begun preparations for massive strikes against facilities in Ukraine's energy sector in response to the ongoing attacks by the Kyiv regime on civilian infrastructure and on Russia's oil and energy complex," it said on Telegram.

Last winter, Moscow repeatedly hit Ukrainian power plants, devastating the country's energy sector and plunging millions of people into cold and darkness in sub-zero temperatures, reports AFP.



Yesterday, the Russian army claimed to have struck a plant in Kyiv producing asbestos and cement whose warehouses, it said, were used to store explosives, as well as a manufacturer of drones and munitions.

Meanwhile, a fire that broke out in an industrial area of the town of Kirishi as result of a drone attack on Russia's Leningrad region has been put out, governor Alexander Drozdenko said.

"The consequences of the fire are currently being assessed," he said on Telegram. Drozdenko added that several residential buildings had been damaged as a result of the attack and that 62 drones had been downed, reports Reuters.

In the Russian-controlled part of Luhansk region in eastern Ukraine, one person was killed in a separate Ukrainian attack on a mine, the region's Russian-installed governor Leonid Pasechnik said.

"শিল্পে প্রাকৃতিক গ্যাস, গৃহস্থলীতে বিকল্প জ্বালানি" "দেশপ্রেমের শপথ নিন-দুর্নীতিকে বিদায় দিন"

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e -Tender Notice

This is to notify for all concerned that the following tender has been published through e-GP portal:

SL	Tender ID	Description of Tender	Tender Selling/ Downloading Time	Tender Closing/ Opening Time
01.	**1320880**	Procurement, Installation & Commissioning of Internet Service for KGDCL Head office, Sholoshahar, Chattogram & Fouzderhat office & Halishahar office and Liaison office, Kawran Bazar, Dhaka.	31-Aug-2026; 11:00 to 17-Sep-2026; 11:00	17 -Sep-2026; 15:00

This is an online tender, where only e-Tender will be accepted in the National e-GP portal and no offline/hard copies will be accepted. The interest person/firms/supplier may visit website www.eprocure.gov.bd to get details of the tender.
To submit e-Tender, registration in the National e-GP system portal (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd) is required. The fees for downloading the e-Tender documents from the National e-GP system portal have to be deposited online through any registered Bank's branches. Further information and guidelines are available in the National e-GP portal and from e-GP help desk (helpdesk@eprocure.gov.bd).

(Engr. Hasan Sohrab)
Deputy General Manager
IT Department
KGDCL, Chattogram

GD-2066

7 die, 23 missing in ferry capsize off Northern Cyprus

REUTERS, *Nicosia*

At least seven people died and 23 were missing after a ferry carrying around 270 passengers and crew capsized off North Cyprus yesterday, leaving survivors clinging to its overturned hull.

The privately owned ferry left the port of Kyrenia at 12:30 pm (0930 GMT) and immediately started taking on water for an unknown reason, authorities said. It was heading for the Turkish port of Tasucu in Mersin province in the eastern Mediterranean.

The disaster occurred just off the coast of Kyrenia, a popular holiday resort for both locals and tourists. The ferry involved, a catamaran, was one of several shuttle sea services that link North Cyprus with Turkey daily.

Turkish Cypriot leader Tufan Erhurman said 237 people had been rescued alive, while seven people had died and 23 people were still being sought.

Video footage showed people in red life jackets sitting or standing on top of the overturned vessel as authorities scrambled coastguard and private vessels for assistance to bring them to shore.

"We have still not been able to reach 23 people. Search and rescue teams are working very intensively to find them," Erhurman said.

প্রেস ইনস্টিটিউট বাংলাদেশ (পিআইবি)
ভর্তি বিজ্ঞপ্তি
কলেজ কোড-৬৫৬৮
সাংবাদিকতায় স্নাতকোত্তর ডিপ্লোমা
শিক্ষাবর্ষ: ২০২৬-২০২৭

প্রেস ইনস্টিটিউট বাংলাদেশ (পিআইবি) জাতীয় বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ের অধীনে সাংবাদিকতায় স্নাতকোত্তর ডিপ্লোমা প্রোগ্রাম ২০২৬-২৭ শিক্ষাবর্ষে (এক বছর মেয়াদি, দুই সেমিস্টার) ভর্তির জন্য উপযুক্ত প্রার্থীদের কাছ থেকে আবেদন আহ্বান করছে।

১. **আবেদনকারীর যোগ্যতা:** ভর্তিচ্ছু শিক্ষার্থীদের জাতীয় বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় বা বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় মঞ্জুরী কমিশন (ইউজিসি) স্বীকৃত যে কোনো বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় থেকে দুই/তিন বছর মেয়াদি স্নাতক (পাশ) অথবা তিন/চার বছর মেয়াদি স্নাতক (সম্মান) পরীক্ষায় ন্যূনতম ৪০% নম্বর/সিজিপিএ ২.০০ পেতে হবে। (যোগ্যতার মানদণ্ড জাতীয় বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় অনুযায়ী)
২. **আসন সংখ্যা:** ৫০
৩. **আবেদন প্রক্রিয়া**
ক. ধাপ-১: জাতীয় বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ের ওয়েবসাইটে (www.nu.ac.bd/admissions) অনলাইন আবেদন করতে হবে। **আবেদনের শেষ তারিখ: ১০ সেপ্টেম্বর ২০২৬।**
খ. ধাপ-২: মাইগভ প্ল্যাটফর্মের (www.mygov.bd) 'সাংবাদিকতায় স্নাতকোত্তর ডিপ্লোমা প্রোগ্রামের প্রাথমিক আবেদন (পিআইবি)' শীর্ষক সেবাটিতে আবেদন করতে হবে। **আবেদনের শেষ তারিখ: ১২ সেপ্টেম্বর ২০২৬।**
গ. আবেদন করার পরবর্তী ১০ কর্মদিবসের মধ্যে প্রাপ্তি স্বীকারপত্র প্রদান করা হবে।
ঘ. আবেদনের পূর্বে অবশ্যই নিম্নলিখিত কাগজ সঙ্গে রাখতে হবে:
- জাতীয় বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ে আবেদনকৃত 'প্রাথমিক আবেদনপত্র'-র পিডিএফ কপি (শিক্ষার্থীর স্বাক্ষরসহ)
- পাসপোর্ট আকারের রঙিন ছবি (সফট কপি)
- স্নাতক পর্যায়ে উত্তীর্ণ পরীক্ষার সনদ, নম্বরপত্র ও রেজিস্ট্রেশন কার্ডের সত্যায়িত স্ক্যান কপি (পিডিএফ)
- দ্বৈত ভর্তি না হওয়া সংক্রান্ত অঙ্গীকারনামার স্বাক্ষরিত কপি (পিডিএফ)

৪. প্রাথমিক ভর্তি আবেদন ফি: ১০০০ (এক হাজার) টাকা
৫. কোর্স ফি বাবদ ১৬,০০০ (ষোলো হাজার) টাকা এককালীন দিতে হবে। (পরীক্ষার ফি ব্যতীত)
ক্লাস: শুক্র ও শনিবার, সকাল ৯টা-বিকাল ৪টা (ক্লাসের সময় পরিবর্তনযোগ্য, ক্লাস শুরুর তারিখ পরে জানানো হবে)

বিস্তারিত জানতে
যোগাযোগ: সমন্বয়কারী,
সাংবাদিকতায় স্নাতকোত্তর ডিপ্লোমা প্রোগ্রাম
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৩, সার্কিট হাউস রোড, ঢাকা-১০০০
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প্রেস ইনস্টিটিউট বাংলাদেশ (পিআইবি)
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FOUNDER EDITOR: **LATE S. M. ALI**

Violent crime cannot become the norm

Authorities must take effective measures to curb criminal activities

It is deeply distressing to see how violent crimes continue to take place around the country despite the government and police reassuring us that steps are being taken to curb the menace. Two reports published by this daily on Sunday reveal something disturbing: killing—often in broad daylight—seems to be gradually becoming commonplace. Meanwhile, ordinary people have been living in constant fear for their safety. It makes us wonder: how much longer must we endure this?

According to one of the reports, police reported four murders and the recovery of four bodies in separate incidents taking place in four districts, between Friday evening and Saturday afternoon. The victims include a 40-year-old poultry trader stabbed to death by unidentified criminals, a 70-year-old banana trader who was hacked to death by his son-in-law, a 25-year-old man killed allegedly by his cousin over land dispute, and a 55-year-old auto-rickshaw driver whose throat was allegedly slit to steal his vehicle. Meanwhile, the other report describes how a 56-year-old school principal fell to her death from her rickshaw near the Jatiya Sangsad building when muggers snatched away her handbag. These reports come on the back of the horrifying murder of a couple and their two children in Rangpur, discovered just over a week ago.

In Dhaka and around Bangladesh, law and order has been in a precarious state for more than two years. When BNP came to power through the February national election, the general expectation was that it would fix the situation and bring the much-awaited relief to the people who have been living in fear for months. Unfortunately, that has not been the case. Police's own statistics show that at least 915 murder cases were filed in the country between March and May this year. More recently, an overview of law and order in the first six months of the BNP government revealed a 2.5 percent rise in the number of criminal cases from those recorded during the same period last year, with a hint that the actual scenario may be worse.

A recent comment by the home minister only adds to the worry. He said that the ongoing energy crisis and its impact on electricity and industrial production may further destabilise the situation, adding that the police have been instructed to stay alert to prevent further deterioration. But can the police function to their full capacity when fear and uncertainty still grip them? Clearly not, judging by the recent trends of crimes and police activity.

To overcome this situation, we strongly urge the government to revisit the police reform recommendations. Without meaningful reform, the institutional weaknesses within the police and other agencies cannot be eradicated. And without a strong and accountable police force, crimes may not go down anytime soon. Ensuring basic security for the people must be among the government's top priorities right now. Crime cannot simply become another risk that citizens learn to live with.

Don't let the citizen service centres sit idle

The government must evaluate why the pilot initiative is failing

It is most unfortunate that the "Nagorik Sheba Kendra," an initiative launched by the interim government in Dhaka last year with the goal to provide 450 essential services to the citizens, have effectively become non-functional. According to a *Prothom Alo* report, of the six centres opened in the capital's Gulshan, Uttara, Nilkhet, Gulistan, Mohammadpur and Banasree areas under a pilot project, four are now closed while one centre is occasionally open. The Gulshan centre is the only one that is operating regularly, but it receives very few service seekers.

The centres were initially designed to handle applications for government services, with the longer-term goal of becoming a single gateway through which citizens could receive complete services. For instance, someone applying for a passport would eventually be able to complete the application, provide fingerprints, have their photograph and biometric information recorded, and have the application forwarded to the relevant government office, avoiding going there in person. The centres were also supposed to provide services such as NID and birth registrations, land services and online GDs, with trained and certified personnel assisting citizens for government-set fees.

However, the personnel were reportedly not provided with the essential equipment or reliable internet connectivity. They found it difficult to run the centres and eventually left. We must ask: why was such a major public service initiative launched without first ensuring the necessary budget, infrastructure, institutional coordination and capacity?

In 2010, the Awami League government launched Union Digital Centres (UDCs) to bring government and other services closer to the citizens. It was largely similar to the interim government's citizen service centres, with trained local entrepreneurs providing various services for a fee. However, the interim government's initial plan was not to replace the UDCs but to bring them under the new system. Unfortunately, that did not happen. Reportedly, the ICT Division is now considering launching a similar initiative named Rural Digital Centres. Before doing so, it must first assess why the existing initiatives have failed.

We urge the government to properly examine the Nagorik Sheba Kendra initiative before deciding whether to close or revive the centres. If it chooses to revive them, it must ensure reliable connectivity and adequate resources, establish clear institutional responsibilities, train and support the service providers, and raise public awareness about the services available. Most importantly, the centres must be properly integrated into the relevant government agencies and digital platforms. Citizens deserve a service system that works, not another initiative that is abandoned soon after its launch.

THIS DAY IN HISTORY

The first victim of Jack the Ripper

On this day in 1888, Mary Ann "Polly" Nichols was found murdered in London's Whitechapel, becoming the first of five women believed to have been killed by Jack the Ripper.

Fixing fragmented health data needs institutional leadership



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SYED ABDUL HAMID

Over the past decade and a half, Bangladesh has invested substantial public resources in digital health systems. Numerous software applications, databases, online platforms, and digital services have been developed. Yet many of these initiatives have emerged as isolated projects. As a result, health information is often scattered across multiple systems. Data have accumulated, but their interoperability and usefulness have not kept pace.

This reality is reflected in the Bangladesh Core FHIR Implementation Guide of the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS). Systems such as DHIS2, hospital automation, and the Human Resources Information System (HRIS) have evolved separately, often using different data structures and standards. This makes information exchange difficult. Our fundamental problem, therefore, is not a lack of technology. It is the absence of a sufficiently strong institutional mechanism to bring different technologies and systems together within a common framework.

Digitalisation is not simply about developing more applications, websites, or software platforms. A digital health system is sustainable only when information can move securely across platforms, new investments can build on existing infrastructure, and systems remain functional beyond the life of individual projects. Continuing to invest public money in similar, disconnected systems is not only inefficient; it also makes it harder to build a coherent national digital health ecosystem.

The Bangladesh Digital Health Strategy 2023–2027 addresses digital infrastructure, electronic health records, telehealth, digital health identity, artificial intelligence, workforce capacity, data privacy, cybersecurity, and national health information exchange. However, an essential institutional question remains: who will lead the transformation, coordinate different initiatives, set common standards, and ensure accountability?

South Asian experiences offer useful lessons. India launched the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission in 2021, with the National Health Authority playing a central role. Rather than requiring every healthcare facility to adopt a single software system, India has focused on creating common digital infrastructure, standards, registries, and an interoperability framework. Digital health IDs, registries of healthcare facilities and health professionals, and consent-based health information exchange are intended to allow different systems to work together. For Bangladesh, the lesson is clear: institutional leadership and a common digital architecture must come before the proliferation of applications.



FILE VISUAL: **STAR**

Pakistan provides another relevant example. Under the Digital Nation Pakistan Act, 2025, the country established the Pakistan Digital Authority (PDA) as a legally empowered institution to oversee the country's broader digital transformation. Its mandate includes data governance and protection, citizen-centred digital services, interoperability, common standards, national digital planning, and coordination of digital initiatives across government. This approach treats digital transformation as a national institutional responsibility rather than a collection of disconnected projects.

Bangladesh needs to adopt a similar institutional perspective for health. Digital health involves far more than putting hospitals online. It encompasses data governance, privacy, cybersecurity, interoperability, common standards, health information exchange, and the effective use of data for clinical care, public health, and policy. These responsibilities require an institution with the authority, expertise, and continuity to govern the entire digital health ecosystem.

Bangladesh should therefore seriously consider establishing an independent national digital health authority. This should not be another temporary project or a small information technology unit. It should be established through legislation, staffed by professionals, and given adequate administrative, financial, and technical autonomy. Its governance should draw expertise from health, information and communication technology, public health, health economics, cybersecurity, data protection, private healthcare, and academia.

The authority could be responsible for defining the national digital health architecture; establishing and maintaining digital health identity and national registries of healthcare facilities and health professionals; setting data and interoperability standards; facilitating secure health information exchange; and ensuring privacy, data protection, and cybersecurity. It should also provide a clear regulatory framework within which both public and private providers can develop and connect digital services.

Perhaps most importantly, the authority should coordinate public investment in digital health. Before any ministry, directorate, or project develops a new digital health system using public funds, it should demonstrate why the investment is necessary, whether a similar system already exists, whether the proposed system can connect with existing platforms, and who will operate and maintain it after the project ends. A simple principle should guide public investment: no new standalone digital health system should be financed unless it is aligned with the national digital health architecture and designed for interoperability.

This does not mean that the government should develop every application itself. The government should provide the common infrastructure, standards, security framework, and interoperability rules, while public and private organisations remain free to develop innovative applications according to their needs. This approach would encourage innovation without public investment becoming fragmented across competing systems.

The current initiative to develop a national e-health platform offers Bangladesh an important opportunity to make this transition. Before developing another platform, we should first take stock of what already exists. A comprehensive national inventory should identify all digital health systems, the investments made in them, their current functionality and utilisation, areas of duplication, and their potential for integration. Based on this assessment, the government should establish the national digital health architecture and determine which systems should be retained, integrated, upgraded, or phased out.

Digital health has become an essential part of the health system's long-term infrastructure. Bangladesh must therefore move from a project-based approach to an institution-based approach. A strong institution can provide continuity even when governments, projects, technologies, and development partners change. It can also ensure that today's investments remain useful tomorrow rather than becoming another set of disconnected digital assets. The choice before Bangladesh is therefore not whether to embrace digital health; we have already made that choice. The real question is whether we will continue to build isolated digital projects or create the institutional foundation necessary for them to work together.

The journey towards a sustainable digital health ecosystem should begin with institution-building. First, establish the institution; then develop the national architecture, common standards, and shared infrastructure; and finally allow software, applications, and innovation to flourish on that foundation. If we get this sequence right, Bangladesh can move from fragmented digital initiatives to an integrated, secure, sustainable, and citizen-centred digital health system.

For a sustainable future, we must take energy efficiency seriously



Mohammad Alauddin
is former rector at Bangladesh Power Management Institute.

MOHAMMAD ALAUDDIN

If we were to stick to simple terms, energy transition denotes systematically moving away from a fossil-based energy structure to a low-carbon energy system, and this has posed a challenge to many countries around the world. This is especially because energy demand has been steadily on the rise globally due to rapid industrialisation, urbanisation, and rising living standards, driving countries to go on a quest for additional sources of energy. Bangladesh, too, has been on a similar journey, although so far, it has mainly focused on increasing generation while a lot of readily available sources of energy remain largely untapped. This is where energy efficiency, the use of less energy to do the same task or provide the same service by increasing energy productivity, comes in.

Approaches to improving such efficiency include supply-side energy efficiency (SSEE) and demand-side energy efficiency (DSEE). SSEE can improve efficiency by reducing losses along the energy supply chain, and DSEE enables consumers to use less energy to provide the same level of service. Realising the growing importance of energy efficiency, the Sustainable and Renewable Energy Development Authority (SREDA) launched the Energy Efficiency and Conservation Master Plan (EECMP) up to 2030 in May, 2016 with an implementation roadmap. The plan aimed to reduce primary energy consumption per unit of GDP (energy intensity) by 15 percent in 2021 and by 20 percent in 2030 relative to 2013 levels.

The EECMP introduced a pioneering framework for energy efficiency in Bangladesh, but it gave less attention to the transport sector, efficiency on the utility side, and energy pricing reforms. This weakened the plan's potential to reduce energy consumption across the economy, especially as transport has become one of the fastest-growing energy-consuming sectors in Bangladesh. The EECMP implementation roadmap proposed several specific programmes. However, many of these programmes, particularly mandatory energy management, appliance labelling, and energy audits, have not progressed as rapidly as envisioned due to limited institutional capacity within implementing agencies and lack of effective inter-agency coordination.

According to the International Energy Agency (IEA), governments—particularly in emerging and developing economies—spent approximately $620 billion on fossil-fuel consumption subsidies in 2023. The International Monetary Fund estimated Bangladesh's energy-related budget subsidies at 0.9 percent of GDP in FY2022-23. Since then, the fiscal burden has remained substantial. In the revised FY2024-25 budget, subsidies for power and fertiliser alone rose to Tk 90,000 crore, partly because the government had to clear large arrears accumulated in the power sector. In FY2025-26, the government faced further pressure from soaring international fuel and LNG prices, with the finance minister estimating that the oil, gas, electricity and fertiliser sectors could require an additional Tk 42,600 crore in subsidies.

While the government argues that lower energy prices are beneficial for economic growth and can make products and services more affordable, prolonged energy subsidies can have unintended consequences. For instance, subsidies can be deemed as an irrational use of taxpayer money. Energy costs directly drive efficiency by making waste more expensive. When electricity or fuel prices spike, the financial incentive for both households and businesses to switch to high-efficiency technologies. By keeping energy prices artificially low, subsidies weaken the price signals that would otherwise encourage households and businesses to conserve energy and invest in more efficient technologies.

However, it's also true that energy efficiency needs an ecosystem of standards, incentives, labelling, enforcement, and public awareness to support it. The government should strengthen and enforce minimum energy performance standards for appliances such as motors, boilers, air conditioners, refrigerators, fans, and lighting products. Additionally, fiscal incentives, such as reduced import duties, tax rebates, concessional financing or utility-sponsored rebate programmes, can make efficient appliances more affordable. Equally important is sustained public awareness to highlight the benefits of saving energy. After all, every unit of energy saved is, in effect, as good as making a new unit of energy.

Perhaps the greatest misconception surrounding energy transition is the assumption that renewable energy alone can solve Bangladesh's energy challenges. However, renewable generation must be complemented by demand-side management. Without energy efficiency, rising demand may continue to outpace the growth of clean energy, requiring additional investments in generation capacity and grid infrastructure. As Bangladesh charts its path toward a resilient and sustainable energy future, concerned authorities must recognise that energy efficiency is not the missing piece of the puzzle, but the foundation upon which a successful energy transition must be built.

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Bangladesh and Malaysia must break the recruitment syndicate's grip



Shariful Hasan
is a labour migration expert and former journalist.

SHARIFUL HASAN

"Is the syndicate more powerful than the state?"

With that question to both Malaysia and Bangladesh, I ended my article, "Labour recruitment to Malaysia: Time to break the never-ending cycle," published in *The Daily Star* on July 25, 2022.

At the time, Bangladesh was preparing to reopen the Malaysian labour market after more than three years of suspension. My warning was simple: reopening should not reproduce a syndicate-driven model in which migrant workers bear the costs and the risks.

The consequences soon became clear.

Around 4,50,000 migrant workers from Bangladesh went to Malaysia between 2022 and 2024. But under the controversial recruitment system, the average migration cost reportedly reached Tk 5.44 lakh or more, against an officially fixed cost of Tk 78,990. Besides, when Malaysia set May 31 as the deadline for Bangladeshi workers to enter the country in 2024, at least 16,970 workers who had obtained clearance from the Bureau of Manpower Employment and Training (BMET), as well as valid visas and tickets, could not reach the Southeast Asian state because of mismanagement by government authorities and local recruiting agents.

My article "Labour recruitment to Malaysia: Syndicate wins, migrants suffer, country loses," published in *The Daily Star* on June 8, 2024, mentioned how the 2022 warning had become reality.

Two years later and after three changes in government, the same Foreign Workers Centralised Management System (FWCMS)-based limited-recruitment architecture—and the related concerns about the syndicate—have returned. On August 21, 2026, Malaysia's FWCMS published a list of 25 Bangladeshi recruiting agencies, raising concerns about a limited-agency recruitment model.

Amid the criticism, on August 28, FWCMS expanded the arrangement to 338 Bangladeshi agencies. Of these, 25 were directly selected agencies, 250 were associate agencies under them and another 62 would work under the state-owned Bangladesh Overseas Employment and Services Limited (BOESL).

However, several fundamental questions remain unanswered. For instance, based on what criteria were the agencies selected? Who controls access to employers, job orders and the digital recruitment chain? Is it still the same FWCMS system? And if recruitment is suspended once again, who will be held accountable?

Reopening, exploitation, suspension: The old cycle

Bangladesh-Malaysia labour migration has followed a familiar pattern over the past five decades: the market opens, allegations of excessive costs and irregularities arise, migrants suffer, recruitment is suspended and attempts are made at reform.

According to BMET, 23 Bangladeshis first went to Malaysia in 1978, while regular migration began in 1992. The market was almost frozen between 1997 and 2005. After Malaysia introduced the calling visa system in 2006, around 4,00,000 Bangladeshis went there in 2007 and 2008. Although the official migration cost was Tk 84,000, workers reportedly paid Tk 2 to Tk 3 lakh or more. Many struggled to find jobs, while a significant number of workers became undocumented. Then in 2009, Malaysia again stopped recruiting Bangladeshi workers. Three years later, in November 2012, Bangladesh and Malaysia signed a government-to-government (G2G) agreement, bypassing private recruiting agencies. But the system did not generate sufficient recruitment.

Meanwhile, the maritime trafficking crisis between 2012 and 2015 exposed a devastating side of irregular migration, with thousands of people attempting dangerous journeys by boat and trafficking camps and mass graves discovered along the Thailand-Malaysia border.

A decade of syndication and control

Private recruiting agencies returned under the G2G Plus arrangement in 2016. But instead of opening the market to all eligible agencies, Malaysia selected a syndicate of just 10 agencies, leading to allegations of monopoly, excessive costs and irregularities in the recruitment network and its associated digital system. FWCMS remained at the centre of the recruitment process.

In September 2018, after Mahathir Mohamad returned to power, Malaysia suspended the system, describing the recruitment process as a form of human trafficking and a money-making scheme. Yet in 2022, the same recruitment model resurfaced despite protests from civil society and recruiting agencies. And this time, 25 Bangladeshi recruiting agencies were initially selected, and later expanded. But once again, FWCMS sits at the centre of the recruitment process.

FWCMS is developed and operated by Bestinet, a Malaysian private company associated with Aminul Islam Bin Abdul Nor. A Malaysian citizen of Bangladeshi origin, Aminul has been identified in media reports as a central figure in Malaysia's migrant recruitment system for the past decade, alongside influential actors within powerful circles in both countries.



PHOTO COURTESY: **SHARIFUL HASAN**

Over the past five decades, the Malaysian labour market has opened many times, allegations of high costs and irregularities surfaced, migrants suffered, and recruitment has been suspended repeatedly, with little change in the recruitment process.

According to media reports, under the syndicate system in 2023 and 2024, the registration fee per worker was set at 100 Malaysian ringgit, equivalent to around Tk 2,700 at the time. Instead, workers were charged Tk 1,07,000, of which Tk 1,00,000 allegedly had to be sent to Bestinet in Malaysia.

Recruiting agencies allege that around Tk 5,000 crore was siphoned out of the country through a "syndicate fee" of Tk 1,00,000 per worker. Another Tk 3,750 crore was allegedly siphoned off in the name of the "visa trade". Altogether, the amount allegedly siphoned out of the country could be at least Tk 8,750 crore. The actual scale of corruption and irregularities, however, may have been even higher.

Between July 2024 and 2026, several cases were filed, several people were arrested, and investigations are still ongoing. Yet the fundamental recruitment architecture has not changed. Instead, concerns about the same model have resurfaced around FWCMS and the proposed list of recruiting agencies.

This raises a fundamental question: how can a private recruitment architecture become so influential in a system involving two sovereign governments? Are the actors behind it more powerful than the governments of Bangladesh and Malaysia? And if they are not, why has the system repeatedly been allowed to operate despite such serious allegations and irregularities?

The concern is regional

Nepal has raised serious concerns about the limited-agency model. After FWCMS published a list of 25 recruiting agencies, Nepal's Ministry of Youth, Labour and Employment expressed concern and held an emergency meeting with Malaysia's ambassador to Nepal to seek clarification. Nepal Association of Foreign Employment Agencies also strongly objected, arguing that restricting recruitment to just 25 agencies would create a de facto monopoly, undermine healthy competition and ultimately open the door to the economic exploitation of migrant workers.

The concern has since become regional. On August 27, representatives of foreign recruitment agencies from Bangladesh, Nepal, Myanmar and Pakistan issued a joint statement calling for equal access, transparency and fair competition. They warned that no digital platform should become a vehicle for syndication, monopoly or exclusive control over migrant recruitment.

Disclose the entire mechanism

For a recruiting agency, a government office or a digital system, a migrant worker may be a number, but for a family, that worker is often its only hope. Migrants often sell land, borrow from relatives, mortgage property or take high-interest loans to finance the journey for a foreign job. If the job materialises, the family gradually recovers its investment. However, if the worker pays Tk 5 to 6 lakh and cannot travel, the debt does not disappear. Migrants and their families have to bear the burden of that sunk cost.

That is why the goal should not simply be how to reopen the market. It should be: how can it be reopened safely, transparently and affordably with the migrant worker at the centre?

Before recruitment begins this time, both governments should disclose the entire mechanism—a step that has been missing in previous recruitment cycles. Workers, recruiting agencies and the public deserve to know exactly how the process will work, who will control each stage, what each party in the process will be paid and what safeguards are in place. If a worker pays but cannot travel, who will refund the money? If the promised job does not exist, who will be held responsible? If a digital platform controls access to recruitment, who will oversee it and ensure that it cannot be used to create a monopoly?

These questions must be answered before recruitment begins. If there are limitations in the current Memorandum of Understanding, both governments should work to amend those as the agreement expires later this year. But transparency cannot wait. It must come before the first worker pays a single taka, accompanied by a clear commitment that anyone who violates the rules—however powerful—will face consequences.

The state must answer

Bangladesh-Malaysia labour migration has repeatedly been plagued by problems. For almost a decade, different versions of limited-agency recruitment have been accompanied by allegations of irregularities, controversy and migrant suffering. Yet those allegedly responsible for previous irregularities have not been held accountable, while the same network appears to have resurfaced in the next recruitment process under a different name. This cycle must be stopped. Both governments have a responsibility to ensure that migrant workers are protected from exploitation and that recruitment is transparent, fair and accountable.

Otherwise, the question "Is the syndicate more powerful than the state?" will remain unanswered.

This time, Bangladesh and Malaysia must prove that the state *is* more powerful than the syndicate.

We should engage with the Mecca pact, but not rush to join it



Dr. Nasir Uddin Ahmed
is a retired Major, researcher, and political and security analyst.

NASIR UDDIN AHMED

The Mecca Joint Defence Agreement, signed by Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Pakistan on August 7, has created a new strategic reality stretching from the Gulf to South Asia. Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman has already indicated that Bangladesh would positively consider joining the pact, should there be an invitation. Law Minister Md Asaduzzaman has also said the government will decide whether Bangladesh will join the pact taking into account the overall situation. He, however, didn't signal a decision in this regard.

Given its likely impact, the issue has, understandably, generated a debate stretching from the parliament floor to the tea stalls of remote areas. The defence agreement matters because it commits the three founding countries to collective defence: an armed attack against one is treated as an attack against all. Saudi Arabia brings considerable financial strength and geopolitical influence; Türkiye contributes a powerful military and a rapidly developing defence industry; and Pakistan brings substantial military experience and a nuclear deterrent. Together, they possess considerable strategic weight. However, calling the agreement an "Islamic NATO" may be premature. Unlike NATO, the new arrangement does not yet have a NATO-type institutional structure, integrated command system, or decades of operational experience. Analysts have also noted that its practical military mechanisms are still in the development stage. And, for Bangladesh, this distinction matters a lot.

Our foreign policy has traditionally sought friendship with all and hostility towards none. This approach is particularly valuable for a country whose economic and security interests are distributed among several competing powers. Bangladesh depends heavily on Western markets for its RMG exports, maintains important economic and strategic relations with China, has vital geographic and political links with India, and has deep economic and human connections with the Gulf. Millions of Bangladeshis work in Middle Eastern countries, while remittances remain crucial to the national economy. Bangladesh also needs Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Pakistan as important partners in different areas. Joining a military alliance, however, is fundamentally different from maintaining friendly bilateral relations.



Turkish President Tayyip Erdogan, Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, and Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif chat after signing a joint defense agreement on August 7, 2026.

FILE PHOTO: **REUTERS**

The greatest complication may come from Bangladesh's relationship with India. Pakistan is one of the three founding members of the Mecca pact. Bangladesh-Pakistan relations have improved considerably in recent years, but geography makes India indispensable to Bangladesh. Trade, transit, border management, water resources, energy, and regional connectivity all require a functioning relationship with New Delhi. A formal military alignment with Pakistan could therefore be interpreted in India as a major strategic shift. Reuters has already described the possible Bangladeshi membership as a test of Dhaka's long-standing effort to avoid choosing between competing geopolitical camps. That does not mean Bangladesh should outright reject the Mecca initiative. In fact, there are several areas in which Bangladesh could benefit from closer cooperation with the three countries. These include military training, counter-terrorism efforts, intelligence sharing, maritime security, cyber security, disaster response, peacekeeping, unmanned systems, and defence technology. Türkiye, in particular, has developed a strong indigenous defence industry. Pakistan has extensive experience in military operations and defence production, while Saudi Arabia has both financial resources and a growing ambition to develop its domestic defence capabilities. A carefully designed partnership could therefore provide Bangladesh with opportunities beyond conventional arms purchases.

Additionally, Bangladesh should also look at the Mecca pact from the perspective of its own security priorities. Dhaka's principal strategic concerns are not the same as Riyadh's, Ankara's, or Islamabad's. It is more immediately concerned with the Bay of Bengal, maritime security, border management, terrorism and transnational crime, climate-related disasters, cyber threats, and the security of its trade and energy routes. If Bangladesh becomes a formal member of a collective-defence arrangement, however, it could potentially face expectations to support another member during a conflict far removed from Bangladesh's territory. This is perhaps the most important question that Dhaka should ask before joining: would Bangladesh be prepared to accept a military obligation whenever another member of the pact is attacked at a far distance? The answer cannot be based on financial and strategic gains, sentiment, and the religious affinity of the people or temporary diplomatic enthusiasm. It must be based on Bangladesh's national interest. There is another reason for caution. The Mecca framework itself is still evolving. Pakistan has recently indicated that the pact is open to new members and that any formal request would be considered in consultation with Saudi Arabia and Türkiye. On the other hand, the possibility of Iran's membership is being actively discussed by many Muslim countries. This suggests that the institutional character and future membership of the pact have not yet been fully settled.

Dhaka should seek detailed clarification from the founding members on the pact's military obligations, command arrangements, rules of engagement, financing, intelligence sharing, and the circumstances in which a member would be expected to provide military assistance. At the same time, Bangladesh should negotiate practical defence cooperation. It could seek joint training, maritime surveillance, cyber security cooperation, drone technology, defence education, and disaster-response capabilities. These are areas where cooperation could strengthen Bangladesh's national security without unnecessarily narrowing its diplomatic choices. There is also a larger strategic principle at stake. The international system is becoming increasingly fragmented. States are forming new partnerships because traditional security arrangements are under pressure. The Mecca pact is one manifestation of that trend.

However, Bangladesh does not have to choose a geopolitical camp merely because other countries are doing so. Our strategic advantage has historically been our ability to maintain relationships with different powers simultaneously. That flexibility is particularly valuable for a country of Bangladesh's size and economic structure. Therefore, Bangladesh should neither rush to join the Mecca pact nor dismiss it. It should engage actively, study its evolution, and negotiate from a position of confidence. If, in the future, membership can demonstrably enhance Bangladesh's security, defence capability, and diplomatic influence without imposing unacceptable strategic costs, Dhaka can reconsider the membership. For now, the wisest course is strategic autonomy with active engagement. Bangladesh should keep the door open, but should not walk through it before knowing exactly where it leads.

I don't mind being called an 'influencer': MASHA

Artiste speaks about career, collab with DW

SADI MOHAMMAD SHAHNEWAZ

Three months ago, an email dropped into Masha Islam's inbox that would shift the trajectory of her creative career: Deutsche Welle (DW), the German state-funded international broadcaster, wanted to collaborate.

What resulted was a 10-episode travel documentary/vlog, the teaser of which was available to everyone through the DW Travel page. Immediately apparent was her chemistry with host Emma Kremer, while the two made inroads into various bustling places of Dhaka at its liveliest.



It marks the first time the global network has partnered with a Bangladeshi influencer and artiste. Brought on board to film and host a multi-part travel series for both their DW Travel and DW Bengali wings, Masha found herself at the helm of a landmark cultural project alongside the German correspondent.

It marks the first time the global network has partnered with a Bangladeshi influencer and artiste. Brought on board to film and host a multi-part travel series for both their DW Travel and DW Bengali wings, Masha found herself at the helm of a landmark cultural project alongside the German correspondent.

"It wasn't easy in the slightest," said Masha. "Filming publicly in a crowded city like Dhaka was always going to be a challenge, especially when there was only a two-person on-ground crew with me. Emma only had the videographer with her, even though we had corresponded with their core team in Germany." Despite that, the artiste handled the grueling production entirely on her own terms—foregoing the safety net of a glam squad. "Without makeup and hair done, without any stylist, I am proud to have pulled it off," she said with a defiant smirk.

Despite the difficulties, the shots that Masha and company got of heritage sites, including Ahsan Manzil and the Lalbagh Fort, were sublime.

Together, they mapped out ten distinct stories diving deep into the history, shades, and heartbeat of Bangladesh, journeying from the lush tea gardens of Sylhet and Sreemangal to the sweeping coastline of Cox's Bazar.

Hosting a bilingual production in both English and Bangla across chaotic urban centres and remote fields was no small feat for the fluently bilingual artiste.

Does it bother Masha when she is called an 'influencer' by organisations, even though she came to the fray through her mellifluous voice? "Not at all," answered the confident artiste. "I used to think of it as a derogatory term, but I've come to realise that influencers are doing the most to convey positive messages to the audience. I am both a singer and influencer in that regard."

However, music remains her true north. Between grueling production days, she has been quietly pouring her energy into a forthcoming album of original tracks, with two songs already polished and ready for release. Travel vlogging on her own YouTube channel is also on the horizon once her schedule permits, fueled by a lifestyle that already keeps her constantly on the move for work. "I had started vlogging before, but could not continue it to that effect," said Masha.

The collab is evidence that life has a way of putting things together for those who try. For the young singer, this opens the door to endless possibilities.



PHOTO: SHEIKH MEHEDI MORSHED



Anne Hathaway joins Tom Cruise in 'Days of Thunder' sequel

Anne Hathaway is set to star opposite Tom Cruise in the upcoming sequel to ***Days of Thunder***, with Paramount Pictures scheduling the film for release on June 2, 2028, according to Variety.

Cruise will reprise his role as race car driver Cole Trickle, while Hathaway will play a racing team owner and engineer. Plot details remain under wraps. Jonathan Levine, known for ***Long Shot***, will direct, with Cruise producing alongside Jerry Bruckheimer and Tommy Harper. The film will be shot for IMAX and released theatrically in formats including Dolby Cinema and 4DX.

Cruise also shared a promotional image featuring Hathaway at a NASCAR track. The original Tony Scott-directed ***Days of Thunder***, released in 1990, also starred Nicole Kidman and Robert Duvall.

EVENTS

'Untold Story'



Alliance Française de Dhaka presents ***Untold Story***, a group art exhibition curated by Fareha Zeba. The exhibition brings together artist books and contemporary artworks exploring memory, identity, heritage, loss, longing and lived experiences. The participating artists use painting, drawing, collage, stitching, textiles, found materials and experimental book forms to share personal stories. The exhibition turns books into intimate artistic spaces and brings unspoken experiences into view.

Date: Tuesday–Wednesday | September 1–9
Time: 3:00–9:00pm | 6:00pm (Opening)
Venue: La Galerie, Alliance Française de Dhaka

NEWS

Pakistan suspends eight officials after infant ward fire

AFP, *Islamabad*

Pakistan's prime minister said eight officials were suspended and called for criminal proceedings against them, after 14 infants were killed in a fire in the maternity ward of a hospital in the country's capital.

A preliminary report conducted by a four-person committee formed by Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif found the deadly blaze had engulfed the unit "within approximately two minutes" just after 6:30am (0130 GMT) on Wednesday, with a nurse only able to save one of the 15 infants in the hospital's care.

Among those suspended were hospital staff including its executive director and the head of the neonatal department, as well as the director-general of Islamabad's emergency services.

Sharif said late Saturday "those responsible for criminal negligence do not deserve any concession" and that they will be "brought to justice".

He also approved taking action against the company responsible for the hospital's security, without naming them.

Emergency services were called within six minutes of the fire breaking out, with the first rescue services arriving at the scene 15 minutes later, the report said.

Parents and other witnesses told AFP the response had been slow and guards had reportedly prevented people from leaving the building.

Dhaka sees no risk

FROM PAGE 1

manner, aligned with the dynamics of the current international political system.

"We will balance our international relations. Bangladesh stands for global peace and stability, and wherever peace and stability are the primary goals, Bangladesh will always be present."

Bangladesh's long experience in UN peacekeeping provides a strong basis for contributing to peace and stability in the Muslim world, he said.

"Maintaining peace is not a new concept for Bangladesh -- we have extensive experience and expertise in this area, and we are recognised globally for it. We do this all around the world, so why should we not do it for our Muslim brotherhood here?"

Discussions on the Mecca pact have progressed constructively.

"Let's see how things develop as we engage further -- we view this very positively," he added.

Pay scale to balance budget

FROM PAGE 12

from July 1, with another 35 percent to take effect at the start of next year. Recommendations may be made to execute the remaining portion of the basic salary in July of the next fiscal year, followed by the allowances in January of that fiscal year.

Meanwhile, a finance ministry official said recommendations have been made to increase the basic salary for government employees across the 1st to 20th grades by up to 100 percent.

Nearly a decade after the Eighth Pay Commission, the interim government formed a 23-member Ninth National Pay Commission on July 27, 2025. Led by former finance secretary Zakir Ahmed Khan, the commission submitted its report to then chief adviser Prof Muhammad Yunus on January 21 this year.

On April 21, a 10-member committee was formed to oversee the implementation, with Cabinet Secretary Nasimul Gani as its chief.

During the budget speech in parliament on June 11, the finance minister announced that the new salary structure would take effect on July 1.

SMS records suggest victim

FROM PAGE 12

the cell tower handling the connection.

The CDRs handed over to law enforcement by telecom operators generally do not contain the content of calls or messages.

A trigger message, on the other hand, is a machine-generated message sent to the device of the target being surveilled to track the location of the cell tower they are connected to at that moment.

"These messages often resemble automated promotional messages that telecom operators send to their users several times a day with internet pack offers or call rates," said Tanveer Hossain Zoha, a prosecutor with the International Crimes Tribunal and a digital forensics specialist.

Then how and why do the investigators suspect that the messages in Ismail Hossain's phone were not just regular SMSs promoting the latest data pack?

DEVIL IS IN DETAIL

Over a span of 20 days, between June 1 and June 19, 2019, when Ismail Hossain was allegedly picked up, his phone number registered 62 calls and messages.

These included 20 calls made from regular phone numbers with various call durations. The other 42 records were text messages.

Between June 1 and June 5, 2019, these messages had fairly normal patterns. There were two messages on June 1, six hours apart from each other. Then two messages the next day about 20 minutes apart, none the next day, and only one each on June 4 and June 5, 2019.

The pattern changed on June 6, 2019. At 1:45pm, he got two messages from the same code within six seconds of each other.

Almost every single day from then on till the day of his disappearance, he got messages in pairs, each within five to seven seconds of each other.

Senior telecommunications officials, speaking on condition of anonymity, said mobile operators do not ordinarily send promotional messages in rapid bursts. Such messages are typically spaced out over time rather than delivered within seconds of one another.

They noted that the only common exception occurs when a subscriber has not used a SIM card for 90 days, prompting the operator to send multiple notifications at once.

That was not the case with Ismail, whose CDR also logs normal phone calls being made and received.

On the day of his disappearance, he got a pair of these messages at 12:31pm, one six seconds apart from the other.

According to the general diary filed by Ismail's wife Nasrin Jahan Smrity, on the evening of that day, Ismail Hossain was picking up spare car parts near Mirpur-1 in Dhaka when men identifying themselves as members of the Rapid Action Battalion (RAB-4) forced him into a microbus.

"When I went to the police station to file a missing persons report, the officer tracked his cellphone and found it turning towards RAB-4," said Nasrin, a claim The Daily Star could not independently verify.

On the day before Ismail's disappearance, five messages, first as a pair at 12:37pm and then as a set of three at 5:15pm. Each time, the messages were spaced five to six seconds apart.

"Each of these messages triggered the location of the cell tower his cell phone was connected to at that particular moment," explained Tanveer.

The Daily Star has independently had the CDR inspected by three people with knowledge about trigger messages who all agreed that Tanveer's was the likeliest interpretation.

"Trigger messages have historically been used to intercept devices or surveil targeted individuals. We have seen precedent of this in Bangladesh, particularly in cases of politically motivated surveillance, enforced disappearances and protests," said Sabhanaz Rashid Diya, who leads Tech Global Institute, which has published a research report on Bangladesh's surveillance infrastructure.

She, however, noted that a final conclusion about the nature and motive of the messages would require extensive forensic investigations.

The final report of the Commission on the Inquiry of Enforced Disappearance said that "silent pick-ups -- unobtrusive abductions -- were virtually impossible without mobile surveillance to pinpoint the victim's location with precision."

It mentioned an internal army inquiry into the abduction of Brigadier Abdullahil Azmi as stating, "DGFI's Dhaka Det [Detachment]had been conducting surveillance on Brigadier Azmi for at least a month prior to his abduction."

While the investigation into the disappearance of Ismail Hossain is ongoing, ICT investigators have zeroed in on RAB-4 as the potential party associated with the case.

The preliminary investigation report of the case states that when the team visited RAB-4 to collect a document called the "command certificate" of that particular day, they found it to be missing.

"During inquiry, RAB representatives have been unable to explain how, under which internal rule, or in the presence of which officers, the relevant Command Certificate was allegedly destroyed or rendered unavailable," it added.

Despite multiple attempts, The Daily Star failed to reach RAB for comment.

No silence in Dhaka's silent zones

FROM PAGE 12

daily before the declaration, immediately after it and two months later.

At the airport's main entrance, the average noise level was 89.19 decibels before the area's designation as a silent zone. It rose to 90.03 decibels immediately afterwards and stood at 89.68 decibels two months later.

Another study by seven researchers from BRAC University, McGill University, Imperial College London and the University of Massachusetts Amherst found widespread excessive noise exposure across Dhaka.

The researchers developed the first citywide model of environmental sound exposure in Dhaka based on data collected in 2023 from 67 locations across the capital.

The study, published this month in the international peer-reviewed journal Science of the Total Environment, said that no residential area or designated silent zone met Bangladesh's nighttime noise standards ranging from 40 to 60 decibels between 9:00pm and 6:00am.

It estimated that nearly all residents of Dhaka city were exposed to outdoor sound levels exceeding the World Health Organization's traffic-noise guidelines, while around 900,000 were exposed to levels above 70 decibels.

According to the WHO, average road traffic noise should remain below 53 decibels during the day and 45 decibels at night.

For residents and commuters across the capital, there seems to be no respite from relentless noise.

Hamidur Rahman, who runs a shop near Dhaka airport, said loud horns have become part of his everyday life.

"High-decibel horns cause severe discomfort. The noise hurts my ears and often leaves me feeling dizzy. Though authorities occasionally remove hydraulic horns from vehicles and fine drivers, the problem resurfaces within days," he said.

Sumaiya Akter, a resident of the airport area, said her child becomes frightened whenever vehicles blare loud horns.

"He complains of headaches quite often... The authorities should take tougher action because the rules for this silent zone are clearly not being followed."

According to health experts, prolonged exposure to noise can cause hearing impairment, sleep disturbance, hypertension, cardiovascular disease and cognitive impairment in children.

They say children and people with pre-existing health conditions face the greatest health risks.

Prof Md Abu Hanif, former director of the National Institute of ENT, said loud hydraulic horns can permanently damage delicate hearing cells in children's ears.

"Continuous exposure to loud traffic noise can delay learning and even cause permanent hearing loss," he noted.

When asked about the enforcement of the new rules, Md Anisur Rahman, additional police commissioner (Traffic) of Dhaka Metropolitan Police, said it is challenging to manually identify offending vehicles.

He further said the DMP is exploring technology that can automatically identify vehicles producing excessive noise.

Anisur said drivers often reinstall hydraulic horns after police remove them during drives, making constant monitoring necessary.

Many traffic police officers suffer hearing loss and complain of chronic headaches as they spend hours in high-noise environments, he said, adding that the DMP is considering buying ear protection devices for traffic police personnel.

Ahmad Kamruzzaman Majumder, a professor of environmental science at Stamford University Bangladesh, said enforcement alone would not solve the problem.

An ineffective manual traffic system makes drivers impatient and encourages constant honking, he said.

"In the end, those making the noise also become its victims. We must all cooperate from our own positions, particularly teachers and students, to raise awareness."

He suggested nationwide awareness campaigns involving schools and government institutions, alongside stricter enforcement.

Youth shot dead near Habiganj border

OUR CORRESPONDENT, *Moulvibazar*

A Bangladeshi youth was shot dead near the Chimtibil border in Habiganj's Chunarughat upazila yesterday, said Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB).

The incident occurred about one kilometre inside Indian territory from the zero line, said BGB.

The deceased, Sohag Mia, was from Chimtibil.

Lt Col Tanzilur Rahman, commander of BGB's 55 Habiganj Battalion, said they initially suspected that Sohag had been killed in firing by India's Border Security Force (BSF). However, the BSF denied involvement, he said.

BGB believes Sohag and several others were involved in a dispute with Indian smugglers over the division of proceeds, during which Sohag was shot, he said. "One of his brothers was with him at the time. He fled the scene and later informed the police and BGB."

Locals said they heard gunshots around 12:30pm and later found Sohag's body.

Doctor Sirajum Munira said Sohag had died before being brought to Chunarughat Upazila Health Complex. Police said necessary documentation was completed for an autopsy.



Farmers and farmhands separate jute fibre from the stalks, receiving jute sticks in return. The photo was taken in the Jhagarar Char area of Sreebardi upazila in Sherpur recently.

PHOTO: **SAHIDUL ISLAM NIRAB**

Jhenaidah key bridge lies unrepaired for a year

OMAR ALI SHOHAG, *Jhenaidah*

A key bridge on the main road connecting at least six villages in Maharajpur and Kumrabaria unions of Jhenaidah Sadar upazila has remained without repairs since it collapsed a year ago, causing thousands of locals to suffer.

Movement of vehicles carrying passengers and agricultural produce has been severely disrupted along the route under the circumstances. People now have to use a makeshift bamboo bridge over the Begbati river on foot for their commute, often at much risk, especially for students of local educational institutions.

The 20-foot bridge over the river collapsed around July last year, but no step has been taken yet to repair it, said Rezaul Islam, a resident of Uttar Bhabanipur village.

"Villagers later built a bamboo footbridge, making the route passable only for pedestrians, while vehicles are forced to take long detours to reach their destinations," he added.

Jahidul Islam of the village said he now has to take his son to school, travelling two kilometres more using an alternative route, as the bamboo bridge is risky for children.

Rabi Joardar, a resident of Defalbari village, said transporting agricultural produce to local markets has become difficult with the bridge unrepaired. Farmers and local residents have to travel several kilometres more to transport jute, paddy and other goods using alternative routes, he added.

Contacted, Upazila Engineer Md Abul Kalam Azad said they were aware of the matter.

"We have included the bridge's renovation under three different project proposals. Whichever project receives approval first, the bridge will be constructed quickly under that project," he said.



Man carefully push their bicycles as a man carries his child across the vulnerable 20-foot bamboo footbridge over the Begbati river, linking at least six villages in Jhenaidah Sadar upazila.

PHOTO: **STAR**

COX'S BAZAR

Reassess road project, preserve sand dunes: BIP

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

The Bangladesh Institute of Planners (BIP) has expressed concern and protested against the alleged damage to sand dunes and the coastal environment caused by the construction of a coastal road from Sugandha Point to Sayeman Beach Resort in Cox's Bazar.

The road is being constructed under the Urban Development and Urban Governance Project, implemented by Cox's Bazar municipality with funding from the Japan International Cooperation Agency.

In a statement, BIP General Secretary Prof Mosleh Uddin Hasan said the sand dunes, coastal vegetation and natural sand layers along Cox's Bazar beach serve as natural barriers against waves, storms, tidal surges and coastal erosion, besides supporting coastal biodiversity.

Filling, levelling or removing dunes for road construction could damage the environment and biodiversity and weaken the coast's natural protection and climate resilience, BIP said.

Digital laws alone not enough, misuse must end

Say speakers

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Enacting or amending digital laws alone will not protect citizens' rights unless authorities prevent misuse, ensure accountability and hold technology platforms responsible for harms caused by their services, speakers said at a roundtable yesterday.

The discussion, titled "Roundtable on Digital Policies and Rights in Bangladesh", was organised by Tech Global Institute (TGI) and attended by policymakers, regulators, journalists, lawyers, researchers, civil society representatives and members of international organisations.

A TGI presentation pointed to weaknesses in the Cyber Protection Act, Bangladesh Telecommunication Act, Personal Data Protection Act and National Data Management Act.

Dr Iftekharuzzaman, executive director of Transparency International Bangladesh, said digital governance challenges involve three major actors -- the bureaucracy, politicians and technology platforms.

> Women reporting online harassment, revenge pornography, and blackmail often face reluctance from police, while complaints involving political figures receive faster responses.
>
> **LAWYER PRIYA AHSAN CHOWDHURY**

He said accountability becomes difficult when the same power structures accused of violating rights are also responsible for providing remedies. He also criticised selective law enforcement, citing swift police action in politically sensitive cases compared with delays in legitimate citizen complaints.

Kamal Ahmed, consulting editor of The Daily Star, said the focus should be on stopping misuse of existing laws. Referring to defamation cases, he said that although the Cyber Protection Act does not allow third parties to file such complaints, they are often accepted in practice, leading to arrests and denial of bail.

"Those who seek a public mandate must understand that it's a fair game. They will be criticised," Kamal said, adding that the right to criticise those seeking or holding political power is fundamental to democracy.

Lawyer Priya Ahsan Chowdhury warned that criminalising defamation or disinformation as cyber offences could threaten freedom of expression.

She said women reporting online harassment, revenge pornography and blackmail often face reluctance from police, while complaints involving political figures receive faster responses.

Cartoonist Mehedi Haque said restrictive laws risk creating a "scarecrow symptom", encouraging self-censorship.

SM Taifur Rahman, deputy director of BTRC, said the regulator does not disclose users' personal information or conduct surveillance.

National Curriculum and Textbook Board
69-70, Motijheel C/A, Dhaka-1000
www.nctb.gov.bd

Ref. No.: 37.06.0000.07.304.007.26/234 Date: 30/08/2026

Invitation for e-Tender (OTM)

This is to notify to all concerned tenderers that the following tenders have been published by National Curriculum and Textbook Board (NCTB) through the e-GP portal (www.eprocure.gov.bd) regarding textbook printing, binding and supplying Secondary Class-8 & 9 for the Academic Year 2027.

Tender Date and Time			
Tender/Proposal Closing/Opening:	14/09/2026; 16:00 PM	Tender Document last selling:	13/09/2026; 16:00 PM
Procuring Entity:	Member (Textbook), NCTB	Nature of e-Tender	NCT, Goods
Source of Fund:	GoB		

SL	Tender ID	SL	Tender ID	SL	Tender ID	SL	Tender ID	SL	Tender ID	SL	Tender ID
1	1325370	2	1325400	3	1325394	4	1325392	5	1325391	6	1325390
7	1325389	8	1325387	9	1325386	10	1325385	11	1325381	12	1325380
13	1325382	14	1325384	15	1325403	16	1325748	17	1325393	18	1325395
19	1325396	20	1325397	21	1325398	22	1325399				

Interested tenderers may visit www.eprocure.gov.bd website to get the details of the Tender. This is an online tender where only e-Tender will be accepted in the national e-GP portal and no offline/hard copy will be accepted. To submit e-tender, you are requested to go through the **www.eprocure.gov.bd** web portal.

30.8.2026
(Professor Shah Muhammad Firoz Al Ferdaus)
Secretary, NCTB
Phone: 2233-85644
Email: secretary@nctb.gov.bd

GD-2069

Man dies after falling into lift shaft

UNB, *Dhaka*

A retired schoolteacher died yesterday after falling into an empty elevator shaft of a building in Dhaka's Hazaribagh.

The deceased is Subhash Chandra Paul, 73, a former teacher of Dhanmondi Government Boys' High School. Subhash was rescued in critical condition and taken to Dhaka Medical College Hospital, where attending doctors declared him dead around 8:30am.

His son, Krishna Gopal Paul, said they lived in their own flat on the 7th floor of the under-construction building and that his father had gone out for his usual morning walk.

"This morning, construction workers at the building informed us about the accident. They and took him to the hospital, where he was pronounced dead."

DMCH police outpost in-charge Inspector Md Faruk said Hazaribagh police were investigating the incident.

CIVIL AVIATION AUTHORITY OF BANGLADESH
HEADQUARTERS, KURMITOLA, DHAKA-1229
OFFICE OF THE MEMBER (OPERATIONS & PLANNING)
AERODROMES AND FACILITATION BRANCH

Ref No: 30.31.0000.149.05.009(3).26/803 Date: 27/08/2026 AD

'LEASE TENDER NOTICE'

Tenders are hereby invited from interested individuals/privately owned institutions / organizations under the following terms and conditions for appointment of a lessee to remove and sell waste/garbage from Terminal-1 & 2 in order to maintain cleanliness inside (airside) Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport, under the Civil Aviation Authority of Bangladesh.

1.	Ministry / Division	Ministry of Civil Aviation and Tourism.
2.	Procuring Entity Name	Civil Aviation Authority of Bangladesh.
3.	Name of Work	Appointment of Lessee for removal and sale of waste/garbage from Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport of Civil Aviation Authority and for maintaining cleanliness inside the airport (Airside).
4.	Tender Package No.	01/2026
5.	Reference No. & Date of Invited Tender	30.31.0000.149.05.009(3).26 Date: 20/08/2026 AD
6.	Procurement Method	Open Tendering Method (OTM).
7.	Lease Period	Initially 01 (One) year from the date of handing over the lease location.
8.	Budget and Source of Fund	Not Applicable.
9.	Tender Publication Date	31/08/2026 AD
10.	Last Date & Time for Selling Tender Schedule	27/09/2026 AD Up to 04.00 PM
11.	Tender Opening Date & Time	28/09/2026 AD At 12.15 PM
12.	Tender Opening Date & Time	28/09/2026 AD At 12.15 PM
13.	Place of Tender Opening	Office Room of Deputy Director (ATM), CAAB Headquarters, Kurmitola, Dhaka. Tenders will be opened in the presence of tenderers or their representatives (if any are present).
14.	Name & Address of the Office Inviting, Receiving & Opening Tender	Office of the Deputy Director (ATM), CAAB Headquarters, Kurmitola, Dhaka.
15.	Place & Address for Selling Tender Schedule	1. Office of the Member (Operations & Planning), CAAB Headquarters, Kurmitola, Dhaka. 2. Office of the Chief Engineer, CAAB Headquarters, Kurmitola, Dhaka. 3. Finance and Accounts Division (7th Floor), CAAB Headquarters, Kurmitola, Dhaka. 4. Office of the Executive Director, HSIA, Kurmitola, Dhaka.
16.	Price of Tender Schedule	Tk. 2,000/- (Two Thousand) only.
17.	Amount of Tender Security	Security Deposit of Tk. 40,000,000/- (Forty Lakh) only in the form of Pay Order from any scheduled bank of Bangladesh must be submitted along with the tender in favor of Executive Director, Dhaka.
18.	Eligibility of Tenderer	Necessary documents in the name of the institution/individual must be submitted: a) Bank Solvency Certificate (Updated) must be attached with the tender. b) General work experience of 5 (five) years as a contractor firm and minimum 01 (one) year experience in related work in any Government / Semi-Government / Autonomous organization (Experience certificate must be submitted). c) Attested photocopy of updated Trade License. d) BIN (13-digit) Certificate. e) e-TIN Certificate. f) Updated Income Tax Clearance Certificate. g) Other documents as specified in the tender schedule.
19.	Special Instructions	The authority reserves the right to accept or reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason whatsoever.
20.	Other Terms & Conditions	a) Application for purchasing tender schedule must be made on the letterhead pad of respective organization/firm. b) Tender must be submitted writing the name of work clearly on the sealed envelope. c) Any defaulting lessee/allottee of the authority will be considered ineligible to participate in the tender. d) If the tender cannot be opened on the fixed date due to unavoidable reasons, it will be opened on the next working day at the same time and place. e) The authority reserves the right to accept or cancel any tender or part thereof or cancel all tenders without assigning any reason.

স্মারক নং-৩০.৩১.০০০০.০৫১.০৬.০০১.২৬/৪৯৮
তারিখ: ৩০/০৮/২০২৬ খ্রি.

27.08.2026
Mahmud Akhtar Hossain
Deputy Director (ATM)
Phone: 02-41091092
Civil Aviation Authority of Bangladesh

GD-2064

Women's voices in Nazrul's Dhumketu

From the inaugural issue, the presence of women writers is noticeable. Some women writers wrote a number of times, but there were at least ten women who wrote at least once. These included a ten- or eleven-year-old girl as well as a thirteen-year-old girl, the former Hindu and the latter Muslim. Sri Birajsundari Devi, Promila's aunt, whom Nazrul called "Ma", and who would help him break his fast at Hooghly Jail and to whom Nazrul later dedicated his book Sarbahara (1926), gave Nazrul her blessings in "Mayer Ashish" in the inaugural issue of Dhumketu. She also wrote a piece—"Nari Kalyan"—for the issue.

NIAZ ZAMAN

Dhumketu was a bi-weekly Bangla paper edited by Kazi Nazrul Islam. It started publication on 26 Sravan 1329/11 August 1922, in a four-page format, but later expanded to eight pages. Rabindranath's poem, hailing the launch of this paper, was used as an epigraph. The paper contained several of Nazrul's own writings—apart from the editorial—such as a reprinting of "Bidrohi" in the inaugural issue, the poem "Muharram" in the Muharram issue of 20 pages (1329/August 1922), and "Agamoni" and "Anandamoyeer Agamone" in the 9 Ashwin/26 September 1922 issue. The police raided the office of Dhumketu on 8 November, but Nazrul was not there. He was finally arrested on 23 January 1923 on charges of sedition. The paper dated 13 Magh 1329/27 January 1923 contained his "Rajbandi'r Jabanbandi", along with poems and pieces on him. Nazrul was jailed for a year, and the paper was suspended for a time. It appeared later under the editorship of Biren Sen Gupta and Amaresh Kanji Lal, but it did not have its earlier revolutionary fervour. It became irregular, and from March 1923, publication stopped.

Thanks to Selina Bahar Zaman, we have the facsimiles of the issues of Dhumketu. From this valuable collection, we realise that from the very beginning, the paper was not only meant to voice Nazrul's anti-British views but also to reveal his non-communal and non-gendered outlook.

The contributors to the paper included both Muslim and Hindu writers, male and female. The advertisement for Himani Snow on the cover of the inaugural issue—and in many subsequent issues—suggests that Nazrul expected the paper to be read by women as well as men. From the inaugural issue, the presence of women writers is noticeable. Some women writers wrote a number of times, but there were at least ten women who wrote at least once. These included a ten- or eleven-year-old girl as well as a thirteen-year-old girl, the former Hindu and the latter Muslim. Sri Birajsundari Devi, Promila's aunt, whom Nazrul called "Ma", and who would help him break his fast at Hooghly Jail and to whom Nazrul later dedicated his book Sarbahara (1926), gave Nazrul her blessings in "Mayer Ashish" in the inaugural issue of Dhumketu. She also wrote a piece—"Nari Kalyan"—for the issue. Masuda Rahman (1885–1926) wrote several times—always appearing as Mrs M. Rahman; Roquiah Sakhawat Hossein (1880–1932)—writing as Mrs R. S. Hossein—contributed an excerpt from an essay and a poem.



Roquiah Sakhawat Hossein (1880-1932)

Roquiah Sakhawat Hossein was born and brought up in a conservative Muslim family in Pairaband, Rangpur. Forbidden to read and write Bangla or English as a child, she managed to learn both so well that she could write fluently in both. For women of her generation, she was a beacon of light, extolling the importance of education in improving the lives of women. Roquiah Sakhawat Hossein was greatly helped by her brother and later by her husband, Sakhawat Hossein, in learning how to read and write in both Bangla and English.

Knowing her passion for education, Sakhawat Hossein left her a considerable sum of money to start a school. Five months after her husband passed away on 3 May 1909, she started a school in his name at Bhagalpur, where she was residing at the time. However, she was unable to continue living there and moved to Kolkata, where, two years later, on 16 March 1911, she restarted Sakhawat Memorial School at 13 Wellesley Lane. At the time of her death on 9 December 1932, there were more than 100 girls studying at the school.

Apart from teaching, she also wrote, in Bangla and English, in Kolkata magazines about her concerns for women, about purdah, and about her school. Roquiah's first publication was not in Bangla but in English. Her story, "Sultana's Dream", for which she is well known internationally today, appeared in the Indian Ladies Magazine (Madras) in 1905. Three years later, her Bangla translation of this story came out in book form from S. K. Lahiri and Co., Kolkata.

Perhaps the earliest Bangla essay of hers to be published was "Pipasha" (Thirst). This piece about Muharram was published in Nabaprabha in Falgun 1308 (mid-February to mid-March 1902). She also wrote in other journals such as Mahila, Nabanur, Bharat Mahila, Al-Eslam, Bangiya Mussulman Sahitya Patrika, Saogat, Sadhana, Naoroz, Mohammadi, Sahityik, Sabujpatra, Muezzin, Bangalakshmi, Gulistan, and Mah-e-Nau. It is not known whether Nazrul and Roquiah ever met in person, though in Nazrul's novel Bandhon Hara (published serially in Moslem Bharat from 1921), many of the sentiments voiced by the women letter writers seem to presage what Roquiah would later say in her essay "Subah Sadek" in Muezzin (Asharh–Sravan 1337/mid-July–mid-August 1930).

A sizable extract from Roquiah's essay "Pipasha" is included in the Muharram issue of Dhumketu. A poem of hers, "Nirupam Bir", was also published in Dhumketu that year. In "Pipasha", she reflects on the plight of the group of warriors, women, and children accompanying Hazrat Imam Hossain on his tragic journey to Karbala. In an age when copyright was not taken seriously and essays, stories, and poems were freely published in different journals, it is not clear whether Nazrul took permission from Roquiah to republish this piece. Though the essay is about Muharram, the piece is divided into two sections, with the second part describing the grief after a loved one died without having a last sip of water. Dhumketu included only the first part, in which the focus is on the tragedy of Karbala.

The only other piece by Roquiah to appear in Dhumketu was a poem, "Nirupam Bir" (The Dauntless Warrior), published on 5 Ashwin 1329/22 September 1922. Unlike "Pipasha", the poem does not seem to have been published before.

"Nirupam Bir" is a remarkable poem from a woman who has been called an "Islamic Feminist". The 1 Bhadra 1329/18 August 1922 issue of Dhumketu had published a photograph of the revolutionary Kanailal Dutt (1888–1908). Perhaps this inspired Roquiah to write the poem. Kanailal was a revolutionary belonging to the Jugantor Group. Arrested with a number of other revolutionaries, he was imprisoned in Alipore Jail. There, along with another revolutionary, he succeeded in assassinating Narendranath Goswami, a government approver. Kanailal was hanged on 31 August 1908. He was the second revolutionary to be hanged by the British after Khudiram Bose—whose picture also appeared in Dhumketu.



Kazi Nazrul Islam in Sitakunda, Chittagong District, in 1929.

In her poem, Roquiah eulogises Kanai as the dauntless warrior. The poem begins with the magistrate ordering Kanai to be hanged. But Kanai—addressed here as Shyam, another name for Krishna—laughs. The one who willingly sacrifices his life does not fear hanging. "Moriya Kanai hobe omor/Shadhyo ki bodhe tarey?" By dying, Kanai will become immortal. Who can slay him? The poem ends with a strident call: "Bolo bolo 'Bande Shyam'", Proclaim, proclaim, "Long Live Shyam". It was a very brave piece of writing by Roquiah, the widow of an official who had served the British and the founder of a school for Muslim girls.

Unlike Roquiah, who appeared only twice in Dhumketu, Mrs M. Rahman appears frequently. Her first name was Masuda, but she wrote as Mrs M. Rahman for Dhumketu.

Masuda Rahman was the daughter of Hooghly's Public Prosecutor, Khan Bahadur Mazharul Anwar Chowdhury. Apart from learning how to read the Quran, she learned some Bangla and Urdu at home. At the age of eleven, she was married to Kazi Mahmudur Rahman, Zamindar of Furfura, who was at the time Registrar of Calcutta. Her early marriage did not deter her from following her own interests. She wrote essays and also a novel, Ma O Meye.

It is not known how Masuda Rahman met Kazi Nazrul Islam, but Professor Rafiqul Islam says she treated "Nazrul like a son". (Nazrul had been estranged from his mother for some time. Perhaps the longing for a mother led him to call Mrs M. Rahman and Birajsundari Devi "Ma". He would dedicate two of his books to them.)

Mrs M. Rahman played a prominent part in Nazrul's marriage. Nazrul had fallen in love with a girl named Ashalata—whom he would rename Promila after their marriage—and brought both Ashalata and her mother, Giribala, to Kolkata in 1924. Nazrul was 23, Ashalata just 16. There were obvious difficulties in this marriage between a Muslim man and a young girl of a different faith. It was Mrs M. Rahman who organised the wedding, which took place on 25 April 1924, according to Muslim rites, though Ashalata did not change her religion. Seven years later, Nazrul dedicated his book Bisher Banshi to Mrs M. Rahman:

Fiery serpent girl of Bengal, the pride of Muslim women
The manifestation of my mother on Earth,
Mrs M. Rahman sahiba,
I lay this at your feet.
(Translated by Nashid Kamal)

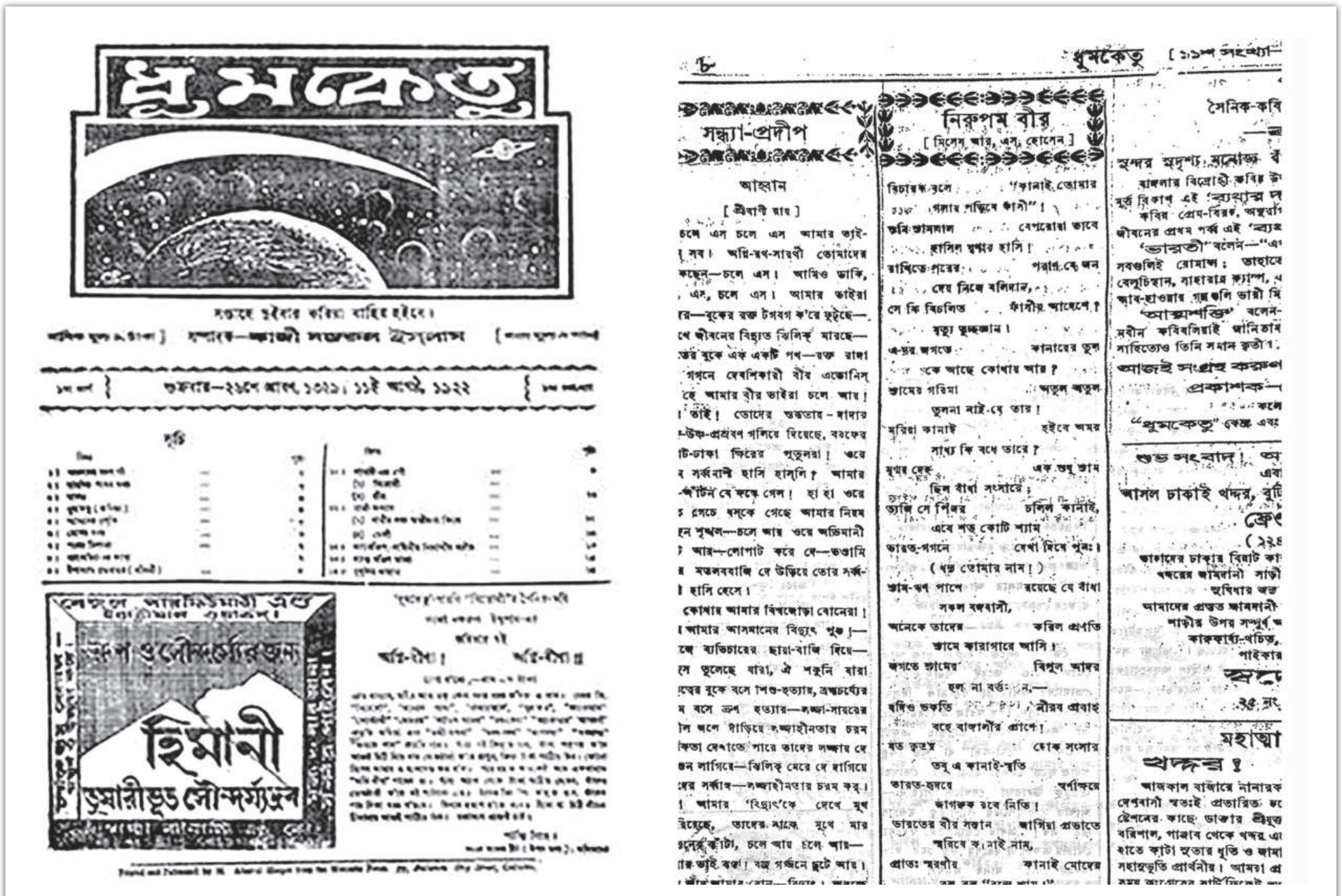
Before Mrs M. Rahman got involved in Nazrul's personal life, she was publishing frequently in Dhumketu. In fact, in the 29 Agrahayan 1329/15 December 1922 issue of Dhumketu, her name and the title of her piece are prominently displayed on the cover of the magazine. In the Muharram issue of Dhumketu, in which Roquiah's "Pipasha" also appeared, she wrote an essay titled "Amader Abhab Abhijog" for the section "Sandhya Pradeep". In this piece, she points out that women are not weak and that they do not always need the support of a tree like a weak vine. They want freedom and independence.

In an earlier issue of Dhumketu, she wrote "Amader Swarup" for "Sandhya Pradeep", calling upon women to awaken. She writes that the call to awaken is everywhere and quotes lines from a poet, Parimal Kumar, who calls upon the sisters and mothers of Bengal to awaken. A few paragraphs later, she reminds women that they have a lot of work to do: "Narir sharthak korar sahasra poth achhey. Bibaho chharao korbar kaj achhey." There are many ways to make women feel fulfilled. Apart from getting married, there are many things for women to do. In "Panch Mishali" in the 21 Kartik 1329/31 October 1922 issue of Dhumketu, she begins by saying she is out of sorts and therefore will provide some humorous anecdotes.

Apart from Mrs M. Rahman, other women also wrote for the column "Sandhya Pradeep". In the 14 Kartik 1329/31 October 1922 issue of Dhumketu, Sri Mahamaya Debi wrote an essay titled "Narir Mukti Kon Pothe". This essay was continued in the 1 Agrayahan 1329/17 November issue of Dhumketu in the same column, along with two other essays by Srimati Nonibala Debi ("Boneder Kotha") and Charushila Mitra ("Narir Sarthakotha Kisher"). In the 26 Agrahayan/12 December issue, Srimati Saktibala wrote a poem, "Boner Dabi", which begins with the lines "Mukti dao/Mukti dao/Supti dao/Bhai tora." The second stanza reads: "Swadhinatao dao/Dao go dao/Dao go dao/Pran bhora."

Srimati Nalini Basu and Srimati Chanchala Debi wrote "Mayer Bodhon" under "Sandhya Pradeep" in the issue of 30 Ashwin 1329/17 October 1922, welcoming the goddess Durga. Young girls, Hindu and Muslim, were also writing. Srilila Mitra, who was ten or eleven years old, wrote two poems: "Bangali"—"Ay, ay/Chhute ay/Ay tora/Bangali"—in the 26 Ashwin/13 October issue of Dhumketu and "Khun-Khoshroj" in the 30 Ashwin/17 October issue. Rizia Begum, the thirteen-year-old daughter of Abdur Rahim of Noakhali, also contributed a poem titled "Arab" in the 14 Kartik/31 October issue of Dhumketu. Srisarashibala Basu wrote the poem "Bhai-Phonta" in the 3 Kartik/20 October issue of Dhumketu.

Generally, Nazrul alone is associated with Dhumketu, but, as seen from these examples, women too were writing for the paper. And, if the ad for Himani Snow—which appeared on the cover of the inaugural issue of Dhumketu and continued to appear in other issues as well—suggests the desire of women to beautify themselves for men, it also stresses that the paper was meant for women readers, not only men. Significantly, the women writers who wrote for Dhumketu not only demanded rights for women, but were also inspired by Nazrul's revolutionary fervour to call upon men and women alike to rise against the British and demand freedom.



(L) Front page of the first issue of Dhumketu, published on August 11, 1922. (R) Roquiah Sakhawat Hossein's poem "Nirupam Bir", as published in Dhumketu on September 22, 1922.

Niaz Zaman is a retired academic, writer, and translator.

Star
DHAKA MONDAY AUGUST 31, 2026, BHADRA 16, 1433 BS

SPORT

What to WATCH

SONY SPORTS 2
England vs Pakistan
2nd Test, Day 5
Live from 4:00 pm

SONY SPORTS 1
Women's Asia Cup
Bangladesh vs Indonesia
Live from 8:30 pm

RAJDHANI TV
English Premier League
Aston Villa vs Arsenal
Live from 1:00 am (Tuesday)

T SPORTS
LaLiga
Barcelona vs Rayo Vallecano
Live from 1:30 am (Tuesday)



Border Guard Bangladesh's (BGB) Saiful Islam (red) attempts a counter-kick after blocking a strike from Bangladesh Army's Mohammad Eliash (blue) on the concluding day of the 5th Federation Cup Taekwondo competition at the National Sports Council Gymnasium in Paltan yesterday. Bangladesh Army and BGB dominated the competition, which featured around 450 male and female athletes from 18 district sports associations and services teams.

PHOTO: FIROZ AHMED

Cricketers satisfied with BCB's BPL explanation

SPORTS REPORTER

The much-awaited meeting between the Cricketers Welfare Association of Bangladesh (CWAB) and the Bangladesh Cricket Board (BCB) took place at the board premises yesterday, with cricketer Nasir Hossain saying afterwards that the players had been informed the Bangladesh Premier League (BPL) would not take place this season.

Nasir, who was banned from all forms of cricket in 2024 before returning to cricket last year, represented the cricketers and CWAB during the media briefing following the meeting.

"BPL is not happening, that's mostly certain. The cricket board talked to us and we are certain that the BPL is not taking place this time," Nasir told reporters after the meeting with the BCB.

Players have proposed organising a new tournament during the BPL window to compensate for their potential loss of income.

"We wanted a tournament during the one-and-a-half month BPL [window]. But it has not been decided whether a tournament will take place," he said, adding that further discussions with the BCB would take place.

One player told The Daily Star that both the cricketers and the BCB had put forward proposals, although nothing had been finalised. With players set to suffer financially in the absence of a major tournament such as the BPL, the cricketer said the NCL T20 was the most likely alternative to be held during the BPL window, given the difficulty of introducing a new tournament into an already packed schedule.

Nasir said the cricketers were satisfied with the discussions and the BCB's explanation.

"The board has explained well why the BPL is not taking place. We are discussing what can take place in BPL's place since without BPL, the players will face a financial crisis. We discussed what the board can do [for compensation]."

Who are really running BFF camps?

ATIQUE ANAM

Something is not quite right with the way the Bangladesh Football Federation is running its national team camps. The latest example is the senior team's management, where a change of manager was made two days after the camp had started.

The BFF announced on Sunday that Amirul Islam Babu was appointed as team manager for the senior national team, which is preparing for next month's FIFA ASEAN Cup. Amer Khan, who had overseen the first two days of the camp, was retained as team coordinator, while another executive committee member, Iqbal Hossain, was appointed team leader.

The timing of the announcement is unusual. Managerial appointments are generally settled before a camp begins, particularly when a team is preparing for an international tournament. The decision to change the manager after the first two days naturally raises questions about what prompted it.



Several BFF executive committee members had reportedly shown interest in the manager's position. One of those who had been in the running told The Daily Star that Amer had initially been expected to continue before pressure from a particular quarter led to Babu's appointment. There has been similar talk within football circles about Babu receiving backing from influential figures associated with Mohammedan Sporting Club.

Babu's appointment also marks a return to the practice of a non-footballer member rather than a former footballer manage the national team. He previously held the position during the 2015 SAFF Championship and is currently chairman of the BFF's media committee.

The bigger issue, however, is not simply who has been appointed manager. It is the growing presence of federation officials around the national teams as the coaches are becoming increasingly distant from public view.

Thomas Dooley has had no interaction with the media since the senior team's camp began. Apart from photographs from closed-door training sessions released by the federation, there have been no interviews with the head coach or players. This is different from the recent practice, when national team camps routinely included media sessions with both.

That matters because Dooley himself raised concerns about the team's preparations on August 15. He spoke about the limited preparation time caused by uncertainty over the start of the domestic season.

The Under-20 national team presents a similar picture.

Bangladesh's U-20 side is currently in Uzbekistan for the AFC U-20 Asian Cup qualifiers, with their opening match against the hosts scheduled for today. Yet coach Gerard Jones has remained largely away from the media, following on from a bizarre pre-departure press conference where neither the coach nor any player was present. Instead, it was manager Sameed Quasem, and BFF technical director Saiful Bari Titu, who spoke to journalists.

Quasem's role in the youth set-up has also attracted attention. He was involved in the appointment of Jones, as well as his predecessor Mark Cox. Cox's tenure ended with success on the field but controversy over his coaching credential. Jones has since been involved in a series of disputes, including a scuffle with assistant coach Atiqur Rahman Meshu. The circumstances surrounding the U-20 team's preparations have added to the sense of instability around the programme.

Taken together, the developments around the two camps point to shortcomings in the way Bangladesh's national teams are being managed. They raise the fundamental question over whether key personnel decisions are being made primarily on merit and suitability for the role, or whether outside influences are having a say in appointments. For teams preparing for international competitions, such uncertainty does little to create the professional and cohesive environment needed for proper preparation.



HAMZA set for Sheffield Utd return

STAR SPORTS DESK

Bangladesh star midfielder Hamza Choudhury is closing in on a permanent move to Championship side Sheffield United, according to English media reports on Sunday.

Hamza currently plays for Leicester City, who were relegated to League One -- the third division of English football. The 28-year-old was reportedly on his way to Derby County, also in the Championship, before Sheffield United seemingly hijacked the deal to bring the midfielder to Bramall Lane on a free transfer for a second stint.

> The move would bring an end to Hamza's more than decade-long journey at the King Power Stadium. He joined Leicester City's youth setup in 2014 and went on to win the FA Cup in 2021, the FA Community Shield in 2021, and the EFL Championship title in the 2023-24 season.

Hamza previously spent the second half of the 2024/25 season on loan at Sheffield United, helping the Blades reach the Championship playoff final.

Sheffield United moved for Hamza following an injury to right-back Femi Seriki. The midfielder played in the same position during his loan spell at the club. Hamza is now undergoing a medical and will then finalise the paperwork on his contract, according to reports.

If everything goes smoothly, Hamza could be available for Tuesday night's match against Bolton, which kicks off just a few hours before the transfer deadline expires.

It has been a downward spiral for 2016 Premier League champions Leicester City, who have dropped into League One after successive relegations and have been keen to offload Hamza's wages.

The move would bring an end to Hamza's more than decade-long journey at the King Power Stadium. He joined Leicester City's youth setup in 2014 and went on to win the FA Cup in 2021, the FA Community Shield -- also known as the English Super Cup -- in 2021, and the EFL Championship title in the 2023-24 season.

U-20s TARGET Uzbek upset

SPORTS REPORTER

Bangladesh's bid to qualify for the AFC U-20 Asian Cup finals faces its biggest test when the men in red and green take on 2023 champions Uzbekistan in their Group B qualifying opener at Do'stlik Stadium in Tashkent tonight.

The match kicks off at 8:00pm, after former champions Syria and India face each other at the same venue in the day's first match.

Bangladesh have not qualified for the final round of the AFC youth competition since 2002. But the SAFF U-20 champions are dreaming of reaching the finals for the seventh time under English coach Gerard Jones, who has overseen nine weeks of preparation involving local players and four overseas recruits.

Hosts Uzbekistan, however, will pose a formidable challenge for Bangladesh, who will look to their overseas contingent, including centre-back Zidane Yousuf, forward Adam Abbas and striker Mohammed Mahe Khan.

Jones is confident his side can exploit Uzbekistan's weaknesses and spring a surprise.

"We know Uzbekistan will be a good opponent. They're going to keep the ball well. They're going to look to counter-press quickly. They're going to want to press high," Jones said at an official press conference yesterday.

But Jones said they are ready to exploit their weakness.

"We also know where they're weak, and we're looking to exploit those weaknesses," he added.

"We've got an identity of how we want to outrun, outfight, out-think, outplay, and outscore the opponent. And that's been since day one, and the players have bought into that."

"So, I feel very confident," the British coach concluded.

Tigresses begin Asia Cup quest

SPORTS REPORTER

Bangladesh women's team will begin their Women's T20 Asia Cup campaign against Indonesia in a Group B fixture at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium today.

The Tigresses have not reached the final since winning their only title in 2018, and captain Nigar Sultana Joty said their target this time is to go all the way to the summit clash.

Bangladesh reached the semifinals in the last edition and will be looking to start this campaign on a winning note.

"We have taken our preparations. We have been reaching semis and returning home recently, so definitely our target is to make the finals," Joty said at the captains' meeting ahead of the tournament.

Bangladesh will face Sri Lanka and the UAE in their remaining Group B matches on September 6 and 8, respectively.

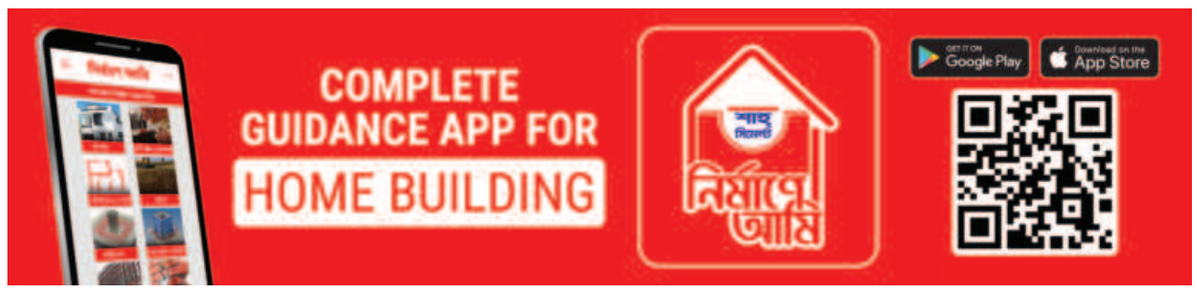


CHELSEA ON A ROLL

Chelsea made it two wins from two in the Premier League with another thriller, edging Brighton 4-3 at home yesterday. In the picture, Cole Palmer celebrates his fourth goal with teammates. All the members of Chelsea's front three were again involved, with Joao Pedro scoring once and setting up Palmer's left-footed curler from outside the box, while Morgan Rogers provided for Pedro. Romeo Lavia scored the other. The win extended Xabi Alonso's perfect start, but Chelsea face a sterner test away to reigning champions Arsenal next Sunday.

PHOTO: AFP





Pay scale to balance budget and inflation

Proposals may be placed before cabinet today

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

The finance ministry may recommend implementing the new pay scale for government officials and employees in four phases over two fiscal years to ease pressure on inflation and the budget.

The recommendations are set to be placed before the cabinet today for approval.

According to sources in the ministry, the phased implementation strategy is being adopted based on high-level government discussions.

The government is taking this approach to strike an acceptable balance between meeting the expectations of government employees and managing the economic pressures arising from the US war on Iran.

In a recent interview with The Daily Star, Finance Minister Amir Khosru Mahmud Chowdhury said the government would implement the pay scale in a staggered manner, as the revenue space has narrowed significantly due to the huge volume of imports.

Under this plan, 30 percent of the basic salary will be implemented retroactively

SEE PAGE 8 COL 4



Vendors occupy the footpath and spill onto the road in front of Tejgaon College in the capital, leaving pedestrians with little room to move through the crowded stretch. The photo was taken yesterday.

PHOTO: ANISUR RAHMAN

SCHOOLTEACHER DEATH

RAB arrests two suspects

Seized motorbike colour raises questions

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

RAB has arrested two suspects in connection with the death of 56-year-old headteacher Ronjila Parvin, who died after falling from a moving auto-rickshaw when a mugger snatched her bag in front of the South Plaza of Jatiya Sangsad Bhaban.

RAB also claimed that it seized a Yamaha R15 used by the suspects.

RAB-2 Commanding Officer Naimul Hasan, additional deputy inspector general of police, yesterday disclosed the developments at a press briefing at its headquarters in Mohammadpur.

He said that with the help of intelligence and technology, prime suspect Mosharraf and his associate Cedric were arrested at the capital's Purba Tejturi Bazar area. Mosharraf has 13 cases, including drug, theft, and burglary cases filed against him, he added.

The RAB officer said the bike used in the mugging belongs to one Rakib, who has been detained for questioning. However, the vehicle was in the possession of Mosharraf on the day of the incident, he added.

RAB claimed that the victim's husband, Abdul Motin, confirmed that the vehicle was used in the incident.



Ronjila Parvin

A murder case was filed with Sher-e-Bangla Nagar Police Station.

However, the bike's colour was in question.

After the briefing, the two arrestees were paraded before the media. At that time, Mosharraf shouted, saying that he was not involved in the incident.

Insisting that the colour of his bike did not match that of the one used in the mugging, Mosharraf said his bike was black and white, whereas the vehicle seen during the mugging was blue. He urged reporters to investigate the matter before RAB personnel swiftly took him away.

Meanwhile, CCTV footage of the incident released by various media outlets showed two fleeing on a motorcycle. Although the footage was unclear, the motorcycle appeared to be blue and was seen on the road in front of the South Plaza of the Sangsad Bhaban.

A photograph of the seized bike provided to the media showed a black-and-white vehicle.

RAB officer Naimul told The Daily Star, "We have also seen the footage released by media outlets. The footage is not clear. Sometimes, due to poor image quality or camera limitations, a motorcycle may appear to be a different colour. However, the victim's husband, who witnessed the incident, confirmed that the seized bike was used in the mugging."

Victim Ronjila, headteacher of Bagbari Girls' Government Primary School in Bogura, arrived at Gabtali Bus Terminal in Dhaka early Saturday. From there, she and her husband took a rickshaw towards Ispahani Islamia Eye Institute and Hospital in the Farmgate area to consult doctors.

NO SILENCE

in Dhaka's silent zones

Noise levels remain far above permissible limits despite tougher rules



AI ASSISTED ILLUSTRATION

Many vehicles use high-decibel hydraulic horns despite restrictions

New rules allow police officers to impose on-the-spot fines

Traffic police cite manpower shortage as a major obstacle to effective enforcement

Police are exploring technologies that automatically identify noisy vehicles

Experts call for greater public awareness, community participation

TAMANNA YESMIN MARIA

Despite new stricter regulations to curb noise pollution, all nine designated silent zones in Dhaka city remain exposed to relentless honking from all types of vehicles, with many using high-decibel hydraulic horns.

Last year, the interim government introduced the Noise Pollution (Control) Rules, 2025, expanding the scope of enforcement and regulations on import, production, storage and sale of illegal horns.

The new rules allow traffic police officers of the rank of sergeant and above to impose on-the-spot fines. Under the previous 2006 rules, only magistrates held such enforcement powers.

The use of prohibited horns can result in up to three months' imprisonment or a fine of up to Tk 10,000, or both. The rules impose heavier penalties on those who manufacture, import or market prohibited horns, with offenders facing up to two years' imprisonment, or a fine of up to Tk 2 lakh, or both.

Yet, nothing appears to have changed.

Even in the designated silent zones, relentless noise has become part of daily life for commuters and residents.

For example, the sound of horns rarely stops outside Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport, though a three-kilometre area surrounding the airport was declared a silent zone by the Department of Environment (DoE) in December 2024.

The DoE also designated the Secretariat and its surrounding area, Agargaon, and areas around the parliament and the Prime Minister's Office as silent zones, while Dhaka North City Corporation (DNCC) declared Gulshan, Banani, Baridhara and Niketan as silent zones in September 2025.

Research shows that at least four of the city's silent zones have noise levels far above the permissible limits.

In March 2022, a 10-member team from the Centre for Atmospheric Pollution Studies (CAPS) at Stamford University Bangladesh found that the combined average noise level in four silent zones -- the Secretariat, Agargaon, and areas around the parliament and the PMO -- was 97.63 decibels, nearly double the permissible limit of 50 decibels.

The Secretariat averaged 100.17 decibels, with noise peaking at 127 decibels. The parliament area averaged 99.35 decibels, while Agargaon -- the quietest of the four areas -- averaged 78.11 decibels.

In 2024, CAPS carried out a follow-up assessment of the newly designated silent zone around Dhaka airport. It collected data over 15 days, monitoring the area for 13 hours

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ENFORCED DISAPPEARANCE

SMS records suggest victim was being tracked

ZYMA ISLAM

For seven years, Anisha Islam Insha had stood on city pavements holding a photo of her father at every protest arranged by rights organisations working on enforced disappearances.

Her father, Ismail Hossain, was a timber trader who went missing from Dhaka on June 19, 2019, when Insha was only 13 years old.

Every year since then, she braved the wrath of the very state that had allegedly abducted her father, got bodily jostled by law enforcement and even had her megaphone snatched away by the police at a time when she was only a child.

After the Sheikh Hasina government fell on August 5, 2024, Insha bravely walked up to the Directorate General Forces Intelligence Headquarters the very next day and demanded that they return her father, who was a member of Zia Parishad, a pro-BNP organisation.



Ismail Hossain

But Insha's father was not there. The day after the protest, the security forces informed the protesters that they had released everyone in their custody. Insha was taken to square one, wondering where her father was.

"I spent years trying to make people believe that my father was not just missing, that he had not just left us, that he was forcibly disappeared," Insha, now 20, told The Daily Star.

One potential breakthrough came this year when investigators at the International Crimes Tribunal found the Call Detail Records (CDR) of her father weeks before his disappearance.

Investigators and technology experts say the messages Ismail received resemble "trigger SMSs", indicating that he was under surveillance.

A CDR is a log generated by a telecommunications operator that records the technical details of communications. It includes calling and receiving numbers, the date and time of the communication, the duration, the type of service used (voice call, SMS, or data session), and

SEE PAGE 8 COL 4

Bismillahir Rahmanir Rahim

16th Death Anniversary



Today is the 16th death anniversary of **Late Alhaj Giashuddin Ahmed**. On this day of remembrance, we, the family members, directors, officers and employees of **Popular Jute Exchange Limited**, as well as other sister concerns, fondly recall the memories of his industrious & benevolent life and pray for the salvation and eternal peace of his departed soul

Late Alhaj Giashuddin Ahmed

POPULAR JUTE EXCHANGE LIMITED
1, Tolaram Road, Narayangonj, Bangladesh



THE LONG HAUL

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THE WHEELS TURNING
Bangladesh's economy

From ageing Bedfords to app-booked fleets and electric delivery vans, Bangladesh's trucking industry has changed with the economy it serves. Yet financing gaps, old vehicles, weak safety enforcement and charging constraints will shape how efficiently its next stage unfolds.

RUDRO ROBIN RAYHAN

Everything around us—from the food on our tables and the clothes we wear to the materials used to build our cities—has, at some point, travelled on a truck.

Often overlooked, trucking is the circulatory system of the economy. Over the past two decades, Bangladesh's industry has moved from a largely fragmented, informal sector towards a more organised and technology-enabled backbone of national logistics. The broader freight and logistics market was valued at an estimated $31.97 billion in 2025, while road transport carries roughly 70% to 80% of inland freight.

FROM BEDFORD TO A NEW GENERATION

Bangladesh's trucking story has deep roots. British-built Bedford TJ and TK trucks became widely used from the late 1950s. Their rugged construction suited difficult roads, and the yellow flatbed Bedford became a familiar symbol of commercial transport. Surviving models are now mostly seen hauling bricks at night—a reminder of how far the fleet has changed.

The market now ranges from 700-kilogram pickups for small consignments to heavy-duty trucks capable of carrying up to 50 tonnes. That breadth reflects Bangladesh's transition from an agriculture-led economy towards manufacturing, exports and mass consumption. It has also created distinct vehicle segments, each shaped by payload, route, fuel cost and the urgency of delivery.

A MARKET TRANSFORMED

The commercial vehicle market more than doubled in value from Tk 2,000 crore in 2010 to Tk 4,400 crore in 2021. High import duties encouraged a shift from completely built-up vehicles towards completely knocked-down kits and local assembly. The market remains concentrated: Nitol-Niloy Group's Tata brand was reported to hold a 31% share in 2023, while IFAD assembles Ashok Leyland vehicles at Dhamrai. Runner, Akij Motors, Rangs Group and Energypac represent other major brands and partnerships.

The rise of light commercial vehicles was another turning point. Commercial transport had traditionally meant trucks carrying one tonne or more. Smaller Japanese pickups and vans were available, but larger engines and fully built imports kept prices relatively high.

The Tata Ace, launched in 2005, demonstrated demand for a compact, lower-cost workhorse and opened the market to a new class of micro-entrepreneurs. Rivals soon followed. By 2021, vehicles below six tonnes represented an estimated Tk 1,200 crore market and about 45% of commercial vehicle sales, with roughly 11,000 units sold annually. Industry estimates suggest light commercial vehicles accounted for half of the 20,000 new trucks sold in 2023.

SEE PAGE S2

ILLUSTRATION: **TANVIR MALEK**

ACI Motors

FOTON

EMPOWERING THE TRUST OF
6,000+
CUSTOMERS

Free
Registration, Insurance, VTS
6 Services

Intsant Cash and Flexible Installment Facility

Nationwide Genuine Spare Parts & Service Network

Foton's outstanding service centers value my urgency. The pickup's long body can carry twice as many loads, which gives my business a boost. It's comfortable and advanced Cabin ensure the driver reliefs. I eagerly recommend Foton Pickup to other business owners.

Bilal Hossain Khan
Chandpur

Popular Model- 1 Ton, 1.2 Ton , 1.5 Ton & 3Ton

Scan for More Details

New Addition

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The wheels turning Bangladesh's economy

FROM PAGE S1

THE CREDIT CONUNDRUM

Financing remains one of the industry's hardest constraints. With formal bank credit difficult to obtain, distributors have increasingly acted as lenders. Seasonal downturns can then translate into missed instalments, bad debts and repossessions, placing pressure on both buyers and vehicle companies.

External shocks amplify that risk. In 2022, higher fuel costs, dollar shortages and import restrictions contributed to a 22% fall in sales. BRTA truck registrations declined from 5,789 units in 2021 to 4,528 in 2022. Even when demand exists, high interest rates and documentation requirements can leave small operators unable to finance a vehicle on sustainable terms.

TECHNOLOGY TAKES THE WHEEL

Digital platforms are beginning to dismantle the traditional truck-stand model by connecting shippers directly with vehicle owners. These services promise faster matching, clearer pricing and better fleet utilisation, while telematics can help operators monitor routes, fuel use, idling and maintenance needs.

Truck Lagbe, founded in 2017, says its network includes more than 80,000 registered trucks and 150,000 customers. Lalamove, Loop Freight and Goods in Motion have also introduced digital booking, fleet-management and freight services. Functioning loosely as ride-hailing platforms for trucks and pickups, they serve both one-off users and recurring commercial clients.

THE GREEN TRUCK ARRIVES

Electric mobility is emerging as the next frontier. In June 2026, the government waived import tariffs on electric buses and trucks through June 2030, alongside a stated ambition to move 30% of trucks towards electric power. A month later, RangsX delivered 18 electric vans to DHL Express, described as Bangladesh's first commercial corporate EV fleet.

E-commerce and pharmaceutical companies are natural early adopters because last-mile vehicles often follow predictable routes and return to a depot. Lower fuel and maintenance costs could strengthen the business case. High purchase prices, limited charging infrastructure, battery range and resale uncertainty, however, remain substantial barriers.

THE ROAD AHEAD

The industry's most visible challenge is the age of its fleet. According to the Bangladesh Road Transport Authority, at least 38,123 registered highway trucks are beyond the 25-year operational threshold. Older vehicles raise questions about emissions, braking, reliability and the economics of maintenance. Driver fatigue and loosely enforced working hours add another layer of road-safety risk.

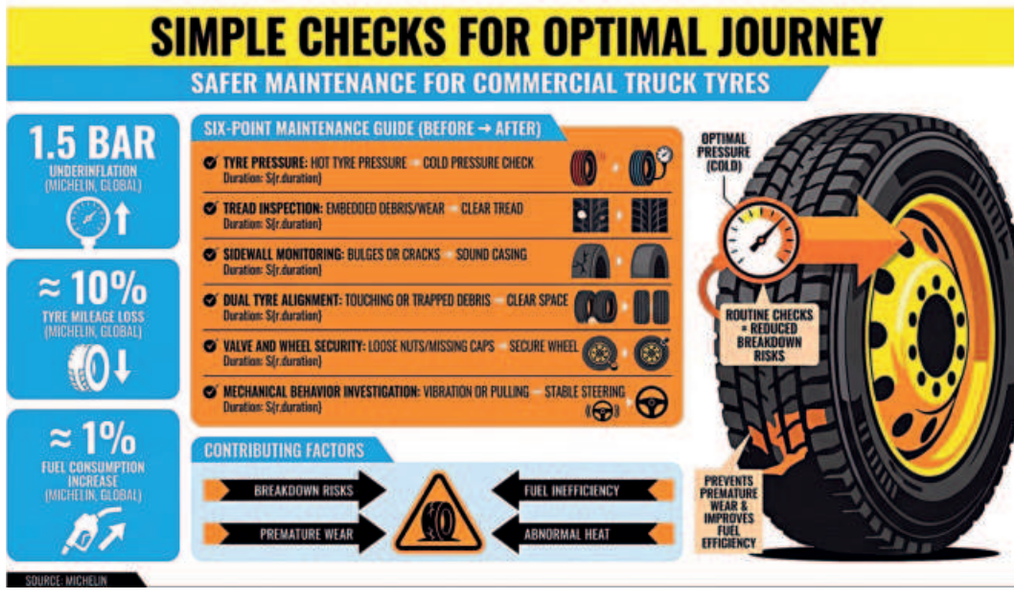
The National Logistics Policy points towards multimodal infrastructure, stronger safety standards, formal financing and EV charging networks. Its effect will depend on implementation: whether financing becomes accessible to small operators, fleet-renewal rules are enforceable, digital systems reach beyond large companies and charging capacity grows outside the major cities.

The next challenge is therefore not simply to put more trucks on the road. It is to make every truck more productive, every journey more predictable and every kilometre safer and more sustainable.

BEFORE THE WHEELS TURN

A truck's tyres carry far more than the weight of the vehicle and its cargo. They also affect braking, steering stability, fuel consumption and the likelihood of an unexpected roadside breakdown. Yet tyre problems often develop gradually, beginning with a small pressure loss, uneven wear or damage hidden between a pair of dual tyres.

Heavy loads, long journeys, high road temperatures and rough surfaces make regular inspection particularly important for commercial vehicles. Incorrect inflation can generate excessive heat, weaken the casing and shorten tyre life, while cuts, bulges and embedded objects may signal a more immediate danger. A brief check before departure can therefore protect the driver, the cargo and other road users while reducing downtime and replacement costs. The following six-point inspection provides a practical starting routine for every journey.



Policy and technology are reshaping commercial vehicles

RUNNER MOTORS LIMITED



> Prompt after-sales service is essential in this business. Nearby service and parts availability are critical to reducing downtime.

MD FEROZ KABIR, Senior General Manager, Marketing and Sales, Runner Motors Limited

Runner Motors Limited is expanding its highway service network and digital fleet tools as Bangladesh's logistics market changes. Md Feroz Kabir, Senior General Manager of Marketing and Sales at Runner Motors Ltd, discusses the policies shaping demand, vehicle financing, local sourcing and fleet technology in an interview with The Daily Star.

The Daily Star (TDS): *Where are you currently seeing the strongest demand in Bangladesh's commercial vehicle market?*
Md Feroz Kabir (FK): The below-one-ton segment remains the largest because these vehicles complete last-mile deliveries. The 1.5-ton payload truck is the second-largest segment. We have also seen sharp growth in medium-duty trucks, which expanded by almost 30 percent. The market was once dominated by conventional 16-ton trucks, but operators are increasingly moving towards medium-duty models.

TDS: *What has driven that shift, and how important is government policy?*
FK: Policy often shapes this market more strongly than general customer demand. A government rule allows a six-wheel truck a maximum gross vehicle weight of 22 tonnes. Traditional 16-ton trucks have a higher self-weight, limiting the payload they can legally carry. Medium-duty trucks are lighter but can carry a similar legal payload, improving operators' earning potential while remaining compliant. The slab-based income tax system has also helped: larger trucks pay more, while medium and smaller vehicles pay less.

TDS: *Runner Motors delivered over 300 vehicles in June. Was that seasonal or part of a longer trend?*
FK: June is traditionally strong as buyers purchase before possible budget-related changes and companies close their financial year. However, this June was substantially stronger than last year, suggesting longer-term demand also contributed. Agriculture remains a major driver, while services and industry also support demand. Without recent fuel and gas shortages, growth could have been stronger.
TDS: How do the priorities of individual transporters and corporate buyers differ?

FK: Individual transporters and small fleet owners focus primarily on mileage and payload. Their income depends on carrying as much as possible while controlling fuel costs. Corporate buyers prioritise performance, timely delivery and dependable after-sales support because vehicles serve their internal supply chains. They may carry lighter loads, but they cannot afford delays or prolonged downtime.

TDS: *How are high interest rates affecting vehicle purchases?*
FK: Current interest and profit rates make five-year instalment plans difficult for small-capital buyers and have pushed many SME customers out of the market. Formal SME loans are also hard to access. Requirements such as a trade licence and three years of banking records exclude many driver-buyers. Documentation for vehicle finance needs to be simplified. Some buyers use NGO financing, but its complexity and high cost can undermine the vehicle's profitability.

TDS: *How developed is Bangladesh's local parts-supplier ecosystem?*
FK: It is not yet fully mature, although local suppliers can provide batteries, leaf springs, plastic components and wiring harnesses. Local tyre production has also emerged, but quality is crucial. Fuel represents roughly 60 to 65 percent of a commercial vehicle's running cost, and tyres are the second-largest expense. A full set can cost Tk 250,000 or more, so high-load tyres must last long enough for operators to recover that investment.

TDS: *How is Runner strengthening after-sales support?*
FK: Prompt service is essential in this business. We have 42 service touchpoints along national highways and in major commercial hubs, covering key routes towards the north, Chattogram, Sylhet and the south-west. We also have a nationwide network of 350 spare-parts dealers. Trucks can remain far from their home base for weeks, so nearby service and parts availability are critical to reducing downtime.

TDS: *What digital technologies are being introduced for fleet owners?*
FK: Our My Eicher application provides customers with a free fleet-management system and has more than 3,000 active users. Its complaint-management system escalates unresolved service issues to senior management. The Eicher Pro 3000 and Pro 6000 series also include built-in telemetry that records distance travelled, peak speed, engine idling and fuel-tank openings. Fleet owners can compare these records with driver reports and manage fuel consumption more effectively.
The vehicles also have on-board diagnostics. Service teams can identify faults electronically instead of spending hours dismantling components. The dashboard alerts drivers to engine issues, while technicians can use video calls to guide them through minor fixes. When a truck reaches a workshop, an existing diagnosis can substantially shorten repair time.

TDS: *What are Runner Motors' priorities for the next five years, and what policy changes does the sector need?*
FK: We aim to expand across commercial vehicle segments by introducing newer, technology-led products. We are prepared to offer vehicles meeting Euro 4 and even Euro 6 emission standards, but that transition depends on government policy and the availability of suitable high-grade diesel. Our next generation of vehicles is undergoing trials ahead of launch.
Registration and financing rules also require reform. During an instalment contract, a vehicle may remain registered in the automobile company's name, creating complications after accidents, theft or other legal disputes. Ownership documents should identify the actual buyer while protecting the financier's interest. Banks, leasing companies and manufacturers that finance purchases also need effective legal mechanisms to address defaults and recover assets. Without that protection, financing will contract and constrain logistics-sector growth.





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AMIR DAUD
CEO
IFAD Commercial Automotive Division

> Fleet owners now judge a truck by how much it can earn across its working life.

LOCAL MANUFACTURING IS RESHAPING COMMERCIAL VEHICLE ECONOMICS

IFAD Commercial Automotive Division

From infrastructure-led demand to local manufacturing and telematics, Bangladesh's commercial vehicle market is increasingly shaped by lifetime operating economics. Amir Daud, CEO IFAD Commercial Automotive Division, discusses changing fleet priorities, the value of local production and the technologies likely to define the sector's next phase in an interview with The Daily Star.

The Daily Star (TDS): How have infrastructure development and longer freight journeys changed what fleet owners expect?

Amir Daud (AD): Better roads, bridges and expressways have made transport faster and increased the number of trips vehicles can complete. Fleet owners now look beyond purchase price to payload, fuel efficiency, durability and uptime. They judge a truck by how much it can earn across its working life. Ashok Leyland trucks and tippers have supported major bridge approaches, expressways and developments around Padma and Payra, so our products and service network must deliver that operating value.

TDS: What advantages does IFAD's Dhamrai manufacturing facility offer customers?

AD: Since beginning operations in 2017, the facility has developed assembly, cabin and body-manufacturing capabilities, supported by greater automation in quality control. Local production lets us adapt suspension, body strength and cabin configurations to Bangladesh's road conditions, load patterns and operating requirements. It creates more value locally and gives us better control over supply. That improves stability when international logistics are disrupted.

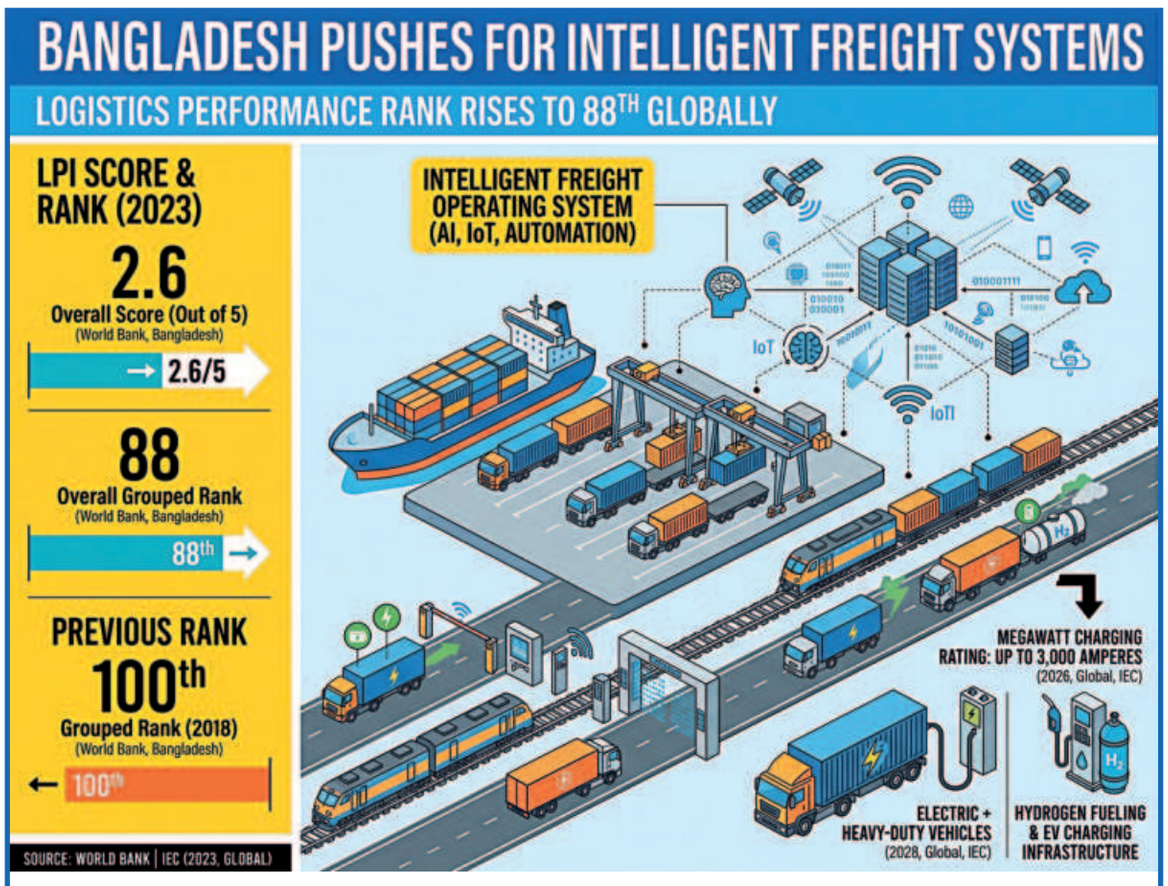
TDS: How does IFAD help fleets reduce downtime and total ownership costs?

AD: Fuel, maintenance, downtime and resale value can matter more than the initial price. Our focus is therefore on fuel efficiency, useful payload, reliability and service support. IFAD Auto Services operates about 20 company-owned centres alongside authorised stations, several hundred parts outlets and more than 1,000 trained mechanics. Our Madanpur facility can handle over 20 vehicles at once and provides accident repair and training. Around 200+ roadside mechanics also support light commercial vehicles. The wider group supplies Apollo tyres and Gulf lubricants, giving customers fewer parties to manage and clearer accountability.

TDS: What will define IFAD's strategy beyond 2026?

AD: Technology will play a larger role in fleet management. We want to expand GPS-based services into real-time diagnostics, predictive maintenance and driver-behaviour monitoring so operators can identify problems. We will also expand manufacturing at Dhamrai. IFAD is following cleaner powertrain development and Bangladesh's fuel infrastructure and regulations.





HOW TECHNOLOGY IS RESHAPING FREIGHT

Artificial intelligence, telematics, electric drivetrains and digital freight platforms are turning trucks into connected operating systems. For Bangladesh, the opportunity is not merely to adopt new vehicles, but to build safer, more efficient logistics around the data they generate.

RUDRO RAYHAN

For generations, freight transport was defined by heavy steel, manual labour and paper schedules. In 2026, vehicles, drivers, cargo, roads and customers are increasingly linked through a continuous flow of data.

TECHNOLOGY ALREADY IN OPERATION

Predictive artificial intelligence and machine learning are among the most consequential changes. Modern dispatch and transportation management systems combine live traffic, historical route performance, fuel prices and customer requirements to recommend better routes and schedules, improving fleet utilisation, fuel use and delivery predictability.

Internet of Things sensors and telematics make fleets more transparent by monitoring engines, brakes, tyres, fuel use and, where necessary, cargo temperature and shock. The resulting data supports predictive maintenance, helping operators address potential failures before breakdowns cause costly repairs, lost time or missed deliveries.

Battery-electric trucks are moving beyond the experimental stage. Better batteries, charging infrastructure and reliability are making them practical for urban and regional freight, where predictable routes allow vehicles to return to a depot for charging.

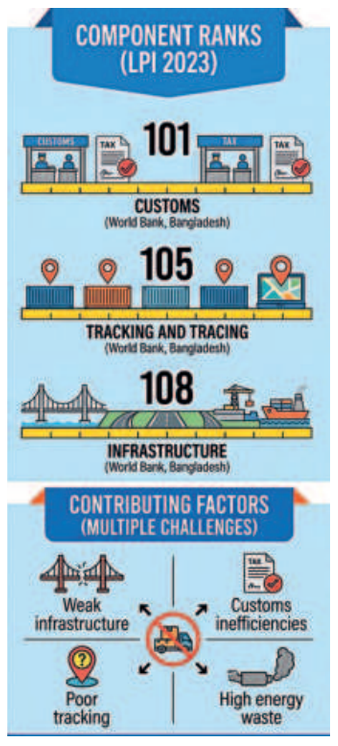
THE NEXT FRONTIER

Several technologies are approaching commercial maturity but remain outside the mainstream. Level 4 and Level 5 autonomous trucks, capable of handling most or all driving tasks, are being tested in controlled settings and selected freight corridors. Regulatory differences, safety standards, infrastructure and public acceptance mean widespread use will take time.

Megawatt charging is another critical part of the electric-truck puzzle. In January 2026, the International Electrotechnical Commission published its specification for connectors supporting currents of up to 3,000 amperes. The goal is to give heavy trucks enough energy during driver rest periods to make long-distance electric freight practical, requiring major investment in charging networks and grid capacity.

Hydrogen is being explored where batteries may face limits, particularly in long-distance, heavy-duty operations. Volvo began testing hydrogen-combustion trucks on public roads in 2026, using high-pressure direct injection, with commercialisation planned before 2030. Hydrogen is therefore more likely to complement battery-electric transport than replace it.

Blockchain and smart contracts offer a different route to efficiency. Tamper-resistant digital records can strengthen cargo provenance, customs documentation and trade finance. A smart contract, for example, could release payment automatically once sensors confirm that temperature-sensitive cargo arrived safely.



Cost, interoperability and regulatory complexity remain barriers.

BANGLADESH'S OPENING

Bangladesh remains some distance from these global frontiers. The World Bank's 2023 Logistics Performance Index placed the country 88th, reflecting weaknesses in infrastructure, customs and tracking. Yet local companies are already changing how freight is booked and managed.

Lalamove has built a network of around 20,000 registered commercial-vehicle drivers and 80,000 customers in Bangladesh, bringing on-demand booking closer to the experience of a consumer mobility app. Truck Lagbe, Loop Freight and Goods in Motion are also helping businesses and households arrange transport digitally, reducing reliance on traditional truck stands and making freight capacity easier to find.

Telematics is gaining ground as well. Kolpolok Limited's Goti Telematics platform offers IoT-enabled fleet tracking and real-time vehicle monitoring, helping businesses improve visibility, vehicle utilisation and oversight of sensitive cargo. Such systems illustrate how global logistics technology can be adapted to local operating conditions.

Electric commercial vehicles create another opening. Bangladesh Automobile Industries Limited has demonstrated battery-powered commercial vehicles designed to provide performance comparable with conventional models while reducing energy and maintenance costs. Their wider adoption, however, will depend on purchase prices, reliable charging and confidence in long-term vehicle support.

THE SYSTEM, NOT JUST THE TRUCK

The most immediate opportunity may be broader use of transportation management systems. These platforms can integrate route planning, driver monitoring, vehicle diagnostics and safety tools. AI-enabled cameras can detect fatigue, speeding and risky behaviour. Vehicle sensors can identify mechanical problems before failure, while Advanced Driver Assistance Systems can support emergency braking, collision avoidance and, in some situations, a controlled stop if a driver becomes incapacitated.

For Bangladesh's trucking industry, this technology promises more than efficiency. Better monitoring can encourage safer driving, improve maintenance and reduce preventable crashes, protecting drivers and other road users.

The future of logistics is not simply about faster trucks or larger ships; it is about the data connecting them. As autonomous driving, hydrogen power and megawatt charging mature, companies that build integrated digital systems will be better placed to compete. For Bangladesh, the transition could make freight safer, more efficient and more competitive.



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Modern fleets demand more than basic utility

ACI MOTORS LTD



"Buyers are moving beyond initial price and basic utility. They increasingly want fuel efficiency, reliability, safety, technology and dependable support."

ARIFUR RAHMAN, Business Manager, ACI Motors Ltd

Improved highways, expanding last-mile delivery and rising operating costs are changing what Bangladeshi businesses expect from commercial vehicles. Arifur Rahman, Business Manager at ACI Motors Ltd, discusses Foton's approach to fleet economics, safety, after-sales support and smarter mobility in an interview with The Daily Star.

The Daily Star (TDS): ***How have better roads and bridges changed fleet-owner expectations?***

Arifur Rahman (AR): Shorter travel times allow more trips, better vehicle utilisation and stronger returns over a vehicle's lifecycle. Buyers are consequently moving beyond initial price and basic utility. They increasingly want fuel efficiency, reliability, safety, technology and dependable support. The wider commercial vehicle market grew by around 20 percent from 2024 to 2025, and Foton has grown with that demand.

TDS: ***What helped ACI establish Foton in Bangladesh's commercial vehicle market?***

AR: We introduced Foton in 2018, focusing on technology-led products, after-sales service, genuine parts and a growing nationwide network. Our vehicles combine ergonomic cabins, digital dashboards, ABS and power steering, making driving easier in congested cities and on rough rural roads. We also introduced air brakes in the light-commercial segment to improve braking efficiency and vehicle control. Our next step is to extend the portfolio into higher-capacity applications.

TDS: ***How does Foton help operators control fuel, maintenance and downtime costs?***

AR: Our turbocharged, intercooled engines are designed to improve fuel efficiency, while accessible maintenance and genuine parts help control workshop costs. The support network now includes 75 service points, trained technicians, preventive maintenance and faster turnaround. For fleet owners, these elements work together: fuel economy lowers running costs, while prompt service keeps a revenue-earning vehicle on the road.

TDS: ***How is the TM series addressing last-mile delivery demand?***

AR: The Foton 1-tonne TM and 1.2-tonne TM Plus are designed for e-commerce, FMCG and SME distribution. Practical payloads, fuel efficiency, power steering, high ground clearance and flexible body configurations allow them to operate across congested urban areas and rural roads. The objective is to give businesses a versatile vehicle that can complete more deliveries with less disruption.

TDS: ***What is ACI Motors' longer-term vision for commercial transport?***

AR: We want to become a reliable goods-transport solutions provider, with greater emphasis on local value addition, connected logistics, telematics and real-time fleet tracking. Electric mobility is also part of this direction. Wider adoption will depend on continued government support and a conducive policy environment, but the goal is smarter, greener and more sustainable commercial transport.

Five decades behind Bangladesh's commercial wheels

UTTARA MOTORS LIMITED



A commercial vehicle company's history can also be read as a timeline of the economy it serves. As Bangladesh's garment industry, construction activity and nationwide logistics expanded, Uttara Motors Limited moved from vehicle distribution towards local assembly and manufacturing. Now preparing for electric mobility, the company's five-decade journey mirrors many of the changes that have reshaped the country's transport sector.

A PORTFOLIO BUILT OVER TIME

Founded in 1973 under Chairman and Managing Director Matiur Rahman, Uttara Motors secured the distributorship of Isuzu in 1981. Its trucks, buses and pickups subsequently became part of the country's growing transport network. In 1993, the company added Swaraj Mazda Limited—later SML Isuzu and now SML Mahindra—to its portfolio, widening its range to include pickups, trucks, tippers and buses for different operating needs.

More than 7,000 SML and Isuzu commercial vehicles have been delivered across Bangladesh, according to Uttara Motors.

Distribution was followed by a move into domestic production. Uttara Automobile Manufacturers Ltd was established in 2001 and began operating the following year. Its 83,000-square-foot facility has an annual capacity of approximately 1,100 units and includes local cabin-painting operations. The group says more than 7,000 SML and Isuzu commercial vehicles have been delivered across Bangladesh, while its manufacturing activities have supported employment and technical skills.

THE ECONOMICS CHANGED

The market surrounding those vehicles has become considerably harder. The post-pandemic slowdown, currency depreciation, higher fuel prices and import restrictions affected sales, particularly in the heavy-truck segment. Inflation, elevated interest rates and high import costs continued to squeeze buyers through 2024 and 2025, while repayment difficulties increased pressure on distributors and credit providers.

Fleet renewal is another unresolved issue. Citing BRTA data, the company says more than 38,000 trucks, tankers and related vehicles are over 25 years old. Replacing these vehicles would have implications for safety, emissions and operating efficiency, but high financing costs make renewal difficult for many owners.

THE ROAD AHEAD

Several national policies now point towards greater local value addition and a cleaner fleet. The Automobile Industry Development Policy 2021 promotes domestic assembly and manufacturing, while the Road Transport Act 2018, Motor Vehicle Scrap Policy, Bangladesh's NDC 3.0 and the National Logistics Policy 2024 address safety, emissions, connectivity and freight efficiency.

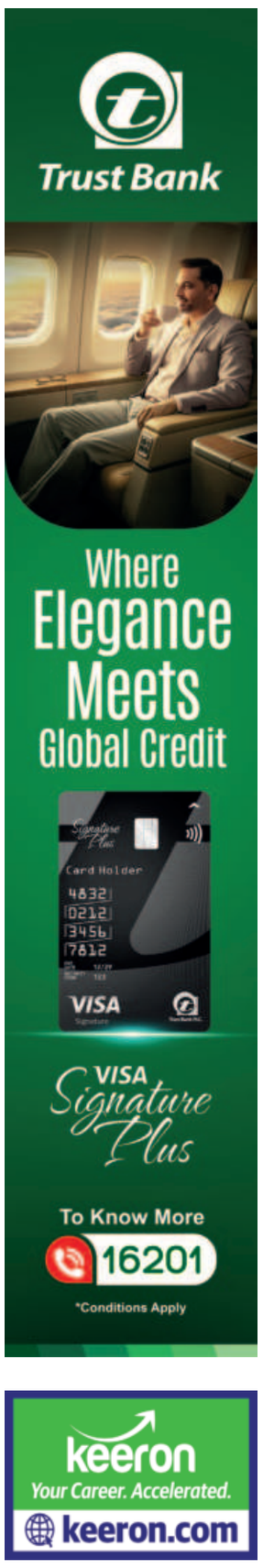
Uttara Motors says it is aligning its manufacturing plans with this policy direction while exploring electric vehicles across passenger, commercial and heavy-duty categories, including trucks. The next stage of its brand story will therefore depend on more than the vehicles it distributes. It will be shaped by how effectively local production, fleet renewal and new powertrains can respond to the changing economics of moving goods across Bangladesh.

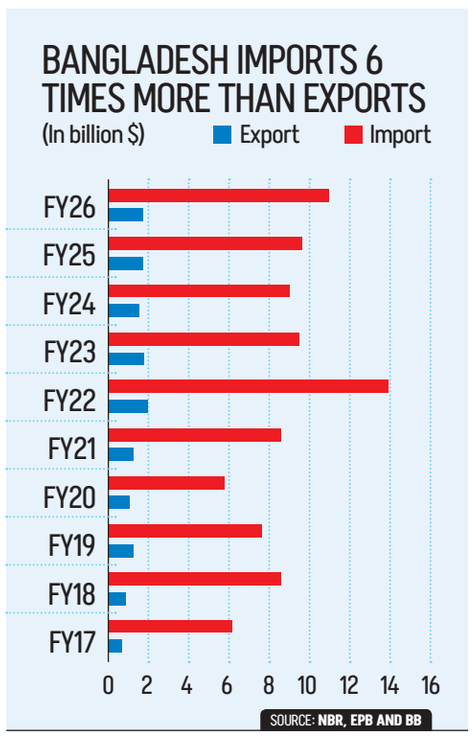


DHAKA MONDAY AUGUST 31, 2026, BHADRA 16, 1433 BS • starbusiness@thedailystar.net

Star BUSINESS







Imports from India rise despite trade restrictions

REFAYET ULLAH MIRDHA

Bangladesh's imports from India continue to rise despite restrictions imposed by both countries on the movement of some goods, while exports to the neighbouring country remained almost unchanged.

The country imported goods worth $10.96 billion from India in fiscal year 2025-26, up from $9.62 billion a year earlier, according to National Board of Revenue (NBR) data.

In contrast, exports to India stood at $1.75 billion in FY26, compared with $1.76 billion in the previous fiscal year.

The figures show that trade between the two neighbours has continued despite restrictions introduced over the past two years, particularly on the movement of goods through land ports.

Bangladeshi businesses say Indian yarn, cotton, fabrics and other industrial raw materials remain in demand because of their competitive rates, and because some international buyers specify particular fabrics or yarn from India.

After China, India is Bangladesh's second-largest trading partner and the country's largest trading partner in South Asia.

READ MORE ON B3

Foreign debt repayment exceeds receipts in July

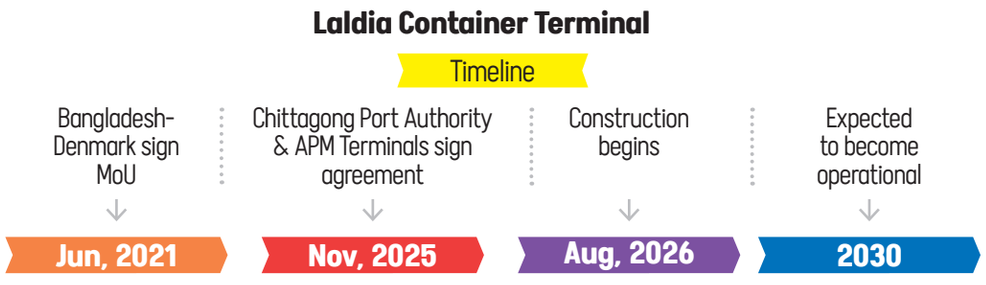
STAR BUSINESS REPORT

The government repaid nearly three times more in foreign loans than it received in July, mainly due to lower loan disbursements.

According to data from the Economic Relations Division (ERD), the government repaid $453 million in principal and interest on foreign loans in July, compared with $446 million in the same month last year.

Meanwhile, it received $180 million in foreign loans in the seventh month of the year, down from $208 million in the same month the previous year.

Fresh loan disbursements also fell a massive 83 percent year-on-year to $14 million in July. Of the total disbursement, the Asian Development Bank provided $65 million, the World Bank $47 million, Japan $39 million and India $27 million.



Laldia terminal construction begins

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

APM Terminals, a subsidiary of Danish shipping group AP Møller-Maersk, yesterday began construction of Laldia Container Terminal in Chattogram, a project expected to increase the capacity of Chattogram port and improve its efficiency of cargo handling.

The $550 million terminal, being built at Laldia Char near the mouth of the Karnaphuli river, is expected to open in 2030 and handle one million twenty-foot equivalent units (TEUs) a year.

That would add nearly one-third to the country's current container-handling capacity.

"This would open a new horizon in logistics and trade facilities and support the country's development," Finance and Planning Minister Amir Khosru Mahmud Chowdhury said at the inauguration of the construction.

The minister said the project would be a significant milestone in the country's journey towards a trillion-dollar economy by 2034.

Khosru said the government is also taking steps to develop other modern terminals, export processing zones and logistics facilities, including free trade zones,

READ MORE ON B2



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KEY OBSERVATIONS

- Prioritise existing investors
- Prepare a 20-year energy strategy
- Ensure predictable energy pricing
- Expand rooftop solar
- Accelerate domestic gas exploration
- Do not politicise the crisis

Fix energy supply for existing industries first

Trade bodies, business leaders and policy experts call on the government

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

Bangladesh must fix its worsening energy crisis and secure supplies to existing industries before courting new investment, business leaders and experts warned at a Dhaka seminar yesterday, cautioning that costly and unreliable energy is eroding industrial competitiveness.

They made the remarks at a seminar on "Bangladesh's Energy Security Challenges: Powering a More Competitive Business Climate", jointly organised by the Metropolitan Chamber of Commerce and Industry (MCCI) and Policy Exchange of Bangladesh (PEB) at the MCCI office in Gulshan.

Mohammad Iqbal Chowdhury, CEO of cement producer LafargeHolcim Bangladesh, urged the government to prioritise existing investors before seeking new ones.

"We have been spending so much time on seminars and programmes to invite new investors. My humble request to the current government is: please do not go for any new investor yet," he said.

"First, come to the existing investors. First supply us properly, first make us happy, and then go for new investors. If you do not have the raw material, you cannot produce," he added.

He called for a 20-year energy strategy, saying investors cannot plan around short-term policies. "Energy has to be sustainable, affordable and reliable."

Fazlul Hoque, administrator of the country's apex trade body, The Federation of Bangladesh Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FBCCI), said he too had advised authorities not to seek new investment in the industrial sector until existing industries achieve stability.

"I am not an investment expert, but I have urged against new industrial investment and suggested exploring other sectors for investment," he said. "If I cannot survive today, I don't need to know what happens after 10 years. That's the truth."

Showkat Aziz Russell, president of the Bangladesh Textile Mills Association, said gas shortages had become a major problem for textile mills, many of which rely on captive power generation.

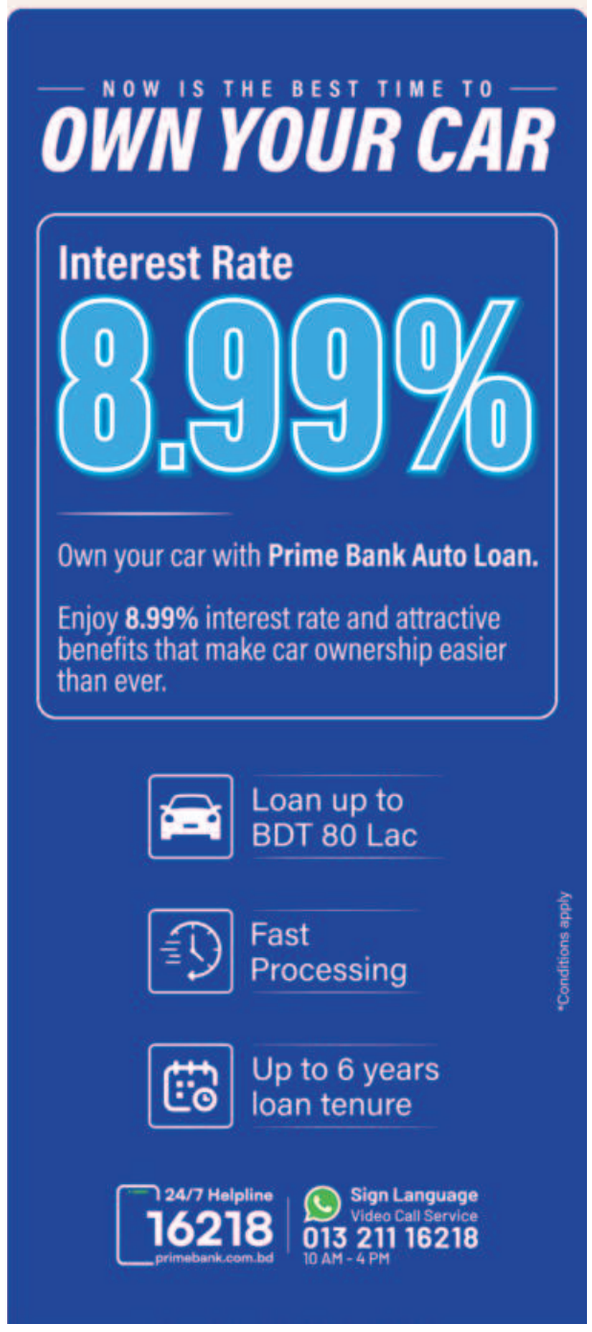
"My job is to flag the problem -- what went wrong, how we can fix it and what the interim policy should be. But the question is, are the policymakers listening to us?" he said.

Showkat complained that Bangladesh had failed to secure long-term energy contracts when prices were low, unlike India.

"We were happy buying gas at spot rates instead of going for long-term contracts," he said, adding that the current situation was foreseeable.

He urged the government and experts to formulate an interim policy to keep industries running.

READ MORE ON B3



BB revises Tk 3,000 agri-refinance scheme for northern region

BSS, *Dhaka*

Bangladesh Bank (BB) yesterday revised several provisions of its Tk 3,000 crore refinancing scheme aimed at creating a special economic centre based on agriculture in the northern region of the country.

Under the revised provision, participating banks will receive refinancing facilities from Bangladesh Bank at an interest/profit rate of 3 percent.

At the customer level, the interest/profit rate will be a maximum of 7 percent.

For Shariah-based financing, the profit rate charged to customers will have to be determined in accordance with the approved investment policy, but it cannot exceed 7 percent.

The rate will be applicable equally to all customers.

The circular also revised the tenure of loans and investments under the scheme.

For eligible sectors or projects, loans or investments provided to customers, including a three-month grace period where applicable, will have a maximum tenure of 18 months.

Participating banks must repay the principal and interest or profit to Bangladesh Bank within a maximum of 18 months from the date of receiving refinancing.

For loans or investments under other specified sectors or projects, including a grace period ranging from three to six months where applicable, the maximum tenure will be 36 months.

Participating banks must repay the principal and interest or profit to Bangladesh Bank within a maximum of 36 months from the date of receiving refinancing. Bangladesh Bank also specified a provision for recovery in cases of misuse of the refinancing facility or charging customers an interest/profit rate above 7 percent.

If such irregularities are identified, the bank concerned will have to pay an additional 2 percent interest/profit over the prescribed rate on the relevant amount as a one-time recovery.

Global Insurance approves 10% cash dividend for 2025

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Global Insurance PLC has approved a 10 percent cash dividend for the year that ended on December 31, 2025.

The approval was given at the non-life insurance company's 26th annual general meeting (AGM), which was held virtually recently, according to a press release.

Sayeed Ahmed, a member of parliament from the Shariatpur-1 constituency and chairman of the insurer, presided over the meeting.

In his address, Sayeed expressed his sincere gratitude to the shareholders for their continued trust, cooperation and support.

A large number of shareholders from across the country took part in the AGM. They approved the directors' report and the audited financial statements of the company, along with other agendas and issues placed before the meeting.

The shareholders expressed satisfaction with the company's overall performance and appreciated the leadership of the chairman and the efforts of the management to ensure the company operated smoothly and efficiently during the year.



Sayeed Ahmed, a member of parliament from the Shariatpur-1 constituency and chairman of Global Insurance PLC, presides over the insurer's 26th annual general meeting held recently. The meeting approved a 10 percent cash dividend for 2025. PHOTO: GLOBAL INSURANCE



Mitchel Lee, chargé d'affaires of the Singapore High Commission in Bangladesh, inaugurates a celebratory programme at WW Tower in Motijheel, Dhaka recently to mark Drip Lab's 2nd anniversary. PHOTO: DRIP LAB

Drip Lab celebrates 2nd anniversary

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Drip Lab, a Dhaka-based popular coffee house, celebrated the 2nd anniversary.

The company organised a celebratory programme at WW Tower in Motijheel, Dhaka recently, according to a press release. Mitchel Lee, chargé d'affaires of the Singapore High Commission in Bangladesh, inaugurated the celebrations as the chief guest.

Md Fazlur Rahman, chairman of AB Bank PLC, attended the event as the special guest.

The event was also attended by executive leaders and senior officials representing top-tier organisations, including Mutual Trust Bank PLC, W&W Grains Corporation, Pragati Insurance PLC and Pragati Life Insurance PLC, along with other prominent corporate partners and clients.

Premier Bank joins BB's Tk 10,000cr refinance scheme

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Premier Bank PLC has signed a participation agreement with Bangladesh Bank under the BB's Tk 10,000 crore refinance scheme to support increased agricultural production, strengthen food security and create employment opportunities through expanded economic activities in rural areas.

Under the agreement, refinance facilities will be provided from a fund created with the surplus liquidity of scheduled banks and managed by Bangladesh Bank. Md Monzur Mofiz, managing director of Premier Bank PLC, and AKM Saiduzzaman, director of the Agricultural Credit Department-2 of Bangladesh Bank, signed the agreement at a ceremony held at the BB headquarters in Motijheel, Dhaka recently, according to a press release.

They expressed optimism that the initiative would make a significant contribution to the sustainable development of Bangladesh's agricultural and rural economy. Through its extensive branch network, Premier Bank PLC will extend loans for crop and agricultural production, rural income-generating activities, agricultural machinery, and the fisheries and livestock sectors.



AKM Saiduzzaman, director of the Agricultural Credit Department-2 of Bangladesh Bank, and Md Monzur Mofiz, managing director of Premier Bank PLC, pose for a photograph after signing the agreement at the BB headquarters in Motijheel, Dhaka recently. PHOTO: PREMIER BANK

Sonali Life approves 15% cash dividend

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Sonali Life Insurance PLC has approved a 15 percent cash dividend for all shareholders for the financial year 2025.

The approval was given at the life insurer's 13th annual general meeting (AGM), held at the company's office in Malibagh, Dhaka recently, according to a press release.

Moinul Islam, chairman of the life insurer, presided over the meeting.

In his address, Moinul expressed his sincere gratitude to the shareholders for their continued confidence, trust and support.

SLI PLC
SONALI LIFE INSURANCE PLC
Islami Shariah Based Life Insurance Company

He reaffirmed the company's strong commitment to sustainable growth, sound financial management, regulatory compliance and maintaining the highest standards of corporate governance.

Zafar Iqbal, Fazlutunnesa, Mostafa Quamrus Sobhan, Fauzia Quamrun Tania, Sheikh Mohammad Danial and Omar Khayum, directors, attended the AGM.

A significant number of shareholders from across the country joined the AGM. They approved the appointment of statutory and compliance auditors for 2026, as well as the audited financial statements and the reports of the directors and auditors thereon.

Md Abdur Rob, company secretary, conducted the meeting.

Md Rafiqul Islam, additional managing director and chief executive officer (acting); Md Monzur Morshed, chief operating officer; Md Ali Reza, assistant managing director and head of internal audit and compliance; and Hasib Reza, chief information officer, along with other senior officials of the company, were also present.

UK business confidence hits highest since March

REUTERS, *London*

British businesses turned the most confident since March this month, bolstered by a rosier view of the economy, according to a survey that echoes other signs of an improving outlook.

Lloyds, a bank, said on Friday that its monthly business confidence index had risen by 4 points in August to +53 percent, above its average +47 percent over the past 12 months.

"Overall, businesses are reporting stronger customer demand, greater optimism about the wider economy and growing confidence in their own trading outlook, all of which will be helping to support investment and growth plans," Amanda Murphy, chief executive of Lloyds Business and Commercial Banking, said.

Government of The People's Republic of Bangladesh
Office of the Executive Engineer, RHD
Ferry Division
Shiromony, Khulna
Email: eefdkhu@rhd.gov.bd

Memo: - 228 Date: -30/08/2026.

Notice for e-GP Tender

e-Tender is invited in the National e-GP Portal (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd) for the Procurement of Goods/Works of RHD, Ferry Division, Shiromony, Khulna (Tender ID No: **1321693, 1321694, 1321695, 1321696, 1321697, 1321698, 1321699, 1321700, 1321701, 1321702, 1321703, 1321704, 1321705, 1321706, 1321707, 1321708, 1321709, 1321710, 1321711, 1321712, 1321713, 1321714, 1321715, 1321716, 1321717, 1321718, 1321719, 1321720, 1321721, 1321722, 1321723, 1321724, 1321725, 1321726, 1321727, 1321728, 1321729, 1321730, 1321731, 1321732, 1321733, 1321734, 1321735, 1321736, 1321737, 1321738, 1321739, 1321740, 1321741, 1321742, 1321743, 1321744, 1321745, 1321746, 1321747, 1321748 & 1321749**). This is an online Tender, where only e-Tender will be accepted in the National e-Gp Portal and no offline/hard copies will be accepted.

Gunjan Barua
Id No.602263
Executive Engineer, RHD
Ferry Division, Khulna.

GD-2068

Laldia terminal

FROM PAGE B1

as part of efforts to turn Chattogram into a regional logistics hub.

Under a public-private partnership (PPP), APM Terminals will develop and operate the terminal under a design, build, finance, operate and transfer model.

It will run the facility for 30 years, with an option to extend the concession by a further 15 years.

The terminal will occupy 49.15 acres along the Karnaphuli river, APM Terminals Chief Executive Officer Romesh David said.

It will have a 616-metre jetty, seven ship-to-shore cranes, 32 electric rubber-tyred gantry cranes and 41 electric terminal tractors, he said. Romesh said the terminal would be a carbon-neutral, zero-emission port. It would also employ female crane operators for the first time in Bangladesh. "Young women from the Chittagong area will operate huge cranes remotely to move containers while sitting in an air-conditioned office."

The project has been in the pipeline for several years. Bangladesh and Denmark signed a memorandum of understanding in June 2021 to facilitate co-operation on the project under the PPP framework.

The Chittagong Port Authority (CPA) and APM Terminals BV signed the final agreement on November 17 last year, paving the way for the terminal to be developed with 100 percent foreign investment.

The new facility will be able to handle vessels carrying up to 6,000 TEUs, roughly twice the capacity of ships that currently berth directly at Chattogram port, CPA Chairman Rear Admiral SM Moniruzzaman said.

He said the port's existing capacity had already been exceeded. Container handling in Bangladesh roughly doubles every 10 years, underscoring the need for terminals closer to the sea.

The Laldia terminal will operate around the clock, making it the first terminal of its kind at the port, the CPA chairman said. It will be able to handle vessels up to 230 metres long with a draft of 10.5 metres.

Electric equipment and modern cargo-handling technology will support greener port operations. The ability to handle larger vessels directly is also expected to reduce waiting times for ships and speed up cargo movement at Bangladesh's main seaport, he said.

Road Transport and Bridges, Railways, and Shipping Minister Sheikh Rabiul Alam said the project would usher Bangladesh into a new era of investment, technology and modern terminal operations. The terminal would also help Bangladesh develop expertise in modern container-terminal operations and advanced port technologies, Rabiul said.

Government of the People's Republic of Bangladesh
Office of the Executive Engineer, RHD,
Patuakhali Road Division,
Patuakhali.
Phone: 0441-62216 Fax: 0441-65108
email: eepat@rhd.gov.bd

Memo No. 35.01.7895.461.07.001.26-1522 Dated: 25.08.2026.

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e-Tenders are invited in e-GP System Portal (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd) by Executive Engineer, RHD, Patuakhali Road Division for the procurement of:
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Sl. No.	Tender ID No.	Tender Reference No.	Name of works	Invitation Date & Time	Last Selling/ Downloading Date & Time	Tender Closing/ Opening Date & Time
1.	1322844	03/e-GP/PMPMajor/Road/PATRHD/2026-2027	Periodic Maintenance Programme Providing DBS Wearing Course work including Repair of Potholes, Undulation, Depression & Strengthening work at Ch. 13+690 Km (Boga Ferry Ghat) to Ch. 41+680 Km (Dashmina College Road) of Lebukhali-Bauphal-Galachipa-Amragachia Road (Z-8806) Under Patuakhali Road Division during the year 2026-2027.	25-Aug-2026 20:35	20-Sep-2026 16:30	21-Sep-2026 12:15

(Md. Juwel Hossain)
Assistant Engineer (A.C), RHD
Road Division, Patuakhali.

(Md. Zamil Akter Limon)
ID No. 602346
Executive Engineer (C.C.), RHD
Road Division, Patuakhali.

GD-2062

Tk 10,000cr farm refinance scheme gets rate cut

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

Bangladesh Bank yesterday cut the interest rate on its flagship Tk 10,000 crore agricultural refinance scheme by 100 basis points to ease farmers' access to credit, boost rural economic activity and support food security.

Under the revised guidelines, the maximum interest rate at the farmer and customer level has been capped at 7 percent per annum, down from the 8 percent set when the scheme was announced in June this year.

The central bank also reduced its refinance rate for participating commercial banks to 3 percent from 4 percent, according to a circular issued by the BB.

Shariah-based banks operating under Islamic banking principles must also cap their customer-level profit rates at 7 percent. All participating banks must apply interest or profit charges on a reducing-balance basis, where applicable.

The BB, however, kept the maximum repayment period for loans disbursed under the scheme unchanged at 18 months and retained the existing penalty rate for banks.

If the central bank finds that funds have not been properly utilised, it will impose an additional 2 percent penalty interest on the misused amount, to be recovered in a single lump sum.

To raise awareness among marginal farmers, the BB asked banks to display clearly visible promotional banners inside and outside their branches highlighting the availability of agricultural credit at 7 percent interest.

In June 2026, the BB announced the five-year refinance fund from its own resources to provide low-cost loans to farmers. It also advised banks to prioritise farmers with smart cards when extending loans.

The scheme covers crops, fisheries, livestock, agricultural machinery, irrigation equipment and other income-generating farm activities. Small and marginal farmers may receive up to Tk 5 lakh in loans for crop production without collateral, based on crop hypothecation.

In its June circular, the central bank set loan limits at Tk 30 lakh for crop production, Tk 15 lakh for livestock and other agricultural activities, Tk 20 lakh for agricultural machinery, and Tk 1 crore for fisheries and livestock projects.



PHOTO: AZAHAR UDDIN

Farmers plant Swarna variety of Khato Jira rice seedlings on a breezy, overcast day in Chaitanyapur village of Godagari, Rajshahi. A brief bout of rain after a prolonged dry spell allowed farmers in the Barind region to plant Aman seedlings.

Bangladesh Bank made over Tk 26,000 crore profit in FY26

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

Bangladesh Bank's net profit rose 15 percent year-on-year to Tk 26,023 crore in the just-concluded 2025-26 fiscal year.

A large portion of this profit came from lending to commercial banks and investments of the foreign exchange reserves, officials of the central bank said.

The board of directors of the banking regulator approved its financial statements for the last fiscal year at a meeting yesterday presided over by Governor Md Mostaqur Rahman.

The banking regulator made a gross profit of Tk 35,016 crore in FY26, while its expenditure hit Tk 8,993 crore and it handed over Tk 25,977 crore to the government.

The board also approved an incentive bonus equivalent to six times the basic salary for Bangladesh Bank officials. As a result, all employees will receive a bonus equivalent to six months of their basic salary.

The central bank employees received a similar bonus in the previous year as well.

Officials of the accounts and budgeting department of the central bank said its lending operations remained strong despite a slowdown in the economy.

As revenue declined, both the government and commercial banks increased their borrowing from Bangladesh Bank, boosting the central bank's interest income.

The central bank also earned good returns from investments of its foreign exchange reserves in different countries, contributing to the rise in its overall profit.

Bank officials said Bangladesh Bank tends to earn lower profits when the economy is performing well and higher profits during economic downturns.



Md Abdus Salam, additional managing director and chief operating officer of Jamuna Bank PLC, inaugurates the bank's relocated Kamarpara branch in Tongi, Dhaka recently.

PHOTO: JAMUNA BANK

Jamuna Bank opens relocated Kamarpara branch

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Jamuna Bank PLC has opened its relocated Kamarpara branch at a new and more convenient location in Tongi, Dhaka as part of its continued efforts to provide customers with modern, accessible and efficient banking services.

Md Abdus Salam, additional managing director and chief operating officer of the bank, inaugurated the branch as the chief guest, according to a press release.

The relocation is expected to make banking services more accessible and convenient for customers in the area while enabling the branch to serve both individual and business clients more efficiently, the release added.

Managers of nearby branches, local representatives, business leaders, customers and other guests were also present at the event.

Imports from India rise

FROM PAGE B1

The trade gap between the two countries, however, remains wide, with Bangladesh importing more than six times as much from India as it exports to the country.

Businesses and economists say Bangladesh has scope to raise exports to India, but the country's export basket remains heavily concentrated in apparel.

India granted Bangladesh duty-free market access in 2010, with one year of retrospective effect, for all products except 25 alcoholic and beverage items under the South Asian Free Trade Area's (SAFTA) least developed country category.

Although exports have increased since then, the growth has not been enough to narrow the trade gap.

M Masrur Reaz, chairman of the Policy Exchange Bangladesh, said three factors are limiting Bangladesh's exports to India.

"Firstly, India has its own import-substitute goods such as garments; secondly, India has a long list of standard requirements, and thirdly, both Bangladesh and India could not establish a regional value chain yet," he said.

He suggested signing the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) between the two countries to expand bilateral trade.

The two countries have introduced a series of trade restrictions since the political changeover in Bangladesh in 2024.

In March 2025, Bangladesh's commerce ministry asked the National Board of Revenue to take steps to restrict yarn imports through land ports to protect the local textile and spinning sector. In early April, India suspended a transhipment facility used by Bangladesh to send garments to third countries through Indian airports.

The NBR restricted yarn imports from India through land ports. Yarn imports from India are now allowed only through Chattogram port.

India later imposed restrictions on the import of garments, agro-processed food, jute goods, furniture and some other Bangladeshi goods through land ports.

Despite the restrictions, imports of Indian goods continued to rise.

Showkat Aziz Russell, president of the Bangladesh Textile Mills Association, said yarn imports from India doubled to around Tk 30,000 crore in FY26 from Tk 14,000 crore a year earlier.

"The higher import of yarn through the seaport is the real reflection of yarn imports from India. Because when yarn was allowed to be imported through the land ports, a lot of yarn used to be imported through informal channels, meaning it was smuggled in," he said.

Russell said restrictions on yarn imports through land ports should not be lifted. He argued that local textile mills are facing higher production costs and competition from imported yarn.

Mahmud Hasan Khan, president of the Bangladesh Garment Manufacturers and Exporters Association, said businesses have raised trade-related issues in different forums to increase exports to India.

He said Bangladesh should be able to export more goods through land ports and gain greater access to the Indian market.

Mohammad Hatem, president of the Bangladesh Knitwear Manufacturers and Exporters Association, said the recent trade disputes have commercial implications but require a political solution.

"It needs a political solution from the top-level leaders of both countries," Hatem said.

MA Razzaque, chairman of Research and Policy Integration for Development, said the issue of land ports is part of a wider bilateral relationship.

"The land port is not an issue alone; it is a matter of a warm relationship between Bangladesh and India," he said.

He said better bilateral relations could support stronger trade because both countries stood to gain from greater commercial engagement.

Md Abdul Wahed, former honorary joint secretary general of the India-Bangladesh Chamber of Commerce and Industry, said trade could increase if the movement of major goods through land ports resumes.

Md Fazlul Hoque, administrator of the Federation of Bangladesh Chambers of Commerce and Industry, called for discussions between the two countries to ease trade rules.

Fix energy supply

FROM PAGE B1

Ijaz Hossain, chairman of ESTex Foundation, a consultancy organisation specialising in industrial sustainability, said the energy crisis had gone beyond a supply problem and become an economic one.

"The number one problem we created for ourselves is that we did not price gas correctly," he said, noting that industries once paid Tk 8 per cubic metre but now pay around Tk 40 while struggling to receive adequate supplies for the past three years.

"Who is going to, in their right mind, invest with this kind of gas situation?" he asked, calling for a comprehensive energy policy, greater use of renewables and realistic pricing.

Moynul Islam, president of the Bangladesh Ceramic Manufacturers and Exporters Association, said the crisis was threatening the industry's survival.

"Throughout my career, I have failed to convince the government that gas is the raw material for ceramics. Without gas, you cannot produce ceramics," he said.

"When factories start closing, the pressure will fall on the government, banks and ordinary people," Moynul said.

Asif Ibrahim, vice chairman of apparel manufacturer New Age Group, said inadequate gas pressure was slowing production, delaying orders and hurting exports.

He urged the government to prioritise export-oriented industries and provide credible load-shedding schedules so factories can plan.

"The private sector is not asking for cheap energy. They are asking for competitive, transparent and predictable energy pricing," Asif said.

He informed that his factory invested around Tk 3 crore to Tk 3.5 crore to install 566kW of rooftop solar, meeting about 25 percent of peak demand.

Yet, reliance on diesel remains costly and is further eroding competitiveness, he said.

M Masrur Reaz, chairman and CEO of PEB, described the energy crisis as the "number one constraint" on businesses and warned that it threatens growth and exports.

He said Bangladesh had faced energy problems for at least three years, largely due to domestic policy mismatches, but the situation had now become acute.

"Bangladesh needs short-term measures as well as medium- and long-term steps to build robust energy security," Masrur said.

Farooq Ahmed, secretary general of MCCI, said factories were operating below capacity because of gas shortages and frequent power outages.

He said better management of the existing system alone could resolve nearly half of the problems.

Government of the People's Republic of Bangladesh
Ministry of Industries
Bangladesh Standards and Testing Institution
Maan Bhaban, 116/A, Tejgaon Industrial Area, Dhaka-1208.
Website: http://www.bsti.gov.bd

Ref. No-36.05.0000.109.01.003.25-1/16 Date: 30-08-2026

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Sl. No.	Tender ID	Name of Goods & Related Services	Tender Last Selling Date & Time	Tender Closing & Opening Date & Time
1.	1316589	Procurement of Stabinger Viscometer for chemical testing lab BSTI, Dhaka.	16 Sept. 2026 at 16:00	17 Sept. 2026 at 12:00 PM
2.	1319022	Procurement of DUMAS Automatic Protein Analyzer & Muffle Furnace for Chemical Testing Lab of BSTI.	16 Sept. 2026 at 16:00	17 Sept. 2026 at 12:00 PM
3.	1320240	Procurement of 04 (Four) types of equipment for chemical testing lab of BSTI, Dhaka.	16 Sept. 2026 at 16:00	17 Sept. 2026 at 15:00
4.	1320736	Procurement of ECD for GC & Fluorescence Detector for HPLC instruments of chemical testing lab of BSTI.	16 Sept. 2026 at 16:00	17 Sept. 2026 at 12:30 PM
5.	1317455	Procurement of Electrical Safety Tester Calibrator equipment for Electrical Laboratory, BSTI, Dhaka.	16 Sept. 2026 at 16:00	17 Sept. 2026 at 15:00
6.	1319711	Procurement of 4 (Four) Types Equipment for NML Lab, BSTI, Dhaka,	17 Sept. 2026 at 16:00	17 Sept. 2026 at 15:00
7.	1320343	Procurement of Central Air Conditioning spare parts for NML Lab, BSTI, Dhaka.	16 Sept. 2026 at 16:00	17 Sept. 2026 at 15:00

e-Tender details can be downloaded from 31th August, 2026 after 16:00 (GMT+6) on e-GP System Portal (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd) for pursue.
This is an online tender, where only e-Tender will be accepted in the National e-GP portal and no offline/hard copies will be accepted. To submit e-Tender, please register on e-GP System (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd) portal.
Further information and guidelines are available in the National e-GP system portal and e-GP help desk (helpdesk@eprocure.gov.bd)

30.08.2026
(Md. Tuhin Ahamed)
Deputy Director (Admin)
Email: ddadmin2@bsti.gov.bd

GD-2063

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5th Annual General Meeting of Akij Takaful Life Insurance PLC

Akij Takaful Life Insurance PLC. successfully held its 5th Annual General Meeting (AGM) on 24 August 2026 at Akij House, Dhaka. The shareholders approved the Audited Financial Statements for 2025, along with the Auditor's Report and Valuation Report, and approved the stock dividend to shareholders and reversionary bonus for eligible participating policyholders.

The shareholders also approved the reappointment of Hoda Vasi Chowdhury & Co., Chartered Accountants, as Statutory Auditor for 2026. The Chairman and Managing Director & CEO highlighted the Company's progress, financial performance, business expansion, sound governance, and commitment to Shariah-compliant takaful solutions.

The Board expressed appreciation to all stakeholders and reaffirmed its commitment to sustainable growth and long-term value creation.

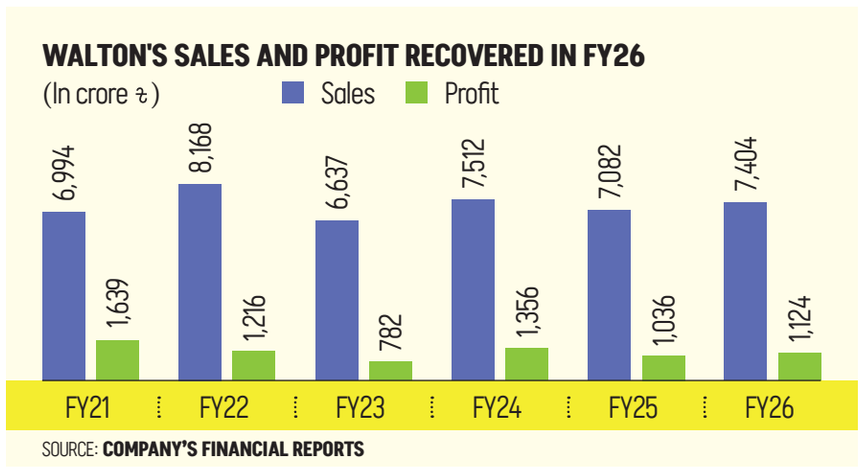
Walton profit gets a lift from lower interest costs

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

Walton Hi-Tech Industries PLC, a leading listed manufacturer of electrical and electronic products, posted higher profits in the last fiscal year, mainly because of a sharp fall in bank interest expenses.

The company has also recommended a higher cash dividend for shareholders.

It reported a net profit of Tk 1,124 crore for fiscal year 2025-26 (FY26), up 8.5 percent from Tk 1,036.62 crore a year earlier. Its earnings per share (EPS) increased to Tk 33.75 from Tk 31.11.



SOURCE: **COMPANY'S FINANCIAL REPORTS**

With higher profits and stronger cash flow, Walton's board recommended a 180 percent cash dividend and a 10 percent stock dividend for the financial year ended June 30, 2026

Walton said the increase in EPS was mainly driven by a sharp reduction in bank interest expenses, or finance costs. Finance costs fell by Tk 267.26 crore, or around 60 percent, during the year.

The company's loan burden also declined as its cash flow improved and it repaid high-cost debts, said Md Rafiqul Islam, company secretary of Walton.

"This helped reduce finance costs," he said.

The improvement in operating cash flow was mainly supported by higher collections from customers and lower payments to suppliers. Customer collections increased by Tk 694.36 crore, or 8.84 percent, in FY26, while payments to suppliers fell by 2.31 percent.

Sales also grew 4.5 percent to Tk 7,404 crore during the year.

With higher profits and stronger cash flow, Walton's board recommended a 180 percent cash dividend and a 10 percent stock dividend for the financial year ended June 30, 2026.

The board proposed the stock dividend to help finance the company's ongoing green energy capacity expansion under its balancing, modernisation, rehabilitation and expansion (BMRE) programme.

Walton said the stock dividend would help ensure an uninterrupted power supply while supporting its capacity expansion. The shares will be issued entirely from retained earnings.

The company will hold its annual general meeting on October 15 around noon through a digital platform. The record date has been set for September 20.

Meanwhile, Walton's net operating cash flow per share (NOCFPS) rose nearly 20.4 percent to Tk 63.72 from Tk 52.91 a year earlier.

Following the dividend announcement, the company's share price rose 1.5 percent to Tk 399 yesterday.

For the previous financial year, Walton paid a 175 percent cash dividend and a 10 percent stock dividend to its shareholders.

MIDAS Financing to sell three commercial properties

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

MIDAS Financing, a non-bank financial institution (NBFI), plans to sell three commercial properties at prevailing market prices, subject to approval from shareholders and regulators.

According to a disclosure to the Dhaka Stock Exchange (DSE) yesterday, the decision was taken at a board meeting on August 27. The properties include commercial floor space on the second floor, along with eight car parking spaces, at Nahar Green Summit in Dhanmondi.

Another property comprises commercial floor space on the first floor, along with one car parking space, at Excel SM Tower in East Nasirabad, Chattogram.

The third property comprises commercial floor space on the third floor, along with one car parking space, at Jamil Shopping Center in Bogura.

The asset sale comes as the company faces a liquidity crunch amid a rise in classified and non-performing loans, said Tanvir Hasan, company secretary of MIDAS Financing PLC.

"Some of our good borrowers also failed to repay their loans," he said.

There has also been some demand from depositors to withdraw their deposits, he said, adding that the company has a large fixed-asset base and the board wants to revive its financial position by selling some of its assets. Shares of MIDAS Financing rose 1.79 percent to Tk 5.70 on the DSE yesterday.

The NBFI reported a loss of Tk 89.30 crore in the first six months of 2026, sharply higher than the Tk 46.88 crore loss recorded in the same period a year earlier, according to its financial statements.

The job market speaks. Are we listening?

APURBO KRISHNA SAHA, BUSHRA CHOWDHURY *and* ATONU RABBANI

Imagine losing your job in the spring of 2020, then spending the better part of a year watching more people crowd into the same shrinking pool of openings. We can now see it almost week by week, not because a government survey told us, but because a job site did.

In our research, supported by a grant from the International Growth Centre (IGC), we mined a decade of data from Bangladesh's largest online job portal, BDJobs.com, covering mid-2015 to the end of 2025. We used it to build a weekly readout of how the job market felt to people living through it. When Bangladesh's Covid-19 lockdown began in March 2020, job postings on the platform collapsed by 70 percent and advertised vacancies fell by 75 percent. Applications fell by only 59 percent. People kept searching as opportunities vanished. The result was a more competitive labour market: 287 people were chasing every open position, up from a pre-pandemic norm of 173.

That squeeze did not ease quickly. Our modelling shows market "tightness", the number of applicants per vacancy, was still nearly 30 percent above normal three months after the lockdown began. Bangladesh's quarterly Labour Force Survey, with its publication lags, was not built to capture that in real time. For context, comparable data from the US and the UK showed similarly sharp initial falls in vacancies, but faster rebounds, likely because furlough schemes and unemployment insurance cushioned workers in ways that are far less available in Bangladesh's largely informal economy. Our data, in other words, reveals not just the labour market shock but the gap in the country's social safety net.


Apurbo Krishna Saha


Bushra Chowdhury


Atonu Rabbani

Compare that with the mass uprising of July 2024. Our data shows an initial dip, followed by sharp spikes. Postings briefly jumped more than 200 percent above baseline, then returned towards normal. Vacancies and postings recovered within about six months, while market tightness normalised in roughly four. It was volatile but short-lived, rather than the long squeeze of the pandemic. They left different fingerprints, and only high-frequency data lets us see the shape of each one. A quarterly survey would have blurred both events into a single noisy data point. Just as interesting is what our dataset failed to detect. The Bangladesh Bank raised and cut its policy interest rate 17 times over the decade, including an aggressive tightening cycle from 2022. Basic economic theory says higher borrowing costs should cool hiring. In our data, however, that signal all but vanishes. At most, a rate rise shaves off a few hundred postings for about a week before fading into statistical noise. Job postings actually grew fastest during the period of the most aggressive rate rises, overwhelmed by the stronger trend of firms moving hiring online.

Taken together, our findings offer a lesson for policymakers. Real-time digital data is good at sounding the alarm on sudden shocks, such as a pandemic, uprising or natural disaster, but nearly useless for tracking the slow burn of monetary policy. It is a smoke detector, not a thermostat. Bangladesh, and countries like it, should build lightweight public early-warning dashboards using platforms like this one, refreshed weekly and sitting alongside, never replacing, slower and more representative official surveys. Such a dashboard would not have prevented the Covid shock, but it could have told policymakers within a week how bad it was and how unevenly it was affecting jobseekers.

Of course, this window is not the whole house. Online postings capture the formal, urban and internet-connected slice of the economy, leaving out roughly 85 percent of Bangladeshi workers who work informally. What happens on this job site is a signal, not a census. But it is a signal we have never had before, updated in real time, at essentially no cost beyond the will to look at it. The next crisis is a strange time to be flying blind when the data has been sitting there all along.

The writers are researchers at Bangladesh Institute of Development Studies (BIDS)

BB sets up Tk 2,000cr fund to shore up frozen food exports

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

Bangladesh Bank (BB) has formed a Tk 2,000 crore revolving pre-financing fund to support the frozen food industry, particularly shrimp and fish exporters, and help businesses cater to international markets.

The fund will provide financing at a maximum interest rate of 7 percent, while participating banks will receive funds from the central bank at 4 percent interest.

The initiative comes as exports of frozen and live fish rose marginally in fiscal year 2025-26, while exports of shrimp, the main export item, fell nearly 4 percent year-on-year to $286 million.

The low-cost financing is aimed at easing key financial constraints facing the export-oriented frozen food sector, including long cash-conversion cycles, high inventory costs, expensive cold-chain operations and limited access to affordable financing, according to a Bangladesh Bank circular issued yesterday.

The three-year fund will operate on a revolving basis. All scheduled banks operating in Bangladesh will be eligible to participate, subject to signing an agreement with Bangladesh Bank's Agricultural Credit Department-2.

The facility will support the production, collection, processing and export of frozen shrimp, fish and other frozen food products. Financing can also be used to purchase raw materials, expand or modernise factories, buy machinery and set up cold-storage facilities.


PHOTO: **STAR/FILE**

Exports of frozen and live fish rose marginally in fiscal year 2025-26, while exports of shrimp, the main export item, fell nearly 4 percent year-on-year to $286 million.

It will also cover the reopening of closed or partially operational fish and food-processing factories, solar power projects and environmental remediation, including soil reclamation.

For new factories, banks can provide term loans for up to seven years, including a maximum one-year grace period. For the renovation, expansion and modernisation of existing facilities, the maximum loan tenure will be five years, also including a one-year grace period.

Working-capital loans can be provided for one year and renewed once, with a borrower eligible for the facility for a maximum of two years.

Under the scheme, new frozen-food factories will be eligible for term loans of up to Tk 30 crore, while existing processors can receive up to Tk 20 crore for renovation, expansion and modernisation.

Businesses can also obtain up to Tk 5 crore, or 30 percent of the main project loan, whichever is lower, for installing solar panels.

Working-capital loans for raw materials, production, wages and utility bills will be determined based on annual turnover, subject to a maximum of Tk 20 crore.

Banks have been instructed to prioritise frozen-food exporters whose factories are fully or partly closed because of working-capital shortages.

However, firms already receiving financing under other Bangladesh Bank or government schemes for the same purpose will not qualify. Classified loan defaulters will also be excluded.

Bangladesh Bank will provide pre-financing to participating banks, but lenders will bear the full credit risk and remain responsible for loan recovery. Banks that fail to repay the pre-financed amount on time will face an additional 2 percent interest for the delayed period.

Banks must monitor loan utilisation and inspect borrowers' factories or offices every quarter.

Beneficiaries must also take steps to meet at least 15 percent of their electricity needs from solar power within two years. Non-compliance may result in the suspension of further financing.

The scheme aims to diversify exports, boost foreign exchange earnings, create jobs and expand rural economic activity.

Nepal flood damage may cost up to a tenth of economy to rebuild

REUTERS

Nepal may need $4 billion to $5 billion to rebuild after this week's devastating floods, Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle told Reuters on Saturday, a bill equal to nearly a tenth of the economy.

"The initial estimate is between $4-$5 billion. Just an estimate," Wagle said. "We will require much less than what we needed for the 2015 earthquake. Loss and damage is being assessed."

A glacier collapse on Wednesday unleashed a huge torrent of rock, ice, mud and debris through Himalayan mountain river systems, killing more than 600 people in Nepal and China's Tibet, with more than 2,000 still unaccounted for.

The flood levelled towns in the border area, sweeping away bridges and roads and damaging major hydropower stations.

Wagle did not elaborate on why the reconstruction bill was expected to be less than the $9 billion spent after the 2015 magnitude-7.8 quake, Nepal's worst recorded disaster.

It killed nearly 9,000 people, destroyed more than half a million homes and caused losses estimated at around a third of Nepal's economy.

Wednesday's floods will nevertheless be a major blow to an economy reliant on remittances, tourism and hydropower, damaging power projects that account for more than 12 percent of national generating capacity.

US-Iran war spurs Europe, Asia to boost renewables

REUTERS, *Brussels/London/Singapore*

Six months into the US-Israeli war with Iran, governments across Europe and Asia are scrambling to accelerate a renewables build-out in a bid to cut dependence on fossil fuel imports, providing a fresh impetus to the global energy transition.

As the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz has choked off a fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) shipments, governments from South Korea and Thailand to the European Union have pledged to increase funding for renewables.

Has the conflict delivered a boon to the clean energy transition? Here are some ways to measure the impact.

RENEWABLES ARE SURGING, BUT COAL IS ALSO UP

Renewable power output is soaring across the world, and the International Energy Agency (IEA) expects it to become the top electricity source for the first time this year.

Since the war began, rooftop solar has proved attractive because it is quick and cheap to install.

In the Philippines, high power prices driven by costlier imported fuel are pushing households and businesses onto solar, while a battery subsidy scheme is fuelling a rooftop resurgence in Australia.

European demand for rooftop systems has also jumped since the war began.

But coal is rising too.

With the Strait of Hormuz closed and renewables still unable to guarantee round-the-clock power, coal-fired generation is set to grow — though the IEA's forecast 8.5 percent jump in renewable output this year dwarfs the 1.4 percent rise in coal.

In the United States, where President Donald Trump has opposed green energy, renewable generation rose 10 percent in the first half of the year from the same period in 2025.


An aerial view shows residential buildings with roof-mounted photovoltaic solar panels in Yinchuan, in northwestern China's Ningxia region. PHOTO: **AFP/FILE**

EMISSIONS ARE STILL CLIMBING

Even as renewable generation surges, the IEA expects emissions of the greenhouse gases that cause climate change to rise 1.1 percent this year to an all-time high of 14.2 billion tonnes.

In 2027, the IEA expects coal output to dip by 0.7 percent, but gas-fired power generation to rise 1.5 percent from this year's levels. Curbing climate change will require even more renewable energy and investments in power grids and energy storage.

ASIA BEARS THE BRUNT

Asian economies most dependent on oil and gas through the Strait of Hormuz have absorbed the sharpest shock.

China leaned hard into solar, with output rising more than three times as fast as coal between March and July.

India, Vietnam and South Korea went the other way, burning more coal.

Some European countries also saw extra coal burn, but the IEA expects EU coal generation to resume its decade-long decline in 2026.

Last month, the Vietnamese government said it was considering building more coal plants to secure supply — despite pledging at the 2021 U.N. climate summit to build no new coal after 2030.